

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Nvidia agreed** to buy artificial-intelligence startup Hugging Face in a deal valued at roughly \$13 billion, accelerating Nvidia's push to promote open-weight AI models and services. **A1**
- ◆ **Stocks climbed** and bond yields retreated on the heels of remarks by Fed governor Christopher Waller. The S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow rose 1.1%, 1.4% and 1.2%, respectively. **A2, B1**
- ◆ **Fox News parted** ways with longtime anchor Maria Bartiromo, announcing the separation after the journalist had been absent from the screen for almost a month. **B3**
- ◆ **The Dutch central bank** moved 78 metric tons of gold valued at \$11 billion from vaults in Manhattan to London, saying it would be easier to trade it from there. **B1**
- ◆ **Tesla rolled out** its steering-wheel-free Cybercabs on the roads of Austin, Texas, in the first public test of its ability to transition from traditional electric vehicles to fully autonomous cars. **B4**
- ◆ **Victoria's Secret** again boosted its full-year outlook, pointing to progress in its turnaround plan, even as second-quarter sales growth cooled. **B3**
- ◆ **Campbell's said it** cut more than 1,750 jobs, or roughly 13% of its workforce, as part of a cost-savings program to hasten a turnaround. **B3**
- ◆ **Tyson Foods said** revenue would grow by less than previously expected this year, citing volatile cattle prices amid a yearslong cattle shortage. **B3**
- ◆ **Docusign raised its** sales outlook for the second time this year, citing a boost from AI-related demand. **B3**

Worldwide

- ◆ **The Trump administration** proposed rules that would let the IRS strip tax-exempt status from private schools and colleges if the government determines that they engage in racial preferences or discrimination. **A3**
- ◆ **Bristol Myers Squibb** waited almost three months to publicly disclose that it had paused closely watched drug research because of safety concerns. **A3**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** again asked the Supreme Court to allow it to implement its proposed new rules on mail-in ballots, hoping to get them in place before the midterm elections. **A3**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** charged an immigration officer with lying about the events leading up to the on-duty shooting of a Venezuelan man in Minneapolis. **A3**
- ◆ **Leon Black sued** the House Oversight Committee probing his ties with Jeffrey Epstein and refused to turn over some nondisclosure agreements, arguing the panel and its chair overstepped their authority. **A4**
- ◆ **Vice President JD Vance** defended his friendship with former Fox News host Tucker Carlson, rejecting pressure from some Republicans to distance himself from the conservative iconoclast. **A4**
- ◆ **Ukraine plans** to step up the presence of its drones near Russian airports to compel their closure, while warning international airlines to re-evaluate the safety of flying there. **A7**
- ◆ **Died: Gloria Steinem**, 92, women's-rights activist. **A5**

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Gloria Steinem, Feminist Trailblazer, Dies at 92



STEADFAST: Gloria Steinem, co-founder of Ms. magazine, spent more than six decades as a journalist, editor, activist and organizer, while becoming a symbol of the women's movement. Steinem died Wednesday at her home in Manhattan. **A5**

Economies Across Mideast Face Poor Outlook as War Drags On

By Omar Abdel-Baqi and Summer Said

DUBAI—When war arrived in this playground for the ultrarich in the Middle East this spring, its leaders like others across the Arab Gulf pinned their hopes on a brief conflict, expecting to roar back by the fall and end a disastrous period in their history. Instead, they are writing the year off as a loss, people familiar with their thinking said, as fighting between the U.S. and Iran drags into its

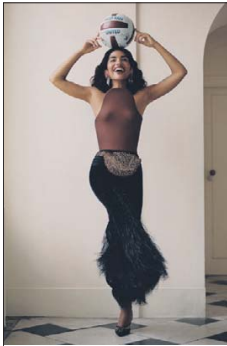
seventh month and a bleak economic picture descends on the region. Marquee events have been disrupted, and luxury hotels are largely empty and slashing staff as war risks keep air travelers away. The Bahrain Grand Prix Formula One race is still happening this October, but thousands of miles away in Malaysia. Saudi Arabia, which has made a multibillion-dollar bet on videogames, moved the E-Sports World Cup to Paris from Riyadh, and Formula One

canceled April's race in the kingdom. The Abu Dhabi Grand Prix is still on the calendar for December, though Formula One said that could change depending on events. A music festival headlined by Shakira this year in the United Arab Emirates has been pulled. Aviation, real estate, tourism, shipping and hotels continue to be hit hard across the region. Companies are dealing not only with a lack of demand but also shipping bottlenecks that have delayed deliveries of everything from heavy machin-

ery to kegs of imported beer. "When this thing ends, it is still going to take six months for things to start to feel normal again," said Rafael Khanoyan, chief executive at U.A.E. contractor Al Ryum Group, who said shipment backlogs and rerouted containers have sharply increased the price of imported goods. Arab Gulf leaders came into the summer expecting the violent phase of the war to wind down in favor of long negotiations over Iran's nuclear pro-

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TOMORROW



WSJ. MAGAZINE OLIVIA DEAN

INSIDE



MANSION The six-figure keys unlocking access to private beaches on Martha's Vineyard. **M1**

Nothing Makes Humans Happier Than Watching Robots Fail

Genre delivers comedy, schadenfreude and a reassuring feeling of superiority

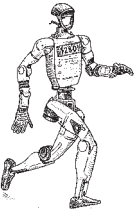
By John Jurgensen

Feeling a little terrified about how quickly technology seems to be sidelining humanity? Try watching a robot sprint straight into a wall. It's hilarious.

In recent videos showing machines on two legs running track in Beijing, some succeeded in breaking Usain Bolt's 100-meter record. And some slammed full tilt into a barrier, collapsing and reeling like drunks. More than one

flopped backward in a cartoonish froth of sparks. The World Humanoid Robot Games was intended to showcase a field evolving in literal leaps, with robots high-jumping, boxing and cheerleading. More important, the exhibition was a source of fresh material for my new favorite genre of entertainment: robots failing spectacularly at basic human feats. It's content that delivers pure physical comedy, a guilt-free schadenfreude and a reassuring

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Klutzn

Chinese Warships Cruise Too Close for Japan's Comfort

Tokyo feels most severe security environment since World War II

By Jason Douglas and Junko Fukutome

SETOUCHI, Japan—The Chinese warships that sail close to the Japanese island of Amami-Oshima make Naruhito Kamada nervous. A stocky former sumo wrestler, the Setouchi mayor worries there might be a collision one day in the narrow channel that connects the East China Sea with the Pacific Ocean. "I feel a sense of crisis," Kamada said in an interview, his office a few hundred yards from the docks where fishing boats and whale-watching expeditions put out to sea. Japanese surveillance has recorded Chinese destroyers passing through the strait near Amami-Oshima at least 10 times this year. That

follows zero such transits in 2025 and is on pace to exceed the 15 recorded in 2024. "It's a provocation for sure," said Takuya Matsuda, an international security scholar at Aoyama Gakuin University in Tokyo. Japan is facing what officials describe as the most severe security environment since World War II. China is flexing its growing military might, pressing maritime claims across eastern Asia and pushing deeper into the Western Pacific, where the U.S. has held sway for years. Deepening alliances among Japan's neighbors—China, North Korea and Russia—have raised questions about the nation's security, as well as the security of vital sea lanes that connect its economy to the U.S. and beyond.

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Dutch Bank Moves \$11 Billion in Gold From NYC, Citing Geopolitical Unrest

By Joe Stonor and Joe Wallace

The Dutch central bank shifted the location of 78 metric tons of gold, valued a \$11 billion at today's prices, from vaults beneath the streets of Manhattan to London, saying it would improve the ability to trade the metal in a pinch. The high-security operation took several months to pull off. Some of the gold was sold in the U.S. and repurchased in the U.K. Other bars were flown to Europe, likely in the storage hold of planes. The result: Almost a third of the Dutch gold reserve is in London and a still chunky 19% in New York, flipping their earlier positions. "In view of increasing geo-

political unrest, DNB is strengthening its crisis preparedness," the central bank said in a statement referring to its Dutch acronym. The central bank also moved some gold from vaults in Canada. "We expect that we will never need to use them, but we do need to strengthen our resilience and preparedness," said DNB President Olaf Sleijpen. The bank didn't specify what it meant by geopolitical unrest. The move follows 18 months in which relations between the U.S. and Europe have frayed over tariffs, President Trump's threats to seize Greenland and his equivocation over the U.S.'s military backing. Gold's place as the backbone of global finance ended with the demise of the Bretton Woods monetary system in

the 1970s. But central banks kept hold of some gold as part of reserves they could sell to defend their currencies if they came under strain. After a long decline, central banks started adding to their gold holdings again around the time of the 2008 financial crisis, according to a 2023 paper by the International Monetary Fund. Since then, proliferating sanctions have encouraged many central banks—notably Russia's—to stock up on gold in case the U.S. cut them off from its banking system. Many central banks, including the Dutch, spread their gold eggs in different baskets around the world to keep them safe. New York and Lon-

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Nvidia Sets \$13 Billion Agreement To Acquire AI Startup

Hugging Face purchase ramps up efforts to push open-weight AI models

By Gareth Vipers

Nvidia has agreed to buy New York-based AI startup Hugging Face in a deal worth about \$13 billion, the latest acquisition by the chip giant at the center of the artificial-intelligence boom. The deal accelerates Nvidia's push to promote open-weight AI models and services that challenge both proprietary models from big U.S. AI companies and open models developed in China. Unlike proprietary models developed by companies such as OpenAI and Anthropic, open-weight models are public, enabling users to download, customize and run them on their own or third-party hardware. Founded a decade ago, Hugging Face has grown into a leading platform for accessing open-weight AI. Engineers use it to collaborate on machine-learning projects, from model development to applications. It was the target of a recent unexpected hack by a new OpenAI model that went rogue. Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang said Hugging Face would remain an open platform. "Open weights broaden access to AI and help ensure that AI leadership is distributed across companies, institutions and communities," he said in a statement Thursday. "Open models let startups, businesses, universities and public institutions build on advanced capabilities without training every model from scratch," the statement said. Hugging Face approached

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U.S. NEWS



CAPITAL ACCOUNT | By Greg Ip

Canada Is Loath to Be Next Venezuela

A few months after capturing Venezuela's leader, President Trump mused about making it the 51st state.

Venezuela didn't end up an American state. It is more of a vassal, or protectorate, or a colony. Call it what you will, it isn't sovereign. Its interim president, Delcy Rodríguez, was installed by the Americans and serves at their pleasure. American troops come and go at will. Its oil revenue flows through the U.S. Treasury. And last week, Trump boasted that the U.S. had taken control of a sizable chunk of its oil reserves at zero cost.

Venezuela is the most extreme manifestation of Trump's "Donroe" doctrine. Under that reformulation of the 1823 Monroe Doctrine, the U.S. seeks dominance of the Western Hemisphere.

Trump has intervened in Argentina's markets to help an ally while meddling in the elections of Brazil and Colombia in hopes of defeating adversaries. In Venezuela, Trump has prioritized control of oil over the restoration of democracy.

Trump's treatment of Venezuela helps explain why Canada broke off trade talks with the U.S. Yet, American officials seem puzzled that Prime Minister Mark Carney would risk trade war given the disproportionate cost Canada is likely to bear. "He's not doing what's best for the Canadian people," Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent declared Monday.

For Carney, it isn't about economic cost, but sovereignty. "No Canadian leader wants to be the Delcy Rodríguez of the North," Chrystia Freeland, Canada's former deputy prime minister, told CNBC last week.

Since World War II, the U.S. pursued trade liberalization as a goal in and of itself, a way to generate mutual benefit and strengthen ties with allies. In that spirit, Canada in the 1980s took what it called a "leap of faith" and negotiated a free-trade deal with the U.S.

President Ronald Reagan described the resulting pact as a "model for the future of this country and the world." A few years later, Mexico joined. The North American Free Trade Agreement was followed by numerous new bilateral pacts slashing trade barriers.

When Trump came to office in 2017, he set out to reverse the free-trade tide. His trade representative, Robert Lighthizer, was anti-free trade and pro-tariff. But he also knew his counterparts had to be able to sell a deal politically back home. The resulting U.S.-Mexico-Canada Agreement, which replaced Nafta, and deals with Japan and



Prime Minister Mark Carney and President Trump in October.

South Korea favored the U.S., but were nonetheless embraced by its partners.

In his second term Trump's approach was completely different. Not only did he hit almost everyone with steep tariffs, he regularly linked the levies to political or territorial goals. He threatened Colombia with tariffs for refusing to take deportees, Brazil for prosecuting his ally, former President Jair Bolsonaro, and Europe to make Denmark hand over Greenland. He said Canada could avoid tariffs by becoming the 51st state.

The U.S., of course, has a long history of interfering in Latin America. Still, Venezuelan-born Harvard economist Ricardo Hausmann says this was often to establish free market institutions and keep

autos and trucks were intended to wipe out its industry, which Trump did little to dispel. "I don't want Canadian cars, I don't want Canadian parts, I don't want Canadian anything," Trump said on social media.

Like imperial Britain and modern China, Trump sees its neighbors as a source of raw materials and a market for manufactured products. This shapes his negotiations. While insisting on steep tariffs on Canadian-manufactured goods, Trump has kept tariffs low on Canadian oil, and indeed pressed for greater access. Though the U.S. is the world's largest oil producer, Trump wanted to revive the Keystone XL pipeline from Canadian oil fields to American refineries.

Most problematic was what Canadian officials interpreted as demands for a veto over trade deals with other countries. U.S. Trade Representative Jamieens Greer disputed that, saying the U.S. wanted to ensure cheap aluminum and steel, such as from China, didn't enter the U.S. from Canada.

Canada in the past had suggested a common approach toward China: "Fortress North America," as Carney sometimes puts it. But the U.S. envisioned "a 'Fortress North America' where one ruler would have dictated what other inhabitants of the

fortress could have done with the outside world, while feeling free to impose restrictions at will on them within the fortress," former Canadian trade negotiator Steve Verheul wrote in a commentary.

It's an open question whether Canadian defiance will outlast a brutal trade war. Its leaders may hope they only have to outlast Trump. Tariffs of some sort are likely here to stay; the Donroe doctrine, not so much.

Congress didn't clamor for control of Venezuela.

Meanwhile, large majorities of Americans oppose Trump's tariffs on Canada and his changing the name of Lake Ontario to "Lake America," according to an Ipsos poll.

Big changes in American trade policy require "some sort of societal consensus," said Doug Irwin, a trade historian at Dartmouth College. "Here it's one person, Trump, or maybe two, with [Commerce Secretary] Howard Lutnick, that have anti-Canada animus. It's hard not to see the hope of a reset."

There is precedent. After being hit with the Smoot-Hawley tariff in 1930, Canada elected a protectionist government that promptly retaliated. Seventeen years, a depression and world war later, Canada joined with the U.S. to create the postwar trading system.

Waller Would Back a Rate Hold if Data Support It

By Nick Timiraos

Fed governor Christopher Waller said Thursday he would support holding rates steady at the central bank's meeting in two weeks if August inflation data continue the recent progress seen in June and July, but that he

could favor a rate increase if that progress reverses.

Recent data have shown signs of improvement on inflation, and "if this continues in the data due over the next two weeks, I would be inclined to support holding the target for the federal funds rate at its current setting," Waller said in remarks during a

Reuters virtual event.

Waller pointed to uncertainty, however, over how military conflicts, trade policy, and artificial intelligence would influence the economy. "If inflation comes in hot, I would consider a rate hike," he said. The Fed held rates steady in July, but three officials voted to raise rates.

The remarks marked a slight shift in tone from July, when Waller said the Fed was at "a crossroads" and, sounding less patient, said the central bank would need to consider tightening if evidence materialized of firmer inflation; he described the cases for accelerat-

ing and decelerating inflation as equally plausible. On Thursday, Waller continued to outline a low bar for raising rates, but said the recent data hadn't necessarily cleared it. He pointed to how a short-term measure of underlying inflation had fallen to around 3%, from 4.76% in February.

Carney Says U.S. Wouldn't Assure Tariff Levels

Any trade pact Canada strikes with the U.S. must ensure agreed-upon tariff levels on certain goods wouldn't be subject to change, Prime Minister Mark Carney said.

Those assurances weren't provided in talks last month, Carney said, which then collapsed and triggered new U.S. tariffs on Canadian goods, and proposed retaliatory tariffs from Ottawa set to take effect on Tuesday.

"There needs to be some stability and credibility" in any future trade pact, Carney said in Thunder Bay, Ontario. He said Canada sought assurances that agreed-upon tariffs on steel, aluminum and automobiles wouldn't be subject to change. The U.S. and Canada had tentatively agreed upon sharp reductions on existing tariffs covering specific sectors, The Wall Street Journal reported.

The White House said this week that Canada was offered the most generous trade deal among the U.S.'s trading partners.

—Paul Vieira

U.S. Trade Gap Increased in July

The U.S. trade deficit widened in July, according to data published by the Commerce Department Thursday.

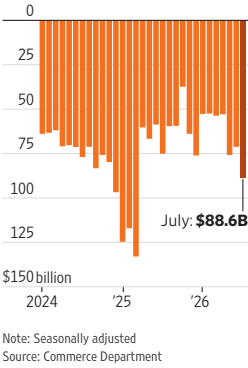
U.S. imports were higher than exports by \$88.6 billion, versus \$71.2 billion in June. Analysts polled by The Wall Street Journal were expecting a \$90 billion deficit.

The gap is the result of imports increasing 2.8% in July from the previous month, to \$399.3 billion, while exports decreased 2.1% to \$310.7 billion.

Imports of goods increased \$11.4 billion in July, while exports of goods decreased \$6.2 billion. Exports of crude oil decreased \$4.5 billion.

—Paulo Trevisani

U.S. trade deficit in goods and services, monthly



Nvidia To Acquire AI Startup

Continued from Page One

Nvidia to discuss a possible deal earlier in the summer, according to Clément Delangue, the startup's chief executive.

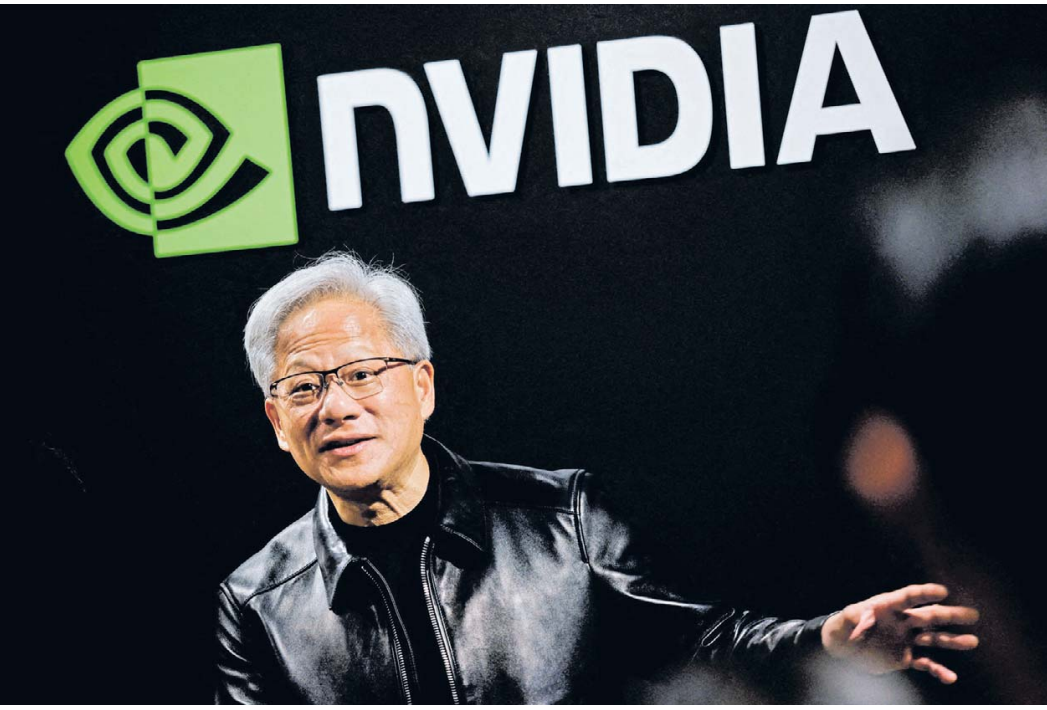
"I think we realized that Hugging Face and open source AI in general was at the turning point, and that it needed more, more resources, more scale, more visibility," Delangue told CNBC on Thursday.

Delangue said he approached Nvidia because it was "a perfect home" for his company.

The company was founded in New York in 2016 by three French entrepreneurs—Julien Chaumond, Thomas Wolf and Delangue—with the aim of building a chatbot for teenagers.

The technology underpinning the original product—particularly tools for natural-language processing—attracted much more interest from developers than the consumer app itself.

A focus of the business became its Hugging Face Hub, which allows developers to upload and download AI models and AI data sets in much the same way software developers use GitHub to share code.



Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang said Hugging Face would remain an open platform.

Nvidia has been at the center of a flurry of recent deal-making activity, using its financial heft to backstop data-center financing and other deals with customers.

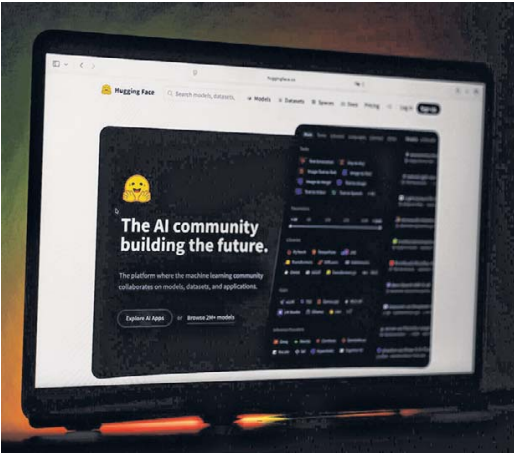
Last month, Nvidia announced plans to join with top Wall Street investment firms to provide partial guarantees for up to \$500 billion in data-center financing and soon af-

ter agreed to backstop a massive Ohio data-center project by OpenAI.

Some industry observers and executives are concerned that a lack of focus on open-source models in the U.S. will prompt businesses and countries to embrace Chinese open-weight models instead. Those models in some cases can rival the performance of U.S. models, while being cheaper to operate.

Some U.S. officials have considered restricting access to Chinese open-weight tools because of security concerns, but Huang, Mark Zuckerberg and other Silicon Valley executives have pushed back on such restrictions.

"Don't regulate hypothetical, theoretical harm. Regulate actual and pragmatic harm,"



Huang told officials from the G-20 countries this week.

Late last month, Nvidia struck a \$6 billion deal with American AI startup Poolside to license its open-weight models and hire the bulk of its engineers, The Wall Street Journal reported.

Nvidia launched the Nemotron Coalition, an association of leading open-model develop-

ers including Mistral, Thinking Machines Lab and Perplexity, earlier this year and said it would share data, expertise and computing resources.

More than 18 million developers, researchers and creators use Hugging Face to share more than 3 million models, 500,000 data sets and 1 million applications, according to Nvidia.

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Tax-Rule Change Targets Colleges Over Race

By RICHARD RUBIN

The Trump administration proposed rules that would let the IRS strip tax-exempt status from private schools and colleges if the government determines that they have racial preferences or discrimination in admissions, scholarships, policies and other programs.

The rules from the Treasury Department and Internal Revenue Service would declare racial discrimination contrary to fundamental public policy in the U.S., continuing the Trump administration's push against affirmative action and diversity, equity and inclusion policies. The move opens a new front in the administration's attempt to reshape higher education.

"Schools rebranding race-based preferences as equitable, inclusive, or diversity-enhancing does not change their discriminatory nature," Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Thursday.

Tax exemptions are valuable to schools, and losing that charitable status could wreck their business models. Typically, private schools, colleges and universities can receive tax-deductible donations from supporters. And they don't generally have to pay corporate taxes on their annual income.

The administration is now seeking public comment, and it could take months or years before the new rules are finalized. About 18,000 institutions could be affected, according to the Treasury Department.

For most schools with fiscal years starting in July, the rules wouldn't formally apply until the 2027-28 school year. To enforce the prohibitions, the IRS would need to conduct an audit and propose the revocation of tax-exempt status. Schools could then challenge those actions in federal court.

However, even the proposed rules could have an immediate economic effect, said Alexander Reid, a partner at law firm BakerHostetler in Washington whose clients include universities. Colleges' bond issuances and private-equity investments hinge on maintaining tax-exempt status, so sudden doubt about whether schools will comply with the law can be problematic.

The Trump administration has pursued many fronts in its efforts to crack down on universities and nonprofits they see as left-leaning. Last year, President Trump threatened to take away Harvard University's tax exemption.

Schools Turn to 'Direct Admissions'

As applicant pipeline dwindles, colleges gain visibility through expedited process

By ROSHAN FERNANDEZ

Hundreds of colleges are sending students letters of admission—without even requiring an application.

Schools are increasingly agreeing to admit students based on a handful of criteria, such as high school transcripts. Known as "direct admissions," this expedited process is free and omits required essays, questions about extra-curriculars and mandated standardized tests.

In turn, the colleges—which are seeking ways to attract more students amid broader financial headwinds—gain exposure to prospects who may never have heard of them otherwise. They then woo the young people into enrolling.

Proponents call the approach a solution for both sides. "Instead of a student applying to the institution, the institution applies to them," said Angel Perez, chief executive of the National Association for College Admission Counseling. "It's a way for students not to have to jump through hoops in order to get into college."

Direct admission has ballooned in popularity, particularly among less-selective private schools vying for a



Jacksonville State University in northeast Alabama added direct admissions last year.

LAMAR SMITH/LAMPY

shrinking pool of college-goers. On the Common App, the number of participating institutions has more than tripled since 2023-24, representing about a fifth of the app's partners, Chief Executive Jenny Rickard said. More than a dozen states now have direct-admissions initiatives.

"We can no longer take a posture that expects our students to come to us," said Karlyn Crowley, president of Kalamazoo College in Michigan, which added direct admissions this year through EAB's Match platform. "We're at a new moment."

Colleges across America are reckoning with the demo-

graphic cliff as the pipeline of 18-year-olds dwindles.

Lesser-known campuses sit at the forefront of these enrollment challenges, though cracks are spreading throughout. And since most colleges admit more than half of applicants—the acceptance rate in the U.S. topped 70% among four-year, not-for-profit schools in a 2023 NACAC report—supporters say direct admissions is a no-brainer.

The process aims to be straightforward: students interested in direct admissions fill out a form—not a full application—on various sites that essentially act as matchmakers. The students, or their

high schools, also submit their transcripts.

From there, the offers roll in automatically. (As with the traditional pathway, though, colleges can yank acceptances if a student's grades tank in their senior year.)

Eden Johnson, a high-school senior, recently got a direct-admission offer to Fort Valley State University in Georgia as part of a summer program she did there. "I thought getting into college would be scarier," she said, "but it just felt exciting."

Johnson, who plans to study biology, still compiled a list of around 20 colleges, and will complete traditional ap-

plications for many.

Though Fort Valley State is a backup option for her, the acceptance helped negate some self-doubt. "It just felt good to be wanted somewhere," she said.

That shift, highlighting acceptances instead of rejections, is an appeal for many young people.

"It's kind of like the dating world," said Jessica Wiggins, vice president of enrollment management at Jacksonville State University, which added direct admissions as part of a statewide initiative launched last year. It is easier to focus on the people who are interested in you, she said.

For that northeast Alabama school, the strategy appears to be helping. Jacksonville State typically drew candidates from nearby counties, but in the latest cycle it also attracted applicants in droves from the southern and western parts of the state.

Not everyone is sold. Critics say direct admission muddies an already-confusing process with countless invitations.

Some schools are unclear about financial commitments accompanying offers.

"There's a big difference between getting in and being able to afford to go," said Beth Kraemer, founder of In College Consulting.

To combat this, Alabama made sure participating institutions deliver price information within initial offer letters.

Drugmakers Quietly Halt Autoimmune Trials

By XAVIER MARTINEZ AND LIZZY LAWRENCE

Bristol Myers Squibb told regulators, researchers and patient-advocacy groups in early June that it had paused closely watched drug research because of life-threatening side effects. It took three months for the company to share that with the broader public.

Novartis paused research into a similar therapy last month, which it confirmed only after a Wall Street analyst noticed while scouring a database. It took a week for the company to reveal that three study patients had died.

Novartis and Bristol Myers are both studying their own new forms of faster-to-produce CAR-T therapy for autoimmune diseases, a promising new area of drug research that re-engineers a person's own cells to attack disabling conditions such as lupus or rheumatoid arthritis.

In Novartis's trial, three people died of a rare complication in which the immune system overreacts. Bristol Myers's zola-cel pause, announced this

week, followed a different complication called ICANS, a form of brain inflammation. Both are known complications of CAR-T therapy, which is already on the market to treat some cancers. "As part of routine safety surveillance," a Bristol Myers spokesperson said in response to an inquiry, "we voluntarily paused enrollment and treatment."

Drugmakers aren't required to tell the public when an experimental treatment turns dangerous. Federal rules require companies to report cases such as these to regulators on a tight clock, but there is no equivalent requirement to alert outside parties such as doctors, prospective patients or investors unless the company thinks the information is material to its bottom line. That gives drugmakers discretion over when to say if they spot problems—even when hundreds of

patients are already enrolled in a study or deciding whether to sign up.

"We're suffering from a lack of shared knowledge," said Sue Chrysogelos, who participated in a CAR-T study for a different drugmaker to treat her scleroderma.

Information about clinical trials can be commercially competitive, so companies guard it closely. When trials are paused without disclosure, though, patients can get stuck waiting without much clarity about the potential risks of participating.

Novartis is studying its therapy rap-cel in eight autoimmune trials, including in multiple sclerosis and rheumatoid arthritis—a broad bet that has enrolled more than 500 patients.

Bristol Myers's safety signal emerged in a trial of zola-cel in patients with a type of lupus,

but the company has halted studies into other autoimmune conditions that cause inflammation and muscle weakness.

It took a Wall Street analyst noticing something odd in a database to surface the halted research.

Sami Corwin, who covers biotech for William Blair, was doing a routine check of clinical trials last week when she saw that a slate of studies testing therapies in autoimmune diseases had gone dark. She started calling around. A colleague noticed that Bristol Myers's trials had frozen, too. By the weekend, her team had confirmed pauses at both companies.

Corwin published a research note that got picked up by a trade publication and shortly thereafter, Endpoints News reported the deaths in Novartis's trial.

Novartis hadn't told Corwin the cases were fatal when she asked about the trial pause, Corwin said. "That was news to me," she said.

The company hasn't answered questions about whether the deaths in Novartis's

3
Number of people who died of a rare complication in Novartis's trial.

White House Files New Appeal on Mail Ballots

By JAMES ROMOSER

WASHINGTON—The Trump administration's bid to deploy the U.S. Postal Service to regulate mail-in ballots is back at the Supreme Court for the second time in as many weeks.

In an emergency appeal on Thursday, the administration asked the high court to allow it to immediately implement proposed rules that would require states to hand over voter data and would give the Postal Service power to reject mail ballots that don't comply with new conditions.

The rules have been blocked by a federal district judge who found they are likely unconstitutional.

Time is running short for the administration to fully implement the rules before the Nov. 3 midterms. North Carolina is scheduled to begin sending mail ballots to voters Friday, and other states will soon follow.

"Once those ballot envelopes enter the mailstream, there is no retrieving them," Solicitor General John Sauer wrote, urging the Supreme Court to quickly lift the district judge's block.

The Supreme Court ordered the groups challenging the Postal Service rules to file a response by Tuesday morning,

effectively guaranteeing that the justices won't resolve the appeal before then.

The appeal is the latest phase in a complex and fast-moving fight stemming from a March 31 executive order that President Trump issued on mail voting. Last week, the Supreme Court ruled that a challenge to the executive order was premature because the Postal Service hadn't yet enacted any of the policies that the executive order directed.

Around the time of that ruling, the Postal Service issued its 95-page regulation, saying it intended to enforce it during the midterms. The regulation mandates that ballot envelopes include individualized bar codes and other design features. It also says that states, as a condition of sending ballots to voters through the mail, must get their ballots approved by the Postal Service and upload information about all voters who will receive mail ballots into a federal database.

The Trump administration says the new rules are critical to protect the integrity of the midterms.

States and voting-rights groups say the proposed postal rules would create mass confusion on the eve of the election and could disenfranchise many eligible voters.

ICE Officer Accused of Lie in Shooting

By SADIE GURMAN AND MARIAH TIMMS

The Justice Department has charged an immigration officer with lying about the events leading up to the on-duty shooting of a Venezuelan man in Minneapolis, people familiar with the matter said.

A grand jury indicted Immigration and Customs Enforcement Officer Christian Castro, 52, on charges of making false statements to investigators during a probe into the January shooting of Julio Sosa-Celis during the Trump administration's immigration crackdown in the Twin Cities. Castro is already charged with assault in state criminal court in connection with the shooting.

The shooting was one of a series of encounters with ICE officers that roiled the Twin Cities during the administration's massive deportation operation known as Operation Metro Surge.

Castro's indictment marks the first time the Justice Department has secured charges against an ICE officer stemming from conduct during the surge. It hasn't brought criminal charges against any of the officers over the shootings themselves, which officials say are still under investigation.

The politically charged case also created a rift with some career prosecutors who



Christian Castro gets into a car last month in Texas.

MICHAEL GONZALEZ/AP

sought to bring a more serious civil-rights case. Justice Department leadership on Thursday also fired a lead prosecutor in the Minnesota U.S. attorney's office on the case, Matthew Evans, who had told attorneys for Sosa-Celis this week that he strongly objected to charging Castro only with making false statements, the people said.

Evans told the lawyers for Sosa-Celis that he wanted to bring civil-rights charges against Castro, but that officials in Washington put brakes on such a case, the people said. The charge Evans sought, deprivation of rights under color of law, has been brought against police officers

accused of excessive force and other misconduct that can carry significant prison time.

The department is now investigating whether Evans broke any laws, the people said. The Justice Department hasn't concluded whether to bring additional charges against Castro, they said, adding the investigation is continuing and such probes take time. ProPublica earlier reported on Evans. Evans couldn't be reached for comment.

Castro surrendered to authorities and was in federal custody Thursday night, one person familiar with the matter said. He couldn't be reached for comment and a lawyer for him

couldn't be identified.

Minneapolis prosecutors in May charged Castro with assault and falsely reporting a crime, alleging that he fired a bullet through the front door of a home that struck Sosa-Celis in the thigh and tore through a wall in a child's bedroom. Prosecutors said Castro had lied about being attacked before the shooting.

Castro was arrested in Texas, where he lives, shortly after the state charges in Minnesota were announced, sparking a standoff between the two states. Minnesota asked a federal judge to order Texas to extradite Castro to face the charges filed there. They argued Texas Gov. Greg Abbott had improperly stalled on releasing Castro while approving other extraditions. U.S. District Judge Fernando Rodriguez Jr. declined to intervene, ruling there was no time limit for extradition decisions.

Castro was released from a Cameron County jail in Texas on Aug. 27.

Minnesota's lawsuit said officials feared he might try to flee, given his ties to nearby Mexico and fluency in Spanish.

The Department of Homeland Security didn't return a request for comment. An attorney for Sosa-Celis also didn't return requests for comment.

U.S. NEWS

Trump Fatigue Is Setting In On Some GOP Candidates

Party sees benefits, risks to president’s midterm support; ‘it smells destructive’

WASHINGTON—Congressional Republican leaders are putting President Trump front and center in their campaign to keep control of the House and Senate, even as some in the party say the strategy could increase the likelihood of a drubbing in the midterms.

By Lindsay Wise, Siobhan Hughes and Maya Davis

“Nobody better to turn out the base than President Trump,” said House Majority Leader Steve Scalise (R., La.). That Trump-centric approach will be on display next week in Dallas as the president stars at an unusual midterm GOP convention.

While many GOP lawmakers are embracing the president, others have started to sound the alarm that Trump’s low approval ratings could sink the party in November. They say resentment is building as Trump focuses more on legacy construction projects and fights with allies than on helping Republicans keep control of Congress.

“Some of the things he’s done, it smells like chaos, it smells destructive,” said Rep. Don Bacon (R., Neb.), who is retiring. He pointed to Trump’s recent executive order renaming Lake Ontario, calling it a “silly” own goal by the president. “Most people think it’s dumb,” he said.

Bacon says he has encouraged Republicans running in competitive races to break with Trump on issues such as tariffs, even if stepping out of line might draw Trump’s wrath. “It’s hard to say, ‘I dis-



President Trump arrived for a barbecue with GOP lawmakers Wednesday at the Rose Garden.

agree and I’m going to vote that way,’ ” Bacon said. “And you’ve got to do it.”

Democrats need to gain just three seats to win back the House and four to retake the Senate, and nonpartisan election analysts have shifted more races in Democrats’ direction over the summer.

For Republicans, “the three most plausible outcomes are that it will be bad, really bad, or truly horrible,” wrote political analyst Charlie Cook, the founder of Cook Political Report.

Rep. Stephanie Bice (R., Okla.) made headlines last week when she was recorded speaking to a group of student Republicans at Oklahoma State University, warning Republican voters could stay home or even vote for Democrats. According to the Bulwark, which obtained the recording, Bice quoted a business executive who told her that he was a longtime Republican but now has “Trump fatigue.”

Bice later said she was relaying the executive’s comments and said the remarks were taken out of context. Fueling the sense of griev-

ance among some Republican lawmakers and strategists is their impatience with Trump’s super PAC, MAGA Inc., which has yet to spend much of its \$400 million war chest on the midterms. “MAGA Inc. is committed to retaining and building the GOP majorities in the House and Senate. We are not in the business of sharing our battle plans with the press,” said the PAC’s spokesperson, Alex Pfeiffer.

Trump, who has said he wants voters to pretend his name is on the ballot, pledged to Republican candidates at a dinner on Wednesday that he would campaign across the country to get them re-elected. “I will be with you 100% all the way until November,” he said.

White House spokeswoman Olivia Wales pointed to Trump’s tax cuts and energy policies and his efforts to lower the costs of prescription drugs and end illegal border crossings.

Retiring Rep. Dan Newhouse (R., Wash.), who voted to impeach Trump in 2021, said the president “certainly has a strong following, but times are tough.” He said voter

exhaustion with Trump is a “legitimate concern” for Republicans. “We need people to turn out,” Newhouse said. “I can see Republicans not being as motivated as Democrats this year.”

Among the more than 100 lawmakers and candidates attending the midterm convention will be Rep. Derrick Van Orden, a Republican running for re-election in a Wisconsin swing district who says he is sticking as close as possible to Trump, even if it costs him his seat. “I’m not backing away,” he said.

Rep. Jeff Van Drew (R., N.J.) said voters in his red-leaning New Jersey district are worked up about gas prices, the cost of living and the Iran War. But he doesn’t think showing distance from Trump is the way to go.

“I’m not that shallow. If you’re my friend and you get in a little bit of trouble, I’m not going to run away from you,” he said. “I think you can at the same time say, ‘Yes, he’s done a lot of good and there’s a lot of things I’m committed to, but there are some things I absolutely disagree with.’ ”

Vance Defends His Carlson Friendship

By NATALIE ANDREWS

WASHINGTON—Vice President JD Vance defended his friendship with former Fox News host Tucker Carlson, rejecting pressure from some Republicans to distance himself from the conservative iconoclast.

“Tucker is a friend, despite the fact that we disagree on a number of things,” Vance told reporters Thursday at the White House. “And I’m not going to play the game where I throw friends under the bus because I have political disagreements with them.”

Carlson didn’t immediately respond to a request for comment.

Carlson, a longtime ally of President Trump, has become one of the president’s sharpest critics, breaking with him over the Iran war and accusing him of abandoning his “America First” campaign platform.

Carlson has alleged that some American politicians place the interests of Israel over those of the U.S. He hosted a Holocaust denier, Nick Fuentes, on his podcast last October, triggering allega-



JD Vance Thursday at the White House briefing.

tions of antisemitism and demands from some prominent Republicans to banish Carlson from the conservative movement.

Some Jewish Republicans, along with other conservatives, have publicly and privately expressed frustration that Vance hasn’t publicly broken with Carlson.

On Thursday, Vance said he disagreed with Carlson on many things, including his criticism of Trump and his recent positive comments about Michigan Democratic Senate candidate Abdul El-Sayed.

“I think El-Sayed’s a crazy person,” Vance said in response to Carlson, who made the case in a recent podcast that El-Sayed was promoting a “Trumpian” American First agenda.

The vice president said he was frustrated when friends of his wife, Usha Vance, publicly turned on her as the couple entered the public eye. “And I remember thinking to myself, ‘What a travesty it is that in the United States of America, we let political disagreements define who our friends are going to be and

not going to be,’ ” Vance said.

It is the second time in a week that Vance has declined to publicly turn his back on Carlson. During an event on Monday evening hosted by the Republican Jewish Coalition, a political-advocacy group, Vance was asked by an interviewer how he decides which platforms to appear on, when some, including Carlson’s, have featured people with antisemitic views.

Vance noted that many people in the room would disagree with Carlson and other podcasters who have been increasingly critical of the Trump administration.

The vice president this summer was also guest on the podcasts of Joe Rogan and Megyn Kelly. Vance said Rogan’s audience consists of the type of people that Republicans need to win over in the midterms.

“I think it’s a mistake to sort of say we’re going to write Joe Rogan off because he said something that we don’t like,” Vance said. “I think the best approach is to actually go in there, and talk to him, and make the argument as best as you can.”

Missouri Top Court Rules Against Map

By JOSEPH PISANI

The Missouri Supreme Court ruled Thursday that the state can’t use redrawn congressional districts that could have benefited Republicans in November’s midterm elections, and voters must decide if they should be used in future elections.

The unanimous decision was a blow to Republicans who were hoping to gain one U.S. House seat with the redrawn map in the midterms. Around the country, both parties have been changing congressional maps hoping to gain an advantage in the House.

Missouri’s new congressional map “did not go into effect and will not go into effect unless and until approved by the voters,” Judge Ginger K. Gooch wrote in Thursday’s opinion. She said that state voters can decide in November if the map can be used in the future.

Until then, a previous map created in 2022 “remains in full force and effect for the November 2026 general election.”

Missouri Gov. Mike Kehoe, a Republican, had pushed lawmakers to redraw the state’s maps last year after pressure from President Trump.

“We are extremely disappointed in today’s decision by unelected judges and their lack of respect for the legislative process,” Kehoe said Thursday, pointing out that the new map was used in the recent primaries. “Holding a primary election under one congressional map and a general election under another is unprecedented and creates uncertainty for Missouri voters.”

Trump also blasted the ruling.

“The Missouri Supreme Court just ridiculously ruled in favor of changing the maps back to what they were a long time ago,” the president said on Truth Social. He said that there won’t be enough time to change the map with the election coming up in a short period.

“Missouri must be able to use the map that was in effect just a couple of months ago, in the Primary,” Trump added.

Defections Pose Test For Jeffries in House

By KEN THOMAS AND MAYA DAVIS

WASHINGTON—The surprise defections of two Democrats on a Republican procedural vote has sparked soul-searching in the party and raised new questions about whether Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries—the possible next House speaker—has the muscle to keep members in line.

House Democrats were stunned when Reps. Jared Golden (D, Maine) and Marie Gluesenkamp Perez (D, Wash.), two centrist members, voted this week to narrowly advance a rules package by a 210-208 tally. That allowed Republicans to then move forward on a series of votes, including a resolution condemning socialism that was designed to embarrass Democrats. Members of the minority party rarely help the majority party pass such rules.

The episode provides an early test of the challenges facing Jeffries and his leadership team in the next Congress if Democrats win back the majority. The votes showed problems could potentially pop in the center of the caucus, alongside anticipated blowups on the left wing, and followed a dust-up over Jeffries’s recent private meeting with Jared Kushner, President Trump’s son-in-law.

Rep. Jim McGovern (D, Mass.), a Jeffries ally and the top Democrat on the House Rules Committee, aired his frustration after the defections. “I’m disappointed and angry about what happened,” McGovern said. “I didn’t get a heads up. I’m the ranking member on the rules committee—I would have appreciated that.”

The incident set off a round of recriminations within the Democratic caucus. Jeffries (D, N.Y.) and top lieutenants Reps. Katherine Clark of Massachusetts and Pete Aguilar of California released a statement saying the decision to join with Republicans “to pass a procedural rule on the brink of fail-



Rep. Hakeem Jeffries

ing represents a significant breach of trust.”

The leaders said it “necessitates a serious response” and asked a Democratic panel to consider the consequences. That panel is discussing potential changes within the caucus, according to people familiar with the talks, including requiring Democratic members to pay their full annual dues to their campaign arm or not side with Republicans on procedural votes to remain in good standing in the party. Democrats took no immediate action against the two lawmakers.

The two defectors defended their votes. Golden, who is retiring, and Gluesenkamp Perez, who represents a tossup district in Washington state, are both from districts that voted for Trump in 2024.

Golden said the Republican rule needed to pass in order for the House to take up his bill designed to protect lobstermen from new regulations, which then was approved in a vote later in the day.

Gluesenkamp Perez, who has been trying to rein in the sea lion population in her district, said in a statement that you “don’t get effective environmentalism without the input of people who make their livelihoods and heritage on the water—whether we’re talking about lobsters or sea lions.”

Black Sues House Oversight Committee Over Its Epstein Probe

By ANNA MARIA ANDRIOTIS AND MAYA DAVIS

Leon Black is suing the House Oversight Committee probing his ties with Jeffrey Epstein and refusing to turn over some nondisclosure agreements, arguing the panel and its chair have overstepped their authority.

Black, the co-founder of Apollo Global Management, had been scheduled to appear Thursday before the Oversight Committee for a second round of questioning. He didn’t appear. Instead, he filed a lawsuit in federal court against the committee and its Republican chair, Rep. James Comer (R., Ky.).

“The Committee is on a fishing expedition that oversteps its authority,” one of

Black’s lawyers, Susan Estrich, said in a statement. “This is no longer about finding the truth about Epstein. It is about trying to destroy Mr. Black.”

In a statement, Comer said: “It’s a shame Leon Black is hiding behind litigation rather than provide answers to the American people.” Comer said he would consult with members about next steps.

“By refusing to testify today, Leon Black is now defying two Congressional subpoenas,” said Rep. Robert Garcia (D., Calif.), the top Democrat on the committee. “We must hold him in contempt immediately.”

The committee has been investigating the government’s handling of the Epstein case and questioning some of the

sex offender’s associates. Black, who was one of Epstein’s biggest financial clients, has said he didn’t know about Epstein’s crimes, never abused a woman and wasn’t blackmailed by Epstein.

In June, Black appeared for questioning by the committee but the session was cut short when he left abruptly. The committee subpoenaed him to return for more questioning and to turn over nondisclosure agreements.

Republicans and Democrats said the subpoenas were the result of Black declining to answer some questions during his June interview, particularly about nondisclosure agreements. “We believe that information is vital to our investigation,” Comer said at the time. Black’s legal team



Leon Black

called the subpoenas a political stunt.

Black’s lawsuit, filed in the U.S. District Court for the District of Columbia, claims the

subpoenas are invalid because they exceed the committee’s “delegated authority in seeking private information that bears no legitimate connection” to the committee’s legislative purpose.

In his lawsuit, Black said the committee overstepped its authority by asking Black about NDAs that weren’t related to Epstein. Black turned over one NDA he reached with a former girlfriend where Epstein played a consulting role, but declined to provide NDAs with other women.

The committee’s request would expose women “who value their privacy, who have no known or public connection to Epstein, who bargained for confidentiality and have refused to release it, and who have no ability to protect

themselves and their privacy before the Committee,” the suit states.

The lawsuit also cites Black being questioned about who in his social circle has NDAs as another example of the committee’s overreach. His lawyer, Estrich, said Black was willing to answer questions about his payments to Epstein but that Black and his legal team understood the committee planned to ask Black questions beyond his ties with Epstein.

Black stepped down as Apollo’s chief executive in 2021 after an outside law firm hired by Apollo found that he paid Epstein \$158 million for his tax-planning and estate services. The review by law firm Dechert found no evidence that Black was involved in Epstein’s criminal activities.

U.S. NEWS

The Icon Who Inspired Women’s Movement

Feminist leader was ever-present; ‘I’m using my torch to light other torches’

By JON MOOALLEM

On Jan. 21, 2017, one day into Donald Trump’s tenure as president of the U.S., and roughly five decades into Gloria Steinem’s tenure as its most famous feminist, Steinem arrived on the National Mall to address the Women’s March on Washington—a mass gathering in rebuke of both a president who had bragged about groping women, and the society that had elected him anyway.

At age 82, Steinem looked as she had always looked, only older: tinted aviator glasses, leather jacket, long hair parted down the middle with two lightened streaks at the front. And she sounded like she had always sounded: resolute but cool-headed and—even amid great trepidation—adamantly joyful, too.

“You look great! I wish you could see yourselves—it’s like an ocean!” she hollered at the roughly half a million bodies in front of her. “This is the upside of the downside. This is an outpouring of energy and true democracy like I have never seen in my very long life.”

Steinem—who died Wednesday at home at the age of 92, according to a post on her Instagram account—was, by then, a living symbol of the women’s movement, having spent her life working, as a journalist, editor, activist and organizer, to brazenly propel women forward and cannily scrutinize the forces holding them back. She was arguably the most effective avatar of a movement that was meant to represent half the population of Earth—and, aware of the peculiarity and pressures of that position, held fast to a conviction that all people were equal and interdependent, and that change comes only from collective action. “We are linked. We aren’t ranked,” she told the Women’s March, deploying a favorite line.

When people asked her who she was passing the torch to, she bristled: “There is no one torch—there are many torches,” she told the New Yorker in 2015, “and I’m using my torch to light other torches.”

Named after a doll

Steinem was born March 25, 1934, in Toledo, Ohio, and named after her older sister’s favorite doll. Her father was a traveling antiques dealer, but also operated a lakeside summer resort in Michigan, where, at a young age, Steinem was enamored of the musicians who passed through to play. She settled on her own plan to escape a conventional, 9-to-5 life: She would be a Rockette.

Her parents separated when she was 10. Steinem lived in Toledo with her mother, Ruth, a former newspaper reporter who had quit to raise her children, suffered a mental breakdown and became addicted to the sodium pentathol she took to tamp down her malaise. Steinem described her mother as disappearing down the street in her nightgown, or marooned in bed “with eyes closed and lips moving in occasional response to voices only she could hear.” Steinem would bring her coffee and bologna sandwiches—a desperate child’s conception of a nourishing meal. She of-



Gloria Steinem, above, at her New York apartment in 1970. At left, at the Women’s March on Washington in 2017.



ten said, of her own generation of women: “Most of us are living out the unlivd lives of our mothers.”

Upon graduating from Smith College in 1956, Steinem received a fellowship to travel and write in India, where, over two years, she learned of the critical role women had played in the Indian independence movement. Before leaving the U.S., Steinem had written a note to her college boyfriend, breaking off their engagement.

In 1960, she arrived in New York wanting to be a journalist but initially only landed odd jobs from the classifieds—dancing at grocery-store openings, standing against a cork board while a magician threw knives—and the sort of freelance pieces editors entrusted to women. (Steinem would later describe “the low point in my life” as “writing about textured stockings” for the New York Times.) She broke through in 1963, with a piece for Show magazine about working undercover as a scantily uniformed “bunny” at the Playboy Club. It was a biting expose about the club’s working conditions and culture of sexual degradation, but Steinem was irritated that many couldn’t get past the salaciousness of its premise.

In 1968, editor Clay Felker hired her as part of New York magazine’s inaugural stable of writers, which also included Jimmy Breslin and Tom Wolfe. There Steinem wrote one of the first mainstream media dispatches from the women’s movement, covering a 1969 abortion speak-out in Greenwich Village, where woman after woman shared stories of terminating pregnancies.

Steinem had an abortion at age 22, in London en route to India, but had never talked about it. At the speak-out, she was rattled by her own silence and the invisibility of these stories in the culture at large. “I began to read every piece of

feminist writing I could lay my hands on, and talk to every active feminist I could find,” she recalled in one of her books, “Outrageous Acts and Everyday Rebellions.”

As Steinem dove headlong into covering the movement, women’s groups invited her to speak. Petrified, she recruited two charismatic friends as alternating sidekicks: daycare owner and activist Dorothy Pittman Hughes, and civil rights attorney Florynce Kennedy. Both were Black, expanding the audience for their talks.

The founding of Ms.

In 1971, Steinem co-founded Ms. magazine, run exclusively by women, for women, and born from conversations with other women writers who had grown exhausted with the belittling conventions and blind spots of male-dominated media. The idea was radical. So was the name. When answering the phone, the staff found they had to refer to the magazine as “M-S magazine” because the appellation was still so unfamiliar in the culture that few recognized the sound of the word.

Ms. would become known for spirited, frank coverage of subjects that were typically only spoken about quietly: workplace and domestic inequalities, domestic violence, homosexuality, racism, date rape. That fearlessness was apparent in the inaugural issue, which included, the year before Roe v. Wade, a statement titled “We Have Had Abortions” signed by 53 famous women, including Steinem, Judy Collins, Anaïs Nin and Billie Jean King.

It was an era in which women weren’t always permitted to open a bank account or get a credit card without their husband’s permission; when a husband was lawfully allowed to rape his wife. Many presumed Ms. would be too revolutionary, explicit or mili-

tant for mainstream women of the time, or be mistaken for a lesbian journal. Instead, it sold out all 300,000 copies of its first stand-alone issue, in July 1972, in just eight days.

Some conservatives reviled the magazine, and some feminists criticized it as not bold enough. But under Steinem’s editorship, which lasted until the sale of the magazine in 1987, it became a beacon for many contemporary women.

She spent several years lobbying to push an Equal Rights Amendment through Congress, and then—unsuccessfully—to have it ratified by the states. In 1971, she and other leading feminists, including Shirley Chisholm, Bella Abzug and Dorothy Height, founded the National Women’s Political Caucus, to get more women elected to office and involved in public

life—one of several equality organizations Steinem would launch. She also initiated “Take Our Daughters to Work Day” in 1992.

Steinem spoke about pushing the women’s movement beyond its initial concerns—essentially, the benumbed, unfulfilled flourishing of white middle-class housewives like her own mother. A core conviction, she wrote in “Outrageous Acts,” was “that sex and race discrimination are so pragmatically linked and anthropologically interdependent that one cannot be successfully uprooted without taking on the other.”

She was especially inspired by the 1977 National Women’s Conference in Houston. The four-day conference, which Steinem had a prominent role in organizing, brought together 2,000 elected delegates

and 32,000 observers—women from every state as well as representatives from indigenous groups.

Humor and allure

Steinem usually attributed her effectiveness as a spokesperson to her sense of humor, but understood that her beguiling good looks also played a role. The allure of her physicality and personality seemed intertwined: She was often shown laughing or making others laugh, dressed stylishly, and was known to tap-dance spontaneously in elevators.

The writer Susan Faludi, speaking to the Los Angeles Times in 1992, noted that Steinem’s attractiveness and wit were a powerful reproach to “those who would dismiss feminism as a gathering of sour-faced, bonneted suffragettes.”

Steinem had many well-known romantic partners in her life, including Franklin Thomas, the head of the Ford Foundation; film director Mike Nichols; Stan Pottinger, an assistant attorney general in the Justice Department’s civil rights division; and Olympic decathlete Rafer Johnson. In the late 1980s, she also dated New York real-estate magnate Mort Zuckerman.

Steinem married for the first and only time at age 66, in 2000, to David Bale, a businessman and environmentalist (and father of actor Christian Bale). Three years later, Bale died of brain lymphoma.

She remained active and peripatetic through her 80s and retained the sensibility of a journalist on the road, eager to listen to strangers’ stories, but was constantly called on to dispense wisdom as well.

When a young audience member asked Steinem at a 2019 event in San Francisco what she would tell a budding feminist like her who wanted to get involved, Steinem answered: “I would say that I’m not here to tell you what to do. I am here to support you in doing anything you f—ing well please.”

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Steinem at the offices of Ms. Magazine in the early 1970s.

U.S. NEWS

‘Standing’ Gives Court Off-Ramp in Tough Cases

By Lydia Wheeler
and Louise Radnofsky

WASHINGTON—When it comes to some of President Trump’s most audacious actions, the toughest question for legal challengers isn’t whether they have winning arguments. It is whether they can sue at all.

The Supreme Court’s 5-4 ruling this week allowing construction to continue on Trump’s White House ballroom provided a textbook example of why it can be difficult to find plaintiffs who can claim they have suffered real, identifiable legal injuries from Trump’s boundary-pushing agenda.

The court’s majority said nothing about whether Trump had any legal basis for remaking the White House complex without congressional approval. Instead, it said the lawsuit was improper because a preservation group couldn’t credibly allege it was facing the kind of real and specific harms that gave it legal standing to proceed in court.

A member of the group who has given walking tours and writes scholarly articles on Washington’s historic architecture hadn’t suffered an actual legal injury by a ballroom going up where the White House East Wing once stood, the court said. “Mere offense, disagreement, or distaste does not qualify as a concrete and particularized injury,” the majority said.

It isn’t clear whether the lawyers challenging the ballroom can find other plaintiffs who would meet the court’s test for standing. And even if they did, the construction is already more than half completed.

The concept of standing often hangs over high-stakes lawsuits, but that has been especially true in cases involving some of the Trump administration’s most controversial actions.

After the Justice Department announced a \$1.8 billion “Anti-Weaponization Fund” to compensate Trump allies who claimed they were targeted unfairly by the government,

Work on Trump’s Arch to Start Soon

Excavation work on President Trump’s 250-foot-tall arch in Washington, is expected to start over the next two weeks, the administration said Thursday.

The project, one of Trump’s many so-called beautification projects in the nation’s capital, is facing litigation. Opponents have argued Trump needs congressional approval to build it. The triumphal arch would block or disrupt the sightline of other monuments, critics have said.

The arch would sit be-

tween the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery at Memorial Circle on Columbia Island.

“This will be one of the Great Pieces of American Architecture,” Interior Secretary Doug Burgum said Thursday on social media.

Trump’s other projects include building a White House ballroom, resurfacing the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool and trying to add his name to the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts. All have faced legal challenges.

—Joseph Pisani

was likely good enough to proceed, but the issue hasn’t been settled and the Justice Department has abandoned the fund under political pressure.

A separate but related provision that ended pending IRS audits of Trump, his family and his businesses remains in effect; court watchers say it isn’t clear that anyone has standing to challenge it.

In a Supreme Court immigration case last year, Justice Brett Kavanaugh said Latinos challenging Trump administration enforcement raids in Los Angeles likely lacked standing to sue because they had no firm basis for knowing that they would be stopped for immigration questioning based on their race, accent or occupation.

In some cases, lawyers have struggled to find anyone willing or able to challenge Trump. No serious lawsuit materialized when his administration accepted a \$400 million luxury jet from the Qatari government or rebranded the Department of Defense as the

Department of War.

Courts have long sent mixed messages on what type of alleged harm is enough to proceed with a lawsuit. Dissenting in the ballroom litigation, Chief Justice John Roberts noted that the high court has previously blessed the idea that environmental litigants are injured from the extinction of an animal species they would like to observe in the wild. A preservationist, he said, ought to be able to claim a similar legal interest “in physically viewing, appreciating, and studying a historic building as it is.”

Some scholars say the Supreme Court’s entire doctrine of legal standing is squishy and can turn on whether the court is eager to rule on the merits of a dispute or instead is looking for an off-ramp to avoid deciding difficult legal questions. “The court finds standing when it wants to find standing,” said Alan Morrison, who teaches civil procedure and constitutional law at George Washington University.

U.S. WATCH



SOLEMN TASK: Jim Maroon removes debris from one of the 9/11 Memorial reflecting pools in New York City. This Sept. 11 will mark 25 years since the deadly terrorist attack.

WASHINGTON, D.C.
Telle Named Acting Army Secretary

President Trump named Adam Telle as acting Army secretary, succeeding Dan Driscoll, who resigned after months of tension with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

Trump said Telle, assistant secretary of the Army for civil works, would start in his new job immediately.

Telle served as chief of staff to Sen. Bill Hagerty (R., Tenn.) and as Trump’s chief liaison to the Senate.

Driscoll had clashed with Hegseth over the direction of the service and the ouster of numerous senior Army officers, The Wall Street Journal previously reported.

With Driscoll’s departure, the Army lacks top Senate-confirmed civilian or military leaders.

—Joseph Pisani

U.S. FOREST SERVICE
Over 20 Research Stations Will Close

The U.S. Forest Service is closing 23 research stations in more than a dozen states as part of an organizational overhaul under President Trump that is intended to trim costs and concentrate the agency’s resources in Western states, officials said Thursday.

Work being done at the research stations will continue at other sites, Forest Service Associate Chief Chris French said. An additional 41 research facilities that faced possible closure will remain open after local officials and members of Congress raised concerns about the reorganization, which was announced in March.

The reorganization also includes moving the agency’s headquarters from Washington to Salt Lake City.

—Associated Press

MISSOURI
Candidate Charged In Drug Conspiracy

A candidate for the Missouri House made an initial court appearance Thursday on a federal drug charge accusing him of trying to plant cocaine and Adderall on his Republican primary opponent.

Thomas Ross, 37, is charged with conspiracy to distribute a controlled substance. He is accused of asking a campaign manager to plant a small amount of cocaine and a prescription amphetamine pill on his opponent, Louise Secker, in the weeks leading up to the Aug. 4 primary, according to court documents. Ross, of Joplin, defeated Secker by a few dozen votes.

Ross didn’t respond to a Thursday message seeking comment about the charge.

—Associated Press

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WORLD NEWS

Russia’s Commercial Airspace Targeted

Carriers re-evaluate safety of flying into the country as Kyiv’s drone war escalates

Ukraine is planning to step up the presence of its drones near Russian airports to compel their closure, while warning international airlines to re-evaluate the safety of flying there, as part of its effort to disrupt Russia’s economy and force Moscow to end the war.

By Benjamin Katz, Marcus Walker and Serhii Bosak

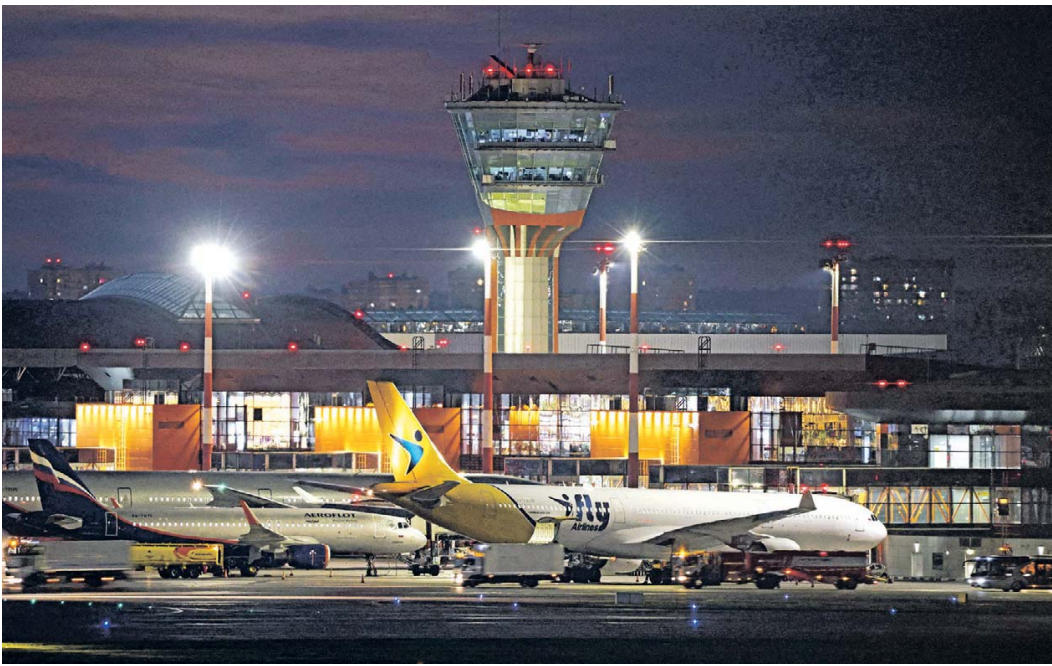
Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky cautioned airlines and their insurers on Tuesday that Russian airspace “is becoming completely unsafe.” Behind his comments, the Ukrainian military said, is a plan to put so many drones in the air near Russian airports that the temporary closures—already increasingly common—become a complete shutdown.

“This is no longer simply a repetition of isolated, sporadic emergency alerts; it is a transition to constant pressure aimed at paralyzing civilian air traffic in the European part of the Russian Federation,” said Serhiy Bratchuk, spokesman for the Ukrainian Armed Forces’ Southern Command.

Ukrainian officials have vowed to avoid targeting airliners and killing civilians. Rather, their plan is to scale up so-called Operation Carpet, under which drones circulate near Russian airports, forcing air-traffic control to pause takeoffs and landings. Ukrainian drones began causing such temporary closures in the summer of 2023 and spiked in recent months.

Russian authorities have refused to close the country’s airspace for civil aviation. Ukraine has kept its airspace closed to civilian flights since the February 2022 invasion.

Although Western countries ended direct air links after the



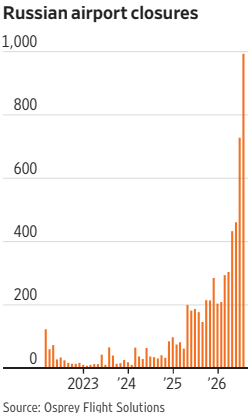
Russia refuses to close its airspace for civil aviation. Planes are parked at Sheremetyevo International Airport outside Moscow.

invasion, airlines from many Middle Eastern and Asian countries have continued to fly to Russia. The absence of U.S. and European competitors has proven a boon for them, offsetting the risk of operating in skies regularly penetrated by Ukrainian drones.

Now, Ukraine wants to make that calculus untenable. In recent months, Ukraine rapidly expanded its long-range air campaign against Russia, sending hundreds of drones a day, as well as cruise missiles, at targets including oil refineries, military industries and commercial warehouses.

In August, a new peak of about 16,000 Ukrainian drones entered airspace that Russia has kept open to civilian aircraft, according to data tracked by aviation-security specialist Osprey Flight Solutions.

The sheer numbers of drones, and the frantic activity of Russian air defenses try-



ing to shoot them down, are creating more risks for civilian aircraft, said aviation-safety experts. Air defenses’ large-scale use of spoofing, or transmitting fake GPS signals to send drones off course, can disorient civilian air traffic.

On average, the proximity of drones forced the temporary closures of 32 airports in Russia each day in August.

Zelensky has criticized Russia for not closing its airspace to remove risks to civilians, as Ukraine has done. “Ukraine does not threaten civilian aviation as such,” he said. “There will simply be drones in Russia’s skies on a scale that has to be taken into account.”

President Vladimir Putin described Zelensky’s warning as a “declaration of terrorism,” adding: “If they follow through, we’ll see how best to answer.”

It remains unclear whether Ukraine’s drone fleet can compel a full-blown closure of Russian airspace, despite the rapid growth of Kyiv’s arsenal. The effort is part of a multi-pronged strategy to impose costs on the Russian economy and bring the war home to Russia.

So far, Putin has rejected Kyiv’s call for a ceasefire that

freezes the fighting on the current front lines. Moscow continues to escalate its own bombing campaign, which has targeted Ukraine’s cities, energy infrastructure and vital business sectors. For the past week, Russian forces have been conducting virtually uninterrupted airstrikes against Ukraine. Hundreds of civilians have been killed in recent months.

Airlines are balking at the growing scope for a disastrous accident in Russian airspace. In June, Israeli carrier El Al halted flights between Tel Aviv and Moscow, citing Ukraine’s drone attacks. In April, Air India shifted its last route from the U.S. that was crossing Russia, instead adding a refueling stop in Seoul on flights from San Francisco to Delhi.

Other airlines have relied on private security companies to help map out which flight paths, altitudes and times of day to use, to reduce risks and

Moscow Closes German Centers

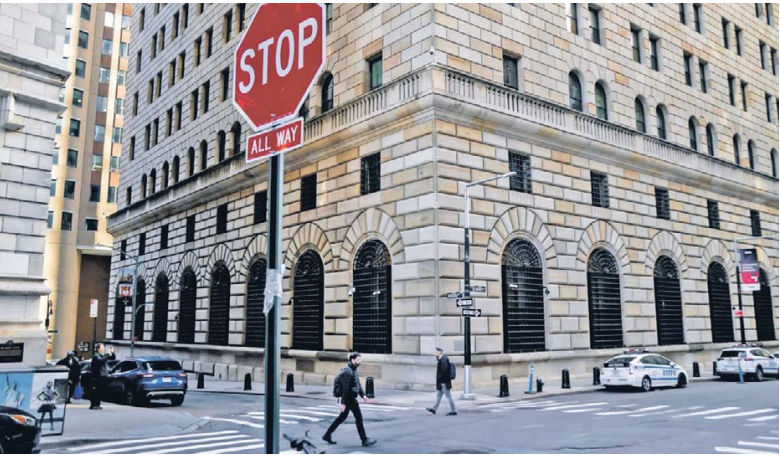
Russia will close German cultural centers on its territory, Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov said Thursday, in a retaliatory measure reflecting the deepening tensions between Moscow and European countries that are helping Ukraine.

Lavrov’s announcement came after Berlin blamed Moscow for an attempted drone attack at an airport on Aug. 4. The explosives-laden drone was found near a Ukrainian plane at the airport, an international freight hub that provides support to Kyiv. The drone was defused.

On Wednesday, Germany said it was closing the Russian Consulate in Bonn and the Russian House cultural center in Berlin.

Earlier Thursday in Munich, several incendiary devices were thrown at a construction site near a building where companies, including from the defense sector, are located, said police. A fire caused no significant damage, police said.

—Associated Press



The Dutch now store 19% of their gold at the Federal Reserve Bank of New York

Dutch Gold Leaves NYC For London

Continued from Page One

don are the two main centers for gold trading. The Fed keeps gold 50 feet below sea level on Manhattan Island bedrock strong enough to support the weight of hundreds of thousands of bars. Security is so tight, three people need to be present even to change a lightbulb.

London, though, remains the global hub for trading physical gold.

The Dutch central bank said bars at the Bank of England need to conform to international market standards and are therefore “regarded as the world’s most easily tradable gold.”

Those in New York and Ottawa, it said, wouldn’t be as easy to trade “in a crisis situation.”

Bank of England vaults also host a lively market in lending and borrowing gold.

Central banks can earn a return by lending bullion to other players in exchange for interest. The hodgepodge of shapes and sizes in the Fed’s vaults limits this market in New York. The operation involved both financial and logistical expertise.

The Dutch central bank

‘Operation Fish’ And World War II

Gold has migrated at other times of geopolitical turbulence. The New York Fed says it attracted much of the world’s bullion during and after World War II, when central banks wanted their reserves far from the reach of the Nazis.

Perhaps the most daring move was ordered by Britain’s then-Prime Minister Winston Churchill. Code-named “Operation Fish,” it saw Britain move its entire gold reserve to Canada.

The first shipment set sail on HMS Emerald days after the surrender of France. It arrived in Halifax a week later having dodged U-boat wolf packs hunting in the Atlantic, according to the Bank of Canada Museum, which says a total of \$160 billion of gold was moved as measured in 2017 dollars.

first sold 59 tons in New York and bought the same amount in London, minimizing the amount that had to fly across the Atlantic.

It transferred a further 27 tons from North America, but not directly to the U.K. In-

stead, the central bank directed the gold to its own vaults in Zeist, in Utrecht province.

Meanwhile, it moved gold from Zeist to London.

The reason? The bars that traveled from the Netherlands to the U.K. met the Bank of England’s standards, so the central bank didn’t have to melt the North American bars down and recast them.

The Dutch central bank didn’t reveal how it shuttled the gold around.

But bullion typically flies commercial in the cargo hold, or sometimes on chartered flights. On the ground, specialized security firms drive it in fortified vans.

Commercial banks including JPMorgan Chase, Citigroup and HSBC are often involved in gold trades by central banks.

The French central bank said earlier this year it had sold 129 tons of gold in New York and bought the same amount in Europe.

The French central bank said this capped two decades of work upgrading the quality of its gold, and that it booked 11 billion euros, equivalent to around \$12.8 billion, in capital gains on the trade.

Leaving gold abroad can prove risky.

Venezuela fought a years-long legal campaign to force the Bank of England to release billions of dollars of reserves held in London, which the U.K. blocked on the grounds it didn’t recognize Nicolás Maduro’s government.

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WORLD NEWS

Sanctions Often Fail To Subdue Autocrats

North Korea, Cuba, Iran are among the nations surviving economic restrictions

Last week, the Trump administration unveiled what it billed as an “Economic D-Day” aimed at forcing Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and return to the negotiating table.

By Timothy W. Martin, Jared Malsin and Kejal Vyas

But the experience of Western sanctions and economic pressure on autocracies such as Cuba, North Korea, Venezuela and Syria shows the challenges facing Washington in trying to bend Tehran to its will. Indeed, the strongmen ruling such countries have used a mix of violence, economic adaptation and political suppression that enables them to withstand economic pain for years, if not decades.

Autocratic countries adapt in various ways. Sanctions typically push activity underground, creating flourishing black markets for goods, services and even people. Dictators also use outside pressure to rally their populations, especially among elites.

The Cuban government has relied on the country’s diaspora to bring in food and medicine even as Washington intensifies pressure on Havana.

North Korea boosts its coffers by stealing cryptocurrency and tricking Americans into working for them in U.S. companies. Russia has reoriented

Limited Wins for Global Pressure

There have been some success stories where the West’s economic pressure has yielded positive results. Nicaraguan leader Daniel Ortega was voted out in 1990 after a decade of sanctions that pummeled the economy, though he later returned to power and remains in charge today. South Africa dropped apartheid after intense global economic pressure. Libya dismantled its nuclear program in 2003

amid heavy sanctions. Economic pressure needs to be coupled with diplomatic campaigns to squeeze an autocratic regime, said Aaron Arnold, a former expert on the United Nations panel monitoring sanctions enforcement against North Korea. “These kinds of levers by themselves may not be the most effective tools,” said Arnold, who is now at the Royal United Services Institute, a London think tank.

its trade flows toward China and other non-Western powers. Tehran, which has branded the U.S. campaign “economic terrorism,” has decades of experience adapting to sanctions. Its trade has grown with countries with which it shares a land border. Iran also has created a parallel financial system with China, bypassing the U.S.-led banking system and weakening Washington’s enforcement powers.

“The fact that the U.S. can inflict pain is a given,” said Djavad Salehi-Isfahani, an economist at Virginia Tech. “My feeling is that these pressures aren’t going to result in more pressure on the Iranian government to compromise.”

Sometimes it requires direct military action to unseat autocrats, as when U.S. forces captured Venezuela’s former leader Nicolás Maduro in Jan-

uary or rebel forces in Syria pushed former President Bashar al-Assad from power in December 2024.

Entrenched power

The U.S. has imposed an embargo against Cuba for more than six decades. As the Trump administration has increased pressure, Cuba’s economy has withered, suffering from power outages and food shortages. But top officials, including leader Miguel Diaz-Canel, have remained defiant even as Trump threatens a “friendly takeover” of the island nation.

Havana, having learned from the Soviet Union’s KGB and East Germany’s Stasi secret police during the Cold War, keeps close tabs on residents, schools, unions and the media to detect and stamp out any dissent.

North Korea has for decades



The statue of former Syrian President Hafez al-Assad was toppled after he was ousted in 2024.

defied some of the harshest sanctions in the world aimed at forcing its leaders to give up its nuclear and long-range missiles. In the past, the economic pressure was such that Pyongyang had signaled a willingness to sacrifice its nuclear program for relief. But no longer.

Now, North Korean leader Kim Jong Un rules a country that has found myriad ways to survive—and even thrive—economically. In recent years, Pyongyang has deployed troops to the Russian front lines for payment, and created an army of operatives able to steal billions in cryptocurrency. Kim recently spurned overtures by Trump to meet, having said the U.S. can choose between “peaceful co-existence or eternal confrontation” with his regime.

Yang Il-cheol, 31 years old, who defected from North Korea last year, said citizens are focused on survival, having lived through fuel outages, starvation and chronic shortages of fertilizer, rice and electricity. People have developed workarounds, like using car batteries to provide emergency power during

blackouts, Yang said. “I think North Koreans’ ability to respond to crises is the best in the world,” he said. The sanctions imposed on Russia during its 2022 invasion of Ukraine generated bold predictions of success, including by then President Joe Biden, who claimed Russia’s economy would be cut in half. Instead, the country’s gross domestic product fell just 1.4% that first year, then recovered. More than four years later, Russian President Vladimir Putin’s grip on power remains tight and he shows no signs of slowing the assault on Ukraine.

Forced removal

Venezuela and Syria experienced deep financial woes from the U.S.-led sanctions campaign. But, in the end, overthrowing the leadership required extraordinary circumstances and military force. Before his capture, Maduro had survived seven years of economic sanctions. During Trump’s first term, Washington expanded a network of sanctions that sought to pun-

ish Maduro’s regime, which was accused of election-rigging, corruption and rampant human-rights abuses. More than eight million Venezuelans, or a quarter of the population, fled during Maduro’s reign.

Both Washington and Caracas officials privately say unwinding the sanctions and encouraging businesses to return has proven difficult, thus delaying economic recovery and making it harder for Maduro’s successor, Delcy Rodríguez, to maintain stability.

In Syria, the U.S. started applying sanctions in 1979. That included designating Syria as a sponsor of terrorism, which restricts foreign direct investment, global trade and access to the world’s financial system. The sanctions imposed during Assad’s time weren’t quickly removed despite a newly elected government and warming ties with the U.S. and Europe. It took nearly two years of diplomatic effort.

Last week, the State Department removed Syria’s designation as a sponsor of terrorism.

FINLAND
Over 2,000 Join Civil-Defense Drill

More than 2,000 people including volunteers and students, are taking part in the biggest civil-defense exercise in Europe since the end of World War II.

In the scenario, critical infrastructure in the central Finnish city of Kuopio, including power and water, has been disrupted by cyberattacks and there is the threat of missile strikes from Finland’s neighbor, Russia.

The goal is for local authorities and ordinary people to rehearse what they would do if they came under attack for real.

Finland’s defense, said retired Army Colonel Asko Muhonen, relies not only on the military but on the “mindset” of ordinary Finns who are ready to take responsibility for their country’s security. Muhonen, who organized the exercise in Kuopio, said that comes partly from the system of conscription which continued in Finland, even after the collapse of the Soviet Union.

—Associated Press

CANARY ISLANDS
At Least 5 Dead On Migrant Boat

A boat carrying West African migrants went adrift in the Atlantic Ocean and left at least five people dead and dozens more feared dead before the vessel was spotted and assisted, Spanish rescuers said on Thursday. Forty-four people were brought to safety in the Canary Islands. Spain’s Maritime Rescue Service on Thursday said one of its planes spotted a “precarious” boat drifting about 70 miles south of the island of Gran Canaria on Wednesday afternoon.

Three survivors were evacuated by helicopter to a hospital on the island. The remaining 41 migrants were brought to safety by boat and disembarked early Thursday in the port of Arguineguin, where they were being cared for by the Red Cross. All of the survivors were men, some underage, and came from Mali or Senegal, said José Antonio Rodríguez Verona, a spokesperson for the Red Cross in the Canaries.

—Associated Press

WORLDWATCH



MOURNING: People pray in Kathmandu, Nepal, for those who died in floods that killed over 1,000 and left nearly 4,000 missing.

Economies In Gulf Face War Woes

Continued from Page One gram, allowing economic activity to bounce back closer to normal, the people familiar with their thinking said.

Those hopes are now gone. Gulf leaders expect the rest of the year will be a washout and are looking at an extended period of low-level conflict with no clear U.S. path to bring it to an end, the people said.

Business people in the hardest-hit sectors in Dubai are signaling a recovery could be a long way off, even as the government has throttled information about war damage, stopped publishing some data and gone on a marketing blitz to portray life in the emirate as back to its prewar best.

Wynn Resorts—which is constructing the first legal casino resort in the U.A.E. at a price tag of more than \$5 billion—said the war has led to a monthslong delay in opening and has increased costs by hundreds of millions of dollars.

“Look, I’m not going to tell you there’s no risk, but when

we underwrote the project...we didn’t underwrite a region with zero geopolitical risk,” Wynn Chief Executive Craig Billings said on a call with investors in August. “We underwrote a country with a demonstrated ability to manage through it.”

Many European and North American airlines—including Air Canada, KLM and Lufthansa—have extended their suspensions of flights to Dubai, in some cases until next year.

Gulf-based airlines have continued to fly across the region, even using Iranian airspace. Their risk appetite is higher. Dozens of planes have landed at or departed Dubai International Airport within five minutes of warnings of missile or drone attacks, The Wall Street Journal has reported.

Dubai International Airport, typically among the world’s busiest, said its passenger traffic fell 31% year-over-year in the first half of 2026. It said cargo shipments are down 29% in the same period.

Hotel occupancy rates dropped to 56% in the first half of the year from around 80% in 2025, according to a report from Cavendish Maxwell, a Persian Gulf-based property consulting firm. Luxury and upscale properties faced the steepest occupancy declines.

The crisis is making tour-

ism less attractive as a counterweight to oil as Saudi Arabia works to reduce its reliance on hydrocarbons under Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman’s Vision 2030 plan, said Neil Quilliam, an associate fellow at international affairs think tank Chatham House in London.

“Vision 2030 was already a bit on the rocks, and they were already changing their priorities,” said Quilliam, referring to the ambitious economic and social-change effort. “There seems to be a push now away from the softer sides of the business goals, more toward industrialization.”

Dubai’s real-estate index, which tracks publicly listed developers, had shed about a third of its value as of Thursday from just before the war.

Residential sales fell 31% in the spring. Sales of luxury properties above \$4 million were hit even harder—down 59%, according to a report from Betterhomes, a Dubai property brokerage.

“This year went into the trash,” said Walid Abou Sabha, a Dubai-based prop-

erty consultant.

Originally from Lebanon, Abou Sabha moved to Dubai in 2023 to tap in to the city’s post-Covid real-estate rush. He went from earning around \$2,000 a month in other Middle Eastern markets to pulling in \$65,000 a month selling properties and living the flashy Dubai lifestyle of fast cars, parties and expensive watches.

After Iran fired on Dubai beginning on the first day of the war, Abou Sabha said his sales in the early spring fell to zero from seven a month, though he said he expects the sector to rebound in a few years.

“You cannot gamble against Dubai. Any time people did, they ended up losing,” Abou Sabha said. Prices in Dubai have held up better than demand. Average sales prices for residential homes were up 3% in 2026’s second quarter from the same period last year, according to Betterhomes. Hotel prices fell only 7% in the first half of the year from the same period of 2025 despite the high vacancies. Airfares have remained high as competition dropped

31%

Year-over-year drop in passenger traffic at Dubai’s airport in first half of 2026

off and jet-fuel prices rose.

Alistair Paine, chief executive of Peninsula, a consulting company that helps international businesses establish in Saudi Arabia and the U.A.E., said prices would eventually succumb to the drop in business, though probably not till the end of the year.

“There is a time effect to be realized here,” Paine said.

Some countries in Asia are aiming to attract businesses leaving the Persian Gulf. Singapore in August announced a tax exemption for some investment profits earned by fund managers. Turkey in June introduced a 20-year tax exemption on certain foreign-sourced income for new residents and a reduced inheritance tax.

Both countries already make it easier for residents to become naturalized citizens than Persian Gulf states, which have extremely restrictive naturalization policies.

“They are incentivizing companies to capitalize on what is going on in the Gulf,” Quilliam said.

Companies that moved into the Gulf chasing the wealth in the region, however, are wrestling with the reality that bureaucratic hurdles and punitive attitudes toward firms that leave could make it tough to return, he said.

“It’s a balancing act,” Quil-

liam said.

The U.A.E. has tried to calm the nerves of its business community, with high-ranking Emirati officials, who typically maintain a low public profile, meeting with investors and entrepreneurs.

Dubai in the spring approved a series of stimulus packages worth about \$680 million. The measures allow for deferrals of—or exemptions from—some government fees, support for hotels and streamlined residency processes.

Dubai is also passing out hundreds of dollars in tourist vouchers that include free tickets to water and theme parks, nearly half off a hotel stay at the city’s posh Palm Jumeirah and three months of a premium food-delivery subscription.

An Emirati-hosted international golf tournament is set to take place in November. Musician Hans Zimmer, bands Imagine Dragons and the Chainsmokers, as well as comedians Russell Peters and Trevor Noah, are scheduled to perform in the country before the year’s end.

But U.A.E. officials acknowledge the war could again prove an impediment.

“A state of neither war nor peace cannot be a sustainable solution,” Anwar Gargash, a senior Emirati adviser, said on social media this week.

WORLD NEWS

German Flashes Charm in Far-Right Bid

Folksy AfD candidate, a former salesman, tries running with a smile in a state race

By Bertrand Benoit

DESSAU, Germany—Locals jostled in the market square here to get a selfie with the far-right Alternative for Germany candidate. Ulrich Siegmund, tanned and smiling, chatted enthusiastically with the crowd, at one point kneeling to speak with a child in a wheelchair.

The AfD is betting that the 35-year-old Siegmund’s sunny disposition and folksy manner, coupled with the party’s signature policies aimed at curbing immigration and leaving the European Union, can lead it to victory in state elections this month in Saxony-Anhalt.

If Siegmund succeeds, it would be the first time a far-right party has governed one of Germany’s 16 federal states since the defeat of the Nazis in World War II—a prospect that has alarmed centrist politicians and the national government.

The AfD’s 256-page governing program for that state calls for a sweeping overhaul of education to reduce teaching about the Nazi era and focus on German achievements as part of a “patriotic cultural policy.” The party would also remove some disabled children and children of asylum seekers from regular classrooms. It favors ending the right to asylum and calls for the deportation of migrants living in the state illegally. It wants to end sanctions on Moscow and restore diplomatic ties.

Some of those aims are beyond the remit of a state government. But gaining control of Saxony-Anhalt, a state of 2.3 million people that was once part of East Germany, would give the party oversight of education as well as police and the state’s branch of the



Ulrich Siegmund, 35 years old, is seen by the AfD as a crucial bridge to more moderate voters.

intelligence service.

The party’s potential control of a state government is shaking Germany’s security establishment. The Saxony-Anhalt arm of the AfD, which is seen as among the most radical of the party’s regional branches, is under surveillance by the state branch of Germany’s domestic intelligence agency, which says it promotes an ethnocentric view of nationality and is working to discredit democratic institutions.

For years, the AfD’s positions were a hard sell for most voters, and most of Germany’s political parties have worked to keep the party out of government. But the party is hoping Siegmund provides the friendly face it needs to close the deal with centrist voters.

Polls suggest he has a shot, putting his support at 40% to 43%. The party has almost twice the support of its next closest competitor, Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s center-right Christian Democratic Union. Depending on how other parties fare, such support could translate into a majority of seats in a state parliament for

the first time since the AfD’s creation in 2013.

“Siegmund is the smiling face of a sinister organization,” said Jürgen Hardt, a conservative lawmaker in Berlin. “Right now, they are being very disciplined, letting him run as he wants. If he wins, he will be a hero. If not, they will throw him out.”

Siegmund was a member of the CDU before switching to the AfD shortly after the party’s creation. Trained as a salesman, he created Berlin Duftet (Berlin Smells), a company that sold room fragrances to stores, promising to boost their sales.

“I discovered early on that my strength was in commerce,” he told a business website in 2014. “I just love selling.”

Siegmund, who didn’t respond to interview requests for this article, has run not just one of the party’s most professional campaigns, some analysts say, but also its most optimistic. Its motto is “everything is possible.” The party’s governing program is loaded with feel-good proposals, including more money for edu-

cation, subsidies for firefighters to get a driver’s license and the abolition of a fee to pay for public broadcasting.

“Siegmund is a blessing. He has a great personality, tremendous energy and a lot of charisma,” said Laurens Nothdurft, general counsel to the AfD caucus in Saxony-Anhalt, adding that the candidate had tapped into the region’s “strong will for change.”

But personality isn’t everything. Pollsters in Germany ask voters what party they prefer. When the question is about candidates, Siegmund doesn’t perform much better than his center-right rival, the state’s current governor. Pollsters say his strength has been to act as a funnel by persuading non-AfD voters to give the party and its program a second look.

His upbeat pitch has proved particularly potent given the political and economic crisis

now permeating Germany. Europe’s largest economy has hardly grown since 2019, its industry is shrinking and Merz has become the country’s least-popular chancellor in living memory.

Mainstream politicians have been looking to the election in Saxony-Anhalt with a mix of fear and fascination. The problem, said Georg Maier, the center-left interior minister of the nearby state of Thuringia, was that a longing for change was blinding some disaffected centrists to the dangers of an AfD government.

The AfD’s proximity to Russia, Maier said, was a particular concern. He said AfD lawmakers in Thuringia had recently requested information from his ministry about drone defenses and Russian spying activities using a procedure that forces the government to respond.

An AfD interior minister, he said, would also have access to Oplan Germany, a secret military plan detailing how NATO troops would deploy through the country in case of a war with Russia, including highly sensitive information about supply routes and ammunition depots.

That concern wasn’t shared by many voters who turned up at some of the AfD’s recent events in Saxony-Anhalt. Klaus Ahting, a 52-year-old translator from the region, said he thought of himself as part of the liberal center yet was also AfD-curious.

“The parties that have been in power up to now haven’t done their homework,” Ahting said. “I’m at a point now where I’m beginning to think it wouldn’t be the worst thing for them to get a shot at governing and showing they can do better.”

Growth Estimates Revised Higher in Germany

By Ed Frankl

Healthy exports and rising public investment have raised expectations for Germany’s economic growth this year, a leading economic-research institute said Thursday.

The Ifo Institute now anticipates growth of 1.4% in 2026, from 0.8% in its previous quarterly report made in June.

“Significant impetus from abroad and increased spending on infrastructure, climate, and defense in Germany are preventing a more severe economic slowdown due to the energy-price shock and low water levels in rivers,” said Timo Wollmershaeuser, head of business cycle analysis and forecasts at the Ifo.

The uptick also was driven by an upward revision to gross domestic product growth in 2026 so far. In late August, Germany’s statistics agency said growth in the second quarter was 0.3%, better than the 0.2% first reported, driven by stronger exports that overcame some of the hit from surging energy costs because of the war in Iran. GDP increased 0.4% in the first quarter of this year.

The damping effects of the energy-price shock on the economy now look weaker, Ifo noted.

“There are rays of hope, especially for the crisis-stricken industry sector,” Wollmershaeuser said. Industrial output has climbed in recent months, official data showed. “The German economy is continuing to recover.”

The Ifo expects growth at 1.2% in 2027, up from the 0.8% it predicted in June, and at 0.8% in 2028. It said inflation is set to rise to 3.0% next year.

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FROM PAGE ONE

The Joy Of Robots Failing

Continued from Page One
ing feeling of superiority.

Like when a weightlifter staggered under a puny-looking barbell, then dropped it, tripped over it and landed face first. It got better when a pair of solemn-looking humans carried the competitor away on a stretcher.

It's tougher to laugh about how much faster a large language model could have written this article. There's nothing entertaining in footage of swarming war drones. Data centers are mushrooming, so numerous and monolithic they seem abstract, until one starts materializing on the Conodoguinet Creek in Pennsylvania, where I grew up.

Robots struggling to cosplay people, on the other hand, are the ideal straw man for my anxieties about human obsolescence.

"If a washing machine breaks, nobody laughs," said Dennis Hong, an engineering professor at UCLA. But when a delivery bot drives off a pier, or a humanoid faceplants while botching a dance move, people are seeing more than slapstick humor. "There may also be a little bit of satisfaction: 'See? Humans are still better.'"

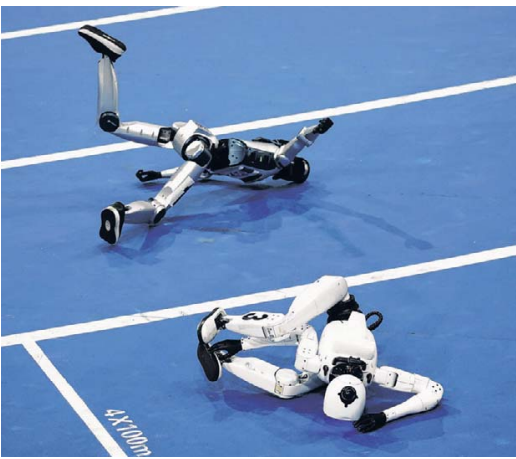
Even Hong, who's working tirelessly to improve robots, finds joy in videos with titles like "Ranking Funniest Clanker Fails."

"Oh, I laugh. Some of them are genuinely hilarious—if it is NOT our robot," he said.

As director of UCLA's Robotics and Mechanisms Laboratory, Hong is rethinking robots for the age of A.I. Traditional robotics called for machines that were mechanically predictable and easy to model. New data-driven systems allow engineers to experiment with designs, controls and materials they previously wouldn't consider.

Hong said he urges students to embrace failure as a learning tool—ideally while using a safety harness and cushions on the floor.

The uncanny physics of ro-



LIYAO ZHANG/GETTY IMAGES

Sprinting robots slammed full tilt into a barrier and collapsed.

bot crack ups is part of what makes them addictive. Artificial limbs programmed for specific movements end up flailing in surprisingly chaotic ways. Humanoid bodies flop with no self-protection reflex.

Changliu Liu, an assistant professor at Carnegie Mellon University's Robotics Institute, has a YouTube failbot compilation she likes to show students. It starts with a human-

oid descending some steps with apparent confidence—then missing a step, toppling like a tree and losing its head on impact.

The laughs keep coming, especially when a little bot in a soccer jersey whiffs a kick and splats on its back. She uses the clips not just to diagnose what went wrong, but to consider what could have gone worse in a real-life environment.

Japan Wary Of Chinese Warships

Continued from Page One

In recent years, North Korea has increased its focus on shorter-range missiles designed to threaten Japan and South Korea. That weaponry includes tactical nukes. Japanese officials said the Russian military has expanded its movements in the sea and air around Japan—including by performing live missile drills near the southern Kuril Islands, which are claimed by both Russia and Japan.

At the same time, the countries have stepped up rhetoric disparaging Japan's militaristic past, saying that the country's efforts to strengthen its defenses are similar to its World War II aggression.

Japan's U.S. alliance, meanwhile, has come under pressure. President Trump has railed against those he perceives as freeloading off the U.S. security umbrella, most recently criticizing countries including Japan for failing to send warships to help the U.S. reopen the Strait of Hormuz. He has sown doubts in Asian capitals over his willingness to come to their aid, questioning whether America should defend Taiwan. Trump has downsized planned U.S. drills with South Korea's military, and redeployed the Japan-based USS George Washington to the Middle East.

Still, the U.S. demonstrated in a giant international drill in the Pacific this summer that it is working closely with Asian allies, with another three-way exercise between the U.S., South Korea and Japan planned for this month. It has also expanded its military presence in the Philippines, as part of Washington's strategy to scatter U.S. forces across the Pacific.

The worsening security backdrop is hastening a Japanese defense buildup championed by Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi. She has doubled Japan's defense budget to 2% of gross domestic product and loosened the shackles of a postwar commitment to pacifism that prevented Japan from selling arms abroad or maintaining a clandestine intelligence agency.

Defense planners are also recasting the country's security priorities to prepare Japan for a prolonged defense in the event of any conflict, a lesson absorbed from the drawn-out war in Ukraine.

On Monday, the Japanese defense ministry asked the government for a record \$56 billion to finance spending on missiles, drones and other priorities over the next fiscal year.

A spokesperson for China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said the Chinese military has always complied with international law and international practice.

Military ruins

The urgency is felt in places such as Amami-Oshima. Kamada, the mayor of Setouchi, said he would like to see a bigger military presence on the is-



KO SASAKI FOR WSJ (3)



Chinese warships are sailing close to the Japanese island of Amami-Oshima. Above, Amami City.

reassured by the defense forces' presence. "If there is a Taiwan contingency, Amami would inevitably get caught up in it," said Keiichiro Tabata, who runs Hotel Bigmarine Amami, a family hotel in Amami City that started 30 years ago as a shop selling fishing gear. He said the bases ease local anxieties.

And despite friction with China, Tabata said he's still happy to welcome Chinese tourists, who have been frequent visitors to his hotel.

That is provided they don't try to steal the island's prized fauna. Last year, three Chinese nationals who had stayed at his hotel were fined and deported after illegally harvesting protected crabs native to Amami-Oshima. Staff at Tabata's hotel heard scratching in the visitors' suitcases. Police found more than 5,000 live crabs inside. The crabs' vivid colors mean they can fetch a high price—the equivalent of \$125 for a large one—from collectors and pet stores.

Defense 'vacuum'

China has been using the narrow strait between Amami-Oshima and the rocky Japanese outcrop of Yokoate in an effort to learn about an area where it might one day face combat, Japanese naval experts say.

A span of international wa-

One of Liu's specialties is human-robot safety. There's a growing need for certification standards as humanoids venture beyond programmed stunts into the unpredictable world of people, she said. "It is when the robot gets out of those stages, when they get in the crowd, then problems happen."

Which brings up my weakness for videos of rogue activity at malls and street festivals in places where humanoids are less expensive to make and deploy, especially China.

In one, a stubby robot sporting an electric-blue wig shows off some spins and thrusts for spectators, then clips a kid with a kick to the stomach. In another, an office bot sends its human co-workers scrambling by suddenly aiming kung-fu moves in their direction.

This content is part of a growing public-relations problem for the field.

"I do think there has been a shift," Hong said. "Robots used to be mostly something people were fascinated by."

Folks once eager for the butlers of the future are now wary of potential attackers and

job thieves. That's a bummer for the engineers developing humanoids with miraculous applications, like autonomous disaster-response bots.

Liu said she's seeing that anxiety play out at demonstration events where some of the young people she's trying to inspire are more interested in tricking the machines. "Once they do something to break the robot they feel very proud of themselves," she said.

That sent me back to the video of my all-time favorite failbot, the "Billie Jean" machine. What starts as a decent impersonation of a Michael Jackson impersonator goes sideways when the gyrating bot stumbles on some stairs, then recovers, only to slam completely on the steps and lie still, as if dead from embarrassment.

Maybe it was the audience's silent reaction to the dancer bombing. Or the fact that it was wearing a T-shirt without pants. But something got to me, and I felt a pang of empathy for the humanoid being dragged off the stage by its human handler.

I wonder what that robot is up to right now.

Officials in Tokyo are also working on plans to create stockpiles of energy, critical minerals, ammunition, food and medicines to show Japan is prepared to dig in if the region tips into crisis—a lesson learned from the extended fighting in Ukraine. Japan's dependence on imported energy from the Middle East has also been made plain by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the ongoing conflict in Iran. "We are trying to be ready for a prolonged war," a senior government official said. Before Ukraine, "we didn't think about it."

But Tomohisa Takei, a retired admiral in Japan's navy who is now a senior fellow at the Sakakawa Peace Foundation in Tokyo, cited the weakness of Japan's defense-industrial base and other thorny problems, including persistent recruitment difficulties for the military in Japan's aging society, saying: "Japan is not ready to fight a protracted war."

Beijing—and, increasingly, Moscow and Pyongyang—has characterized Japan's defense buildup as a rekindling of the militarism that led to Imperial Japan's brutal march across Asia and its defeat in World War II. China was angered by Prime Minister Takaichi's remark late last year that Japan could get dragged into any conflict over Taiwan.

In response, Beijing throttled tourist flights to Japan from China and squeezed Japanese firms' access to Chinese rare earths, critical components in manufacturing. China also stepped up naval and coast guard activity around disputed nearby islands, known as the Senkakus in Japanese and Diaoyu in Chinese, and portrayed Takaichi in Imperial Japanese uniform in state propaganda.

Russia took a similar position, with a spokesman from the foreign ministry saying "the current remilitarization course runs counter to the Japanese people's interests."

He spoke just prior to Russian President Vladimir Putin's first official visit to the southern Kuril Islands, which were seized by Russia from Japan at the close of World War II and which Japan still claims.

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un's sister, Kim Yo Jong, meanwhile, has accused Washington of being behind Tokyo's "dangerous military moves."

Koizumi, Japan's defense minister, has expressed bafflement at the charge of militarism. "Nothing could be further from the truth," he told a recent gathering of security officials in Singapore. He said China is the one with strategic bombers and nuclear weapons, not Japan, saying China has been outspending Japan and other countries on its military for years.

Tokyo hopes that by beefing up its capabilities—in areas such as missile defense, naval power and drones—it can strengthen U.S. commitments to the region's defense, Japanese officials say.

Hiroshi Ota, a former missile-unit commander who now leads trekking tours on Amami-Oshima, wishes people in Japan would be more aware of the security risks the country faces.

"Surrounded by such countries, Japan is extremely vulnerable" he said, referring to China, Russia and North Korea. "We must realize that without the U.S. military and the United States' backing, Japan cannot survive."



A political poster of Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi, and a military vehicle on the island.



ARTS IN REVIEW



‘By Any Means’ suggests it takes a dirty man to clean up a historically and culturally entrenched mess. We’re in 1966 Mississippi, where a strait-laced black FBI agent (Yahya Abdul-Mateen II) and a career criminal (Mark Wahlberg) become unlikely partners in an effort to solve a racist murder. Welcome to a race-swapped “48 Hrs.” with a heart of righteous fury.

Civil-rights dramas tend to be preachy and self-congratulatory, painting halos on the white saviors and the black victims, but the rousing “By Any Means” takes a literally punchy approach. It filters the trauma of race-based suffering through a genre piece about busting heads. Setting out to rebut the sanctimony of, say, “To Kill a Mockingbird,” with its holy glow, the feature directed by Elegance Bratton (“The Inspection”) has more of a “Dirty Harry” vibe. In a system corrupted by racism, justice is sometimes unattainable. If they mess with you, notes Mr. Wahlberg’s character, you’re allowed to mess with them, except he uses a different verb than “mess.”

Two years after the landmark Civil Rights Act of 1964, black people in Mississippi are still rarely seen at the ballot box because of continuing intimidation and a \$2-a-head poll tax. Vernon Dahmer (Giancarlo Esposito), an NAACP leader, announces he will personally pay the fee for any voter who can’t afford it. This effectively paints a target on his back, and Ku Klux Klan members set out to kill him as terrifyingly as possible.

One of the few black FBI agents, Mr. Abdul-Mateen’s Wayne

FILM REVIEW | KYLE SMITH

A Gangster For a Good Cause

‘By Any Means’ follows a mob hitman enlisted to help solve a racist murder



Strider (a fictional character), is assigned to the case, but isn’t making much progress; when he visits the crime scene, the local police ignore his badge and bar him from entry. Witnesses are too scared of retribution to say what they know. Strider’s bosses (Josh Lucas and David Strathairn) tell him they’re calling in a little unplanned assistance from a friend of the bureau with special exper-

tise in finding the truth. True detail: Mr. Wahlberg’s Gregory Scarpa, a capo in the Colombo crime family in New York, was for many years an FBI informant. The movie portrays him as an arm’s-length option for the bureau to beat information out of those with knowledge of racist crimes such as the “Mississippi Burning” case of three civil-rights activists whose bodies were buried

in an earthen dam after they were murdered.

If the civil-rights revolution was primarily effected by patient application of the laws, “By Any Means” suggests some of its reforms came about via the impatient application of fists. As written by Sascha Penn (showrunner for the Starz series “Power Book III: Raising Kanan”), the story is an entertaining tale of white supremacists getting their faces turned purple.

Mr. Wahlberg and Mr. Abdul-Mateen do a more than competent job of recapturing the feuding-buddies energy that Eddie Murphy and Nick Nolte gave “48 Hrs.” Strider, the FBI man who wants to do everything by the book, learns quickly that Scarpa is astonishingly ready to solve problems via the pull of a trigger. Goading his sort-of partner, whom he calls “Jackie Robinson,” though Strider replies that he isn’t the first black FBI agent, Scarpa seeks to win him over to the wisdom of beating information out of shady characters. The gangster notes that he doesn’t see the point of Martin Luther King Jr.’s pacifist strategy and prefers the style of Malcolm

Mark Wahlberg and Yahya Abdul-Mateen II in the film, set in 1966, above; Mr. Wahlberg, below.

X, who famously said, “We want justice by any means necessary,” hence the film’s title. “Turn the other cheek, that ain’t really winning, is it?” Scarpa says.

Mr. Wahlberg is, as usual, overflowing with masculine bravado and irrepressible charm even as he is deriding Strider (“So you’re my driver?”) and reveling in cruelty. In one scene, in a gun store, he beats up a shopkeeper who doesn’t even know anything, just to make sure. So extreme are Scarpa’s methods that he and Strider have a fistfight themselves, filmed with visceral urgency by Mr. Bratton.

There is a lot of psychological hurt to this story—a scene in which Strider coaxes an innocent old lady to tell him what she knows about the crime, risking her life in the process, carries a heart-breaking undercurrent of doom—and even more of the kind that accompanies getting your head smashed in. It’s the only way to the truth, Scarpa says: “I’ve been trying to make a f— man out of you,” he tells Strider.

Scarpa, thrillingly aggressive as he is, is not nice, and that’s the point. Answering savagery with savagery may not be a morally balanced way to look at the world, but onscreen it plays brilliantly, as it has many times in other movies. “Dirty Harry” was condemned as racist and even fascist in its day; Dirty Marky paints a crowd-pleasing picture of how disregarding the rulebook could help topple the Ku Klux Klan.

TELEVISION REVIEW | JOHN ANDERSON

Dickens Redone In Familiar Fashion

The new MGM+ version of “A Tale of Two Cities” isn’t overly faithful to the Charles Dickens book, but Dickens wasn’t overly faithful to the French Revolution. *Egalité*, perhaps. The author used a head-spinning historical event to frame the typical elements of the classic 19th-century novel—sweeping narrative, parallel lives, interconnected destinies, the best and worst of humanity—and the uprising was tailored to fit the script. But the story does have great moments.

Waiting for those moments requires quite a bit of patience, though. And while it would be unfair to pick on MGM—or its producing partner here, the BBC—this “Tale” fits what has become a predictable pattern among literary adaptations, and period pieces in general. The artificiality isn’t just about painted backdrops and CGI mobs.



It’s about overly noble characters, their stagy exchanges, the manicured squalor of the poor and, for the rich, an opulence that might have arrived courtesy of Wayfair. Again, this isn’t something specific to “A Tale of Two Cities” or its pre-



Mirren Mack, left, and Kit Harington, above, in a new version of ‘A Tale of Two Cities.’

senters. There seems to be a stylistic monopoly at work among the streamers of “original content” that renders innovative storytelling—and any semblance of cinema—invalid. This is evidently quite appealing, or mollifying, to many audiences.

But it is a bit ironic, given how freely the producers have played with their source material. (This version is “based on” the 1859 Dickens book, the all-purpose qualifier.) Lucie Manette (Mirren Mack, “Sex Education”), who was spirited out of France as a child after her father,

Dr. Alexandre Manette (Guillaume Gallienne), was sent to the Bastille, is studying to be a surgeon. In 1770s London. Clandestinely, of course. (There will be cadavers aplenty as the tale proceeds.) The high-born Charles Darnay (François Civil), estranged from his arrogantly evil family, the Evrémondes, fought in the American Revolution. Mme. Defarge (Roxane Duran), literature’s most notorious knitter, is vaguely sympathetic. But this is also a story about literal class warfare, one in which those who oppose the privileges of blood are unwilling to forgive the sins of the fathers. No one questions the illogic.

No one seems to notice, either, that the hero, dissolute lawyer Syd-

ney Carton (Kit Harington, “Game of Thrones”), looks very little like Charles Darnay, even though pivotal moments of the plot hinge on their uncanny resemblance to each other. This critic is all for color-blind casting. Making me pretend that these guys look alike is asking too much.

One does buy into the love triangle, though, among Lucie, Sydney and Charles, especially since Lucie and Sydney go to bed together (not in the text!) before she realizes she really loves Charles. And Sydney—

after schemes, escapes and sacrifices—is set up for the most famous fictional moment in the Reign of Terror. It’s a superb sequence, one in which Mr. Harington shows the depth of his talent and which all of Sydney’s earlier cynicism and strutting has made more convincing, and moving. It also suggests that a far, far better adaptation might have been possible if the considerable talent behind the “Tale” had been more constructively liberated.

A Tale of Two Cities Begins Sunday, 10 p.m., MGM+

Mr. Anderson is the Journal’s TV critic.

ARTS IN REVIEW



Travis A. Knight and Cher Álvarez in the show, based on the popular films.

THEATER REVIEW | CHARLES ISHERWOOD

Horror High Jinks on Broadway

‘Paranormal Activity’ proves an insidiously effective play, and doesn’t rely on flashy technical wizardry

The things that go bump in the night at the theater are usually the knees of someone behind you beating a tattoo on the back of your seat, or one of the larger iPhone models clunking to the floor. But at “Paranormal Activity,” a show inspired by the popular film franchise, all the disturbing sounds come from the stage. Except for the occasional, funny imprecation shouted from the audience: “Don’t do it!” someone behind me screeched when one of the characters started acting like a brainless teen in a slasher movie, walking heedlessly into a dark room.

The stage version, writ-

ten by Levi Holloway (author of the quick-flop Broadway thriller “Grey House”) and directed by Felix Barrett, founder of the Punchdrunk theater company (creators of the long-running “Sleep No More”), naturally follows the template traced by many of the seven movies in the series, which collectively grossed almost \$900 million. Comely young couple moves into new house; high jinks of horror ensue.

Lou (Cher Álvarez) and James (Travis A. Knight), married almost a year, have just arrived in London, where he has found a better job than he had back in Chicago. They are happy to get away from that city, where they were plagued by un-

nerving but undescribed events. And Lou is also pleased to put some distance between her and her mother-in-law, Carolanne (a floridly funny Shannon Cochran), who lives in Florida and, as we see in a video chat, is overbearingly eager for them to give her a grandchild. When she spots a whiskey in Lou’s hand she blurts out, “Not pregnant, then.” She also helpfully informs them that the antidepressants Lou takes can “mess with the chances of having a baby.” Thanks, Ma.

The movies employed the found-footage style made popular by “The Blair Witch Project,” using supposedly homemade video to lend an air of this-could-happen-to-you verisimilitude. Obviously the stage version, which originated in the U.K. and was seen at several U.S. regional theaters before arriving on Broadway, cannot replicate that effect. But what makes it appealing—even refreshing, for Broadway—is its low-tech approach to generating goosebumps. Although ghosts of a sort do eventually appear, they are in human skins and human-scaled. There’s little in the way of flashy pyrotechnics—who hasn’t seen a TV suddenly freak out?—indicating the supernatural activity. These are low-frills thrills, and all the more insidiously effective for it. (The superb “illusions designer” is Chris Fisher, who is also, perhaps not incidentally, a magician.)

As Lou and James settle into the house—the set, by Fly Davis, depicts a modest two-story dwelling, with kitchen and living room below, bedroom, bath and po-

tential nursery (and locus of scary happenings) above—everyday mishaps gradually accrue sinister significance, as they begin to multiply. An alarm goes off, inexplicably. The power flares out when Lou is in a Zoom meeting. James finds the gas on in the kitchen, although Lou insists she turned it off, and tension simmers between them

when James suggests that maybe she forgot because of her medication. The door of that spare room upstairs opens with an ominous creak (natch).

Ms. Álvarez, whose Lou seems to be the focus of the marauding spirit—or the cause of its presence, as she fears—gives a terrific, understated performance, Lou’s unease and rising anx-

ity never descending into bathos or hysterics. And Mr. Knight is also superb as James tries to muffle his own fears the better to lessen his wife’s. The astute, low-key nature of their performances enhances the tale’s creepy credibility.

As the strange disturbances cause more friction between the couple, they decide to call in a medium whose podcast Lou has been listening to. Etheline Cotgrave—despite her fantastical name played suitably in realistic, non-Madame Arctati-ish mode by Eva Kamin-sky—takes her work seriously. She insists that Amazon’s Alexa not just be powered down but unplugged. (Talk about scary.) Unfortunately things don’t go well: Echoing the first movie, the spook-hunter gets so spooked she flees the house, leaving a dire prediction behind her.

I can’t say “Paranormal Activity” had me white-knuckled throughout. Absent an intermission, the tension might grow tauter more consistently. But Mr. Holloway and Mr. Barrett are expert at twisting the mundane into the uncanny, and rely only minimally on the kind of jump-scars that cheapen many a horror movie. Best of all, the shocker revelation explaining the shivery occurrences is haunting and persuasive—within the wide parameters of the genre, of course. It leaves us with a chilling moral about how the misdeeds of the past, not properly atoned for, can shape the contours of life, and even death.

Paranormal Activity
August Wilson Theatre, 245 W. 52nd St., New York
888-811-5040, closes Jan. 3, 2027

Mr. Isherwood is the Journal’s theater critic.



Scenes from the play, written by Levi Holloway and directed by Felix Barrett.



The WSJ Daily Crossword | Edited by Mike Shenk

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- 27 Ski slope ascender
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- 29 The perfect place
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- 34 Call on
- 35 Rent out
- 37 Ontario or Michigan
- 38 Dubai bigwig
- 39 Some wines
- 41 Reutlingen rejection
- 42 Lamp resident
- 43 Wine valley of California
- 48 Polite reply
- 50 Gumbo stuff
- 51 Stadium fixtures
- 52 Words of agreement
- 53 Birthing party
- 54 Actor Quinn
- 55 Did some ushering
- 56 Ranch marking
- 57 Relaxed runner
- 61 African flow
- 62 Dire fate
- 63 Smallest bills
- 65 Keep tabs on
- 67 Quattro precursor

WE'RE HERE TO HELP | By Matt Gaffney

The answer to this week’s contest crossword is a five-letter TV show.

Across

- 1 After expenses
- 4 Address for a longtime buddy
- 9 Part of MIT
- 13 Like some poetry
- 15 Analyze grammatically
- 16 Serious promise
- 17 1952 western starring Marlon Brando
- 19 Start to cool?
- 20 Make amends
- 21 Something caring folks give
- 23 Lennon loved her
- 24 1991 Bill Murray comedy
- 27 Future adolescents
- 30 Word often followed with a!
- 31 Atrocious
- 32 Heist take
- 36 Tool in school
- 40 2019 superhero movie
- 44 Rapp on stages
- 45 Puzzle with an extra level
- 46 Joke around
- 47 Like many piano pieces
- 49 Tricky puzzles
- 52 2016 Ken Loach movie that won the top prize at Cannes
- 58 Fish with a suggested 1:250 gallons of water ratio
- 59 Managua month
- 60 Stranger who just starts interacting with you
- 64 Lacking duds
- 66 2002 Spike Jonze movie that earned a Best Actor nomination for Nicolas Cage
- 68 Neutrogena competitor
- 69 Restaurant with cheeseburgers, maybe
- 70 Sour fruit
- 71 Grow smaller
- 72 Tennis champ Agassi
- 73 Printing measures
- 7 Something guessers take
- 8 Seek support from
- 9 Promise to reimburse
- 10 Magnate
- 11 Court reporter
- 12 Beat
- 14 Words requesting permission
- 18 Elf precursor
- 22 Court position
- 25 Arthur on many courts

Down

- 1 Science show
- 2 Tighten up the copy in
- 3 Save to watch later
- 4 Graz grandpa
- 5 Gently wash against
- 6 Label available on farfetch.com

Previous Puzzle’s Solution

CAB	DELL	SHAVE
AGO	ALEUT	LONER
BIGAM	ISTS	OTTER
ALIBI	SEABED	
LEERED	AGORAS	
	UNIT	ABIGAIL
CLIP	GUNMEN	MOO
AUNT	LEI	TILT
LIC	ARIPANA	ASIS
EGOTRIP	ODOR	
BRIGHTS	ACTUAL	
	WEEKLY	TANGO
ATEAM	GOOVERBIG	
MAORI	BIGOT	ATE
PUNTS	SAWS	GAS

► Email your answer—in the subject line—to crosswordcontest@wsj.com by 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time Sunday, Sept. 6. A solver selected at random will win a WSJ mug. Last week’s winner: Ileana Krumme, Ann Arbor, MI. Complete contest rules at [WSJ.com/Puzzles](https://www.wsj.com/puzzles). (No purchase necessary. Void where prohibited. U.S. residents 18 and over only.)

OPINION

Make Mark Ruffalo Great Again



POTOMAC WATCH
By Kimberley A. Strassel

Republicans are fighting for their mid-term lives, so it's something to watch the president finally rally them together with a plan to lock down the Hollywood academy and California's liberal political class.

And the Oscar for Most Self-Defeating Politics goes to . . .

"I am going to suggest that Republicans and Democrats get together, and immediately craft Legislation to save the Movie, Television, and Entertainment Business in America. Congress should approve, immediately, a Federal Production Incentive to create Entertainment Jobs in America," Donald Trump enthused on Truth Social Monday. This was followed by a Tuesday post praising the "great bipartisan response" to his great Hollywood bailout, then by yet another, of the president thumbs-upping it with his Hollywood ambassador, Jon Voight.

Feel better, voters. As gas prices rise, the president has George Clooney, Jeff Katzenberg, Sen. Adam Schiff and Gov. Gavin Newsom, covered.

The congressional response to adding billions in Hollywood subsidies to \$40 trillion in debt was notable, if not "great." Republicans—unable to pass capital-gains relief for homeowners or basic online safety legislation, or even to fund the mili-

tary—finally found an oppressed class worth uniting for: studio barons and megastars. "Whatever we can do to be supportive is a good thing," Florida Rep. Vern Buchanan saluted, taking a break from deficit laments. Plans are already afoot to drive a bill through the House Ways and Means Committee. Expect the topic to be central at next week's GOP "midterm convention" in Texas. The implicit Republican 2026 message: Make Mark Ruffalo Great Again.

Trump’s Hollywood bailout is sure to bomb at the box office and the ballot box.

Democrats hear Christmas bells. The California delegation (85% Democrats) has made a cause of this bailout, and Mr. Schiff held a hearing on the proposal in March. The California senator—who as a representative led the charge to impeach the president twice—proposes Republicans and Democrats "work together . . . to get this done, and bring the movie magic back to America." Mr. Newsom, who last year proposed a \$7.5 billion federal tax credit, abandoned his previously scheduled Trump trolling and on Monday gold-stamped the president's plan with: "Amen. Let's make it happen." It's "The Good, the Bad and the Ugly," D.C.-spending style.

On the merits, the proposal

is dreadful. Yes, the U.S. has seen a big drop in domestic movie production, partly a function of a global industry's adjusting to streaming services and falling ticket sales. The issue is cost. And no surprise California has led the way in shedding slots. Of the estimated 100,000 industry jobs nationwide lost since 2022, the biggest chunk dropped from the Los Angeles area. What movie-maker is eager to engage in a state with onerous "above the line" taxes, insane regulations, and actor and writer guilds that strike with the regularity of the ticking clock in "High Noon"? It isn't a trick question.

One solution—the one that ignores underlying economic reality, but makes politicians look proactive—is to join in the global subsidy race to the bottom, trying to lure production back with more giveaways at taxpayer expense. The president's claim that "money spent on Tax Incentives will be made up tenfold by the money pouring into the Treasury's coffers" is fantasy. California last year doubled its own film credit, and here we are. The other solution—less politically fun, lacking in spending gratification—is to demand California save its own industry, and its broader self, by reversing policies that are driving a "Ten Commandments"-style exodus from its state.

But it's the politics that are most self-sabotaging. The latest Reuters/Ipsos poll shows the single top issue this midterm for a plurality of Americans is the cost of living, and

that 71% of respondents disapprove of Mr. Trump's handling of that problem. The country wants Republicans to provide them concrete wins on live issues: gasoline prices, inflation, taxes. Yet polls show the party's message, which now hinges on the year-ago accomplishment of a reconciliation bill—isn't landing. That's in part because the main messenger keeps bouncing from threats against Iran to vaccine plot theory to arguments over the appropriate name for the body of water between Rochester, N.Y., and Toronto.

There is at least continuity in the White House now positioning the GOP to roar into a midterm sprint as lead advocates for the Chanel class (just as that group gears up to bash the president at the Emmys, the Grammys and the Golden Globes). It's in keeping with the spring-through-summer obsession with other topics that blare a disconnect from average concerns, say a \$400 million, 90,000-square-foot, gilded ballroom. The GOP isn't only failing to get its message across; it's actively making itself look oblivious. It was a similar disconnect that helped Democrats lose in 2024.

Mr. Trump has pledged to spend the final 30 days before the election stumping for the GOP. He can use those stops to reassure voters that Republicans will improve their day-to-day lives—or he can pledge to spend their money on Tinsel Town. Those messages don't go together.

Write to kim@wsj.com.

Trump Picks the Wrong Christian Charity

HOUSES OF WORSHIP
By Cliff Smith

Having brought to an end the U.S. Agency for International Development, it is unsurprising that the Trump administration is seeking to mend fences with evangelicals by reinstituting \$2 billion in foreign aid, with government directing the funds through Christian and other faith-based charities. Many churches are deeply entwined with groups that received significant funds from USAID. One April poll showed that three-fourths of evangelicals were concerned about the dismantling of USAID.

What is surprising is that the Trump administration chose World Vision, a troubled evangelical international-aid charity, to oversee this project. World Vision has repeated and serious problems vetting both staff and programs, leading to significant amounts of money going to U.S. designated terrorist entities, including Hamas and Osama bin Laden affiliates. World Vision has repeatedly denied its culpability, acknowledged both by Israeli courts and key actors in the Senate.

World Vision's Gaza director, Mohammad Halabi, was arrested by Israeli police in June 2016 and convicted in 2022 for siphoning off up to \$50 million and diverting it to Hamas. World Vision and its partisans, such as the European Union Delegation to the Palestinians and Amnesty International, have insisted on Mr. Halabi's

innocence and criticized the court proceedings.

Last year, Hamas traded Israeli hostages taken after Oct. 7, 2023, to get Mr. Halabi out of prison. Tim Costello, a former chief executive of World Vision Australia, said he was enormously relieved that Mr. Halabi gained his freedom and "burst into tears." Earlier this year, Israeli forces captured documents in Gaza that demonstrated both that Mr. Halabi was a Hamas operative and that Hamas worked to disrupt his trial, viewing it as a threat to their security.

More troubling still is World Vision's stiff-arm to Congress. Sen. Chuck Grassley (R., Iowa) sought answers about the Halabi affair in 2023, demanding access to an audit World Vision had ordered of itself. "Congress and the American people deserve transparency with respect to the steps World Vision has taken to ensure taxpayer money is used as intended and not for illegal activity," Mr. Grassley wrote. World Vision refused to hand over the audit, claiming that contractual obligations allowed the organization to make it available only to certain governments and administrative agencies, including the State Department.

Mr. Grassley's suspicions are grounded in his previous experience with the charity. An investigation headed by his office found that World Vision's operations in Sudan provided hundreds of thousands of dollars to the Islamic African Relief Agency, a Sudanese charity

that had funded the Taliban, Hamas and one of Osama bin Laden's organizations. Mr. Grassley's team found that World Vision was "borderline negligent" and "ignored elementary level investigative procedures" in allowing taxpayer dollars to go to the Islamic charity.

Other World Vision scandals include alleged involvement with several branches of the Popular Front for the Liberation

World Vision has a history of sloppy vetting to the benefit of terror groups.

of Palestine, another U.S.-designated terror organization, in 2012 and 2020 and alleged further dalliances with Hamas officials and other Hamas funding organizations throughout the years.

This has disturbed some officials in the administration. A senior official with the Office of Management and Budget took shots at the State Department, telling the Jerusalem News Syndicate that World Vision is "severely compromised," while the State Department's response was to repeat talking points that resembled those from World Vision's press releases.

Clearly, the Trump administration wants to repair relations with evangelicals and believes that funding foreign programs under the oversight

of Christian charities will help. But State Department officials have paid too little attention to World Vision's history of serious problems. Now officials are caught in a bind, with warring sections of the administration having a public fight over their chosen partner.

Nothing suggests that World Vision will behave differently this time around. Mr. Grassley's report on the charity's financial mishaps in Sudan expressed "reservations concerning World Vision's ability to avoid [similar] situations," given its "posture" during the investigation in which World Vision abjured responsibility, according to the report.

A new partnership with the dubious charity undercuts the administration's message that foreign-aid cuts and reform were necessary because such funds often go to terrorists and are prone to widespread fraud and abuse. Moreover, it will hurt the administration's relations with its hawkish pro-Israel supporters.

The State Department should reverse course. There are excellent reasons to restore slashed USAID funds, when aimed at the correct targets. There are also excellent reasons to put America's Christian organizations at the forefront of such charitable work. None of those reasons require working in partnership with an organization that has World Vision's history.

Mr. Smith is a lawyer and a former congressional staffer.

By Bob Greene

As summer enters its final laps, at last I have the answer to a question that has nagged at me for more than half a century.

As the 1950s made the turn to the 1960s, I attended a boys' summer camp in Wisconsin's North Woods. At Camp Golden Eagle, in Woodruff, Wis., all the usual activities were ours: baseball, archery, canoeing, swimming.

But one part of summer that most piqued our wide-eyed interest—that for all these years has felt like a dizzy dream—wasn't on the campgrounds at all.

Through the forest, out on a highway, was an A&W Root Beer stand. It wasn't like today's full-menu A&W restaurants—it sold root beer only, made fresh on the premises.

There was a rumor, passed down from older campers to younger ones. The root beer, we were told, had "a *liiiiittle* bit

of alcohol" in it. The word was always stretched out.

Forbidden fruit. We would sneak through the forest, to Highway 51. A&W is known for frosty glass mugs, but our root beers came in quart-sized waxy paper containers shaped like traffic cones.

We'd gulp down the contents, then sneak back into camp, convinced we were tipsy. In retrospect it was absurd, yet all summer we believed it. Maybe it was the word "beer" in "root beer." Some counselors, with straight faces, swore that the A in A&W stood for "alcohol."

Over the years, every time I would see an A&W sign, I would hear that old phrase in my head. This summer I read in the Indianola, Iowa, Independent Advocate that the town's A&W store was celebrating its 70th anniversary.

The owner—James McConnell, the fourth McConnell to run the place—didn't have the answer as to whether there re-

ally was a "*liiiiittle* bit of alcohol" back then. But I couldn't let another summer end without knowing.

I called A&W Restaurants' headquarters in Lexington, Ky. I reached the chairman, Kevin Bazner, 71, and started blathering on about Camp Golden Eagle and the stand on Highway 51.

Sixty summers later, I got to the bottom of a boys' camp tall tale.

He laughed and said instantly: "Your memory is correct." Not that the "*liiiiittle* bit of alcohol" was or is accurate: There has never been alcohol in A&W. But the rumor, he said, was once absolutely rampant nationwide among young A&W drinkers, including Mr. Bazner himself, growing up in Michigan in the '50s and '60s.

"Freshly made A&W, in

those glass mugs, had a foamy head, like draft beer," he said. A&W never promoted the rumor, but pre-social-media it passed from person to person, a whispered (and false) secret. "I can't even tell you how many times I've heard people say that," he told me.

So the "A" in A&W has nothing to do with alcohol?

"A&W was named for our founders, Roy Allen and Frank Wright," he said.

But who would cherish a fact so mundane? Camp Golden Eagle closed in 1985. Last summer a group of old campers returned to Woodruff for a reunion. Online, I found a video of their celebration.

Many are grandfatherly-looking. In the video several are at a picnic table, laughing merrily in the midst of some sort of imbibing competition.

The old campers are chugging cans of A&W.

Mr. Greene's books include the novel "All Summer Long."

BOOKSHELF | By John J. Miller

The Blade Looks Back

Impatience Is a Virtue

*By Mitch Daniels
Lyons, 600 pages, \$39.95*

Mitch Daniels was about to land his first job in Indiana politics. At the end of the interview, in 1971, his future boss made a crack to a colleague: "Have you checked his arrest record?"

It was no joke to Mr. Daniels, then 22. "I had prepared myself for that moment," he writes in his memoir, "Impatience Is a Virtue." A year earlier he had been, in his words, "scooped up in a local law enforcement marijuana crack-down." The young man came clean and confessed his crime to his fellow Republicans.

He still got the job and learned later that his interviewers had set him up, wanting to know if he'd own up to what they already knew. "I generally find it exaggerated and melodramatic when someone says that one event or moment changed the rest of their life," Mr. Daniels writes, but he insists that the claim is appropriate here.

"If I had not told the truth, completely and right on the spot, everything that followed would have been different." Everything that followed fills this detailed account of an accomplished career that brought Mr. Daniels to the brink of running for president. Amusing anecdotes and lessons strengthen an otherwise straightforward chronicle. During those early days of toiling for Republicans in Marion County, Ind., for example, Mr. Daniels learned the need to balance effective campaigning with the misguided expectations of politicians: "Billboard advertising is critical. You buy one giant board, between the candidate's house and the headquarters where you're sure he'll see it every day. And that's all you buy."

By 1977 Mr. Daniels was working in the office of Richard Lugar, a freshly elected Republican senator from the Hoosier State. "A Senate office was basically a personal PR firm," he notes, in an observation that is perhaps closer to the truth half a century later. Soon he became a political aide in the White House of Ronald Reagan. In the 1990s he joined the corporate world in an executive position at Eli Lilly. The pharmaceutical company was tangled in a public dispute over the allegedly harmful side effects of Prozac, its popular antidepressant. Mr. Daniels met with patient groups and journalists, in a successful effort to defend the drug. "I often wonder whether Prozac could have been saved in a social media world like today's," he writes. "I wouldn't want to fight that fight again now."

A decade later, Mr. Daniels was back in Washington, where he became director of the Office of Management and Budget under President George W. Bush. Mr. Daniels pushed for the administration's tax cuts of 2001 and their extension two years later. While he still supports them, he expresses "second thoughts" over what at the time was a major selling point: the removal of millions of Americans from the tax rolls. "By excusing so much of our population from taxation," he explains, "we have risked diminishing their sense of citizenship." He worries that, as voters, "they won't feel any stake in limiting government spending." He mentions that other countries have broad-based consumption taxes. "One day, we will need something similar."

After two terms championing free markets as Indiana’s governor, Mitch Daniels was faced with the biggest political decision of his life.

Mr. Daniels devotes the longest section of "Impatience Is a Virtue" to his election as governor of Indiana in 2004 and his two terms in that office. Known as a budget hawk—Mr. Bush had nicknamed him the Blade—Mr. Daniels searched for ways to reduce state spending. "You'd be amazed at how much government you'd never miss," he told audiences. He delivered school-choice scholarships, a right-to-work law and what he calls "the largest privatization of public infrastructure in America," involving the Indiana Toll Road.

Letting a for-profit company manage the toll road made so much fiscal sense to Mr. Daniels that he was surprised to run into resistance. "With all the facts, the data, the overwhelming public interest case for our transaction so plain, still we took vicious, often personal abuse," he recalls. He concluded that "any change or reform worth doing will bring criticism, generally in proportion to its importance." He admits that he developed "scar tissue." It may have played a part in persuading him to forgo his greatest political opportunity.

As Mr. Daniels neared the end of his second term as governor, many free-market conservatives encouraged him to pursue the presidency in 2012. Mr. Daniels reflects on several factors that went into his decision. Though he quips about his short stature and receding hairline, he moves on to a substantive point about policy: His strong views on entitlement reform and debt reduction, he recognizes, "continue even at this writing to be politically fatal." In addition, his wife and daughters "hated the idea." He let them exercise veto power.

"This biggest decision of my life was among the simplest," he writes. "I have never felt regret." Even so, it's hard not to read a later comment about the 2020s with a sense of wistfulness: "Until public revulsion at the degraded nature of our political system demands something better, a lot of highly capable people are likely to steer away from public life."

The man who wouldn't be president of the U.S. instead became president of Purdue University. For a decade, Mr. Daniels kept tuition in check, promoted free speech and intellectual diversity, and opened the campus to in-person teaching when many other schools resorted to pandemic lockdowns. Today he's 77, having turned his long-forgotten record of arrest into a solid record of achievement—and a legacy that will always include the question of what might have been.

Mr. Miller is director of the Dow Journalism Program at Hillsdale College and a Free Expression columnist for The Wall Street Journal.

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OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Data-Center Dividend for Workers

President Trump has drawn condemnation for suggesting that communities that block data centers will end up “backwards and poor.” His remark was hyperbolic, but he’s right that areas embracing data centers are enjoying more jobs and faster wage growth.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics last week published industry-level data on state and county employment and wages through March of this year. We compared growth in Loudoun County, Va.—known as Data Center Alley—with other Washington, D.C., suburbs since early 2020 before the pandemic. The disparities are striking.

Loudoun has long been a hub for data-center development because of its easy zoning, relatively low-cost energy and geographical proximity to telecom network exchanges. It’s an exurban county with more land for growth than older suburbs closer to D.C. But it has also embraced growth, unlike those older suburbs. Construction growth has accelerated amid the AI boom, with permitted data-center space increasing by some 150% between 2020 and 2025. Jobs have followed.

Most counties surrounding the capital have experienced little job growth since the pandemic. Loudoun is the exception, with employment surging 17.4% since early 2020. Jobs increased by 1% or less in Fairfax County, Va., and Prince George’s County, Md. Virginia’s Arlington County (-7.3%) and Maryland’s Montgomery County shed jobs (-5.6%).

Construction jobs increased 63% in Loudoun, far more than in Fairfax (6.3%), Arlington (8.2%), Prince George’s (8.3%), and Montgomery (a 12.8% decline). Job growth from data-center construction also appears to be having positive spillover labor effects in other industries. Employment in leisure and hospitality in-

creased 6.8% in Loudoun while declining in other D.C. suburbs since early 2020. Average weekly wage growth for leisure and hospitality workers in Loudoun over this period (69%) was double that in Fairfax (26%), Arlington (29%), Montgomery (31%) and Prince George’s (27%).

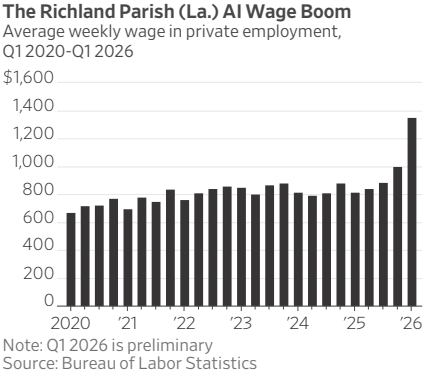
Building and operating data centers may have increased demand for blue-collar workers and bid up wages. Loudoun’s fast-growing workforce may have increased spending at restaurants and tips for hospitality workers. If more construction workers are grabbing drinks after shifts, bartenders make more money.

Loudoun’s prosperity isn’t an isolated example. Meta’s massive data-center project in Richland Parish in Louisiana is helping revive that poor, rural farming community. Since the first quarter of last year, private employment in Richland has grown 41%, and average weekly wages have shot up 61%. Neighboring parishes have experienced little or no growth.

In a single year, Richland’s construction workforce has risen more than 10-fold, with average weekly wages up 182%. That amounts to an annual \$86,000 pay increase for construction workers. Employment in leisure and hospitality has increased 21.5%, with average weekly wages in the industry soaring 34%.

While building data centers won’t provide lifetime employment, many workers will be needed to run and maintain them, as well as the plants that power them. Politicians in both parties fret that AI will increase the concentration of wealth and leave rural communities behind. Folks in Richland who are prospering probably don’t see it that way.

Data centers can help to spread prosperity without government intervention and income redistribution. Could that be the real reason America’s political class is turning against them?



A Murder in Times Square and a Sick Culture

The murder of Erin Piacenti, the junior Bank of America executive and new mother stabbed Monday in Times Square, should be inspiring tough questions. For one, why are the mentally disturbed left to wander the streets until a tragedy results? Instead an Oscar-nominated movie director has taken the occasion to celebrate the murder as some kind of anti-Israel assassination.

Lexi Alexander, a Palestinian-American director, shared news of the murder alongside a meme of Batman staring up at a bat signal with the face of Luigi Mangione, who murdered UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson. Ms. Alexander explained that she advocates a boycott of Bank of America. Apparently the bank had issued a “buy” recommendation for banks in Israel, whose economic performance has surpassed expectations.

How dare BoFA offer professional investment advice. “Israel doesn’t care about the woman who got killed, they care about the positive rating BoFA gave them in the middle of a genocide. There is huge money at stake,” Ms. Alexander averred on X. Which shows there is no conversation into which some people won’t shoehorn their anti-Israel derangement, and no low to which they won’t stoop.

The attacker seems to have had no political message. She stabbed another passerby and then advanced on police, who shot her dead. This is pure projection on the part of Ms. Alexander and the like-minded on social media.

It also suggests they know well what it means to “globalize the intifada”—and support it. In the Second Intifada (2000-05), Palestinian terrorists carried out random stabbings, shootings and bombings that killed some 700 Israeli civilians. New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani defended that slogan during his campaign, and only with the greatest reluctance did he ultimately “discourage” it.

Jews are about 10% of New York’s population, but they are the target of more than half of the city’s hate crimes. In 2026 the city has seen 229 confirmed anti-Jewish hate crimes, compared with 29 anti-black and 27 anti-Muslim. These increased the past year even as crime fell.

In a grim milestone, annual security spending by the U.S. Jewish community has passed \$1 billion, up 33% since 2024, says the Jewish Federations of North America. The average cost is some \$225,000 per institution—and rising—to allow for prayer or school attendance. It has become known as the antisemitism tax.

Handouts for Hollywood—Really?

The second Trump Presidency has taken some strange policy turns, and the latest example is Mr. Trump’s endorsement this week of a tax subsidy for Hollywood. Has the President lost the pro-growth tax plot that helped make his first term an economic hit?

“Congress should approve, immediately, a Federal Production Incentive to create Entertainment Jobs in America,” Mr. Trump wrote on social media. “It can be done quickly, accurately, efficiently and, importantly, will benefit ALL of America. What we watch on the Silver Screen should be made in what was once the Movie and Motion Picture Capital of the World.”

Well, no. A federal subsidy for entertainment production on its own won’t create many jobs or enhance U.S. prosperity. It will enrich large Hollywood producers and prop up industry unions, which have struck labor agreements that make the U.S. a less attractive place to shoot TV shows and movies.

It’s true that the share of films shot outside the U.S. has increased, though the overall amount of content has also grown. But the industry is also changing because streaming services provide a distribution platform for low-cost productions. Film makers no longer need large production companies, big crews or A-list stars to make a splash. Movie ticket sales have fallen some 40% since 2019, which makes it more challenging for studios to make money on expensive productions.

That’s one reason the U.S. motion picture and video industry has lost 106,300 jobs over the last four years, 63,400 of them since the beginning of the pandemic. These job losses have notably coincided with the expansion of state

tax incentives for film and TV production. More than three dozen states offer subsidies for the industry.

Adam Schiff and Donald Trump unite to subsidize the rich and famous.

New York’s tax credit covers 30% or more of production costs and is refundable—meaning producers get the money even if they don’t owe state tax. These subsidies are a form of income redistribution to a politically favored industry, and not a poor one. New York last year spent \$1.2 billion on production subsidies, which is more than twice as much as the revenue generated by its congestion tax on drivers entering Manhattan’s business district. Yet the state has been bleeding entertainment production jobs since 2022.

California awards \$750 million in tax credits a year—more than double what it did in 2019—yet it has lost 19,200 production jobs. Mr. Trump has a point that “Hollywood is a Complete and Total Disaster! Despite the name, it is getting very little work. There is no incentive to be there.” But businesses of all types are leaving La La Land because of its high costs.

We wonder if Mr. Trump knows that the main champion of Hollywood handouts in Congress is California Sen. Adam Schiff, his impeachment nemesis. Press reports say Paramount Skydance CEO David Ellison has also lobbied for this corporate welfare. Why should taxpayers underwrite Mr. Ellison’s business or Jeffrey Katzenberg’s films?

Mr. Trump’s 2017 tax reforms were successful because they were largely neutral and encouraged long-term investment. A production tax credit would provide a short-term stimulus for one industry, which primarily supports Democrats. The idea deserves to die on Congress’s cutting-room floor.

How Monopolistic Accreditors Enforce Ideology

The American Bar Association unfortunately isn’t alone in having an accreditation monopoly (“Busting the ABA’s Accreditation Monopoly,” Review & Outlook, Aug. 29). The same is true for many other organizations, including the American Psychological Association Commission on Accreditation, whose status as an accreditor is now up for renewal. Like the American Bar Association, the American Psychological Association is a professional association with an in-house accreditation arm. And, like the ABA, the APA temporarily suspended its DEI standards in 2025. But suspension isn’t the same as removal, and the Education Department is right to see to it that these standards are eliminated, as has been done by accreditors for schools of medicine, podiatry and optometry.

Worse, however, are accreditors unaccountable to the department. Take the Council on Social Work Education. Its standards are riddled with

DEI, including competencies aimed at ensuring social workers “demonstrate anti-racist and anti-oppressive” practice. In fact, in its most recent accreditation standards, those terms come up more than 10 times each. Yet, as a programmatic accreditor, CSWE doesn’t need the Education Department to grant its authority. Rather, it’s baked into state law or regulations—a fact CSWE doesn’t hide, noting that in most states one must graduate from a CSWE-accredited program to get licensed or even sit for the licensing exam.

Breaking these monopolies will need to go beyond what the Education Department can do. States need to take action by introducing competition, thereby ending the days of monopolistic accreditors and their ideological requirements serving as prerequisites for professional licensure.

STANLEY GOLDFARB, M.D.
*Do No Harm
Bryn Mawr, Pa.*

Accountability for New York’s Reckless Bikers

Regarding your editorial “Bring Your Crash Helmet to New York City” (Aug. 15): On June 22 of this year, while walking on the sidewalk in the East Village, I was struck head-on by a motorbike, pinning me to the doorway of an apartment building. Incapacitated with injuries and painting the sidewalk red with my blood, I looked up at the rider. He responded with expletives and reminded me that the accident was my fault before ripping the throttle on his motorbike and taking off. The rider made it clear that this type of behavior is acceptable and expected in today’s New York City.

Broken bones and torn ligaments aside, what was particularly frustrating about my accident was what happened afterward. Camera footage of

the accident was available and obtained, and the suspect’s unusual clothing that evening could have made him identifiable. Yet the New York Police Department closed the investigation, suggesting a police department that doesn’t have the resources to hold criminals accountable and is influenced by a mayoral administration that allows this problem go unaddressed.

The responding officers, and others I’ve pressed on the issue, have all delivered to me messages to this effect: “City Hall doesn’t let me do my job anymore.” Or: “Our hands are tied.”

I hope that my story, along with others, can help bring about the safe New York we all deserve.

BRIAN FOX
New York

A Return to Sound Money Will Fix Inflation

Regarding your editorial “The Hawk at Jackson Hole” (Aug. 29): Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh’s Jackson Hole speech correctly acknowledges that inflation remains the Federal Reserve’s central failure. But the solution requires more than adjusting the federal-funds rate upward or downward.

Today, the federal-funds rate is roughly comparable to the annual increase in the Consumer Price Index. That means holders of short-term Treasury securities are receiving little or no real return before taxes—and a negative real return after paying income taxes on their nominal interest income. Savers are still being penalized by inflation and taxation.

The Fed should stop trying to micromanage the price of money by targeting interest rates. Instead, it should stop expanding the money supply and allow short-term interest rates to reflect supply and demand in money markets, just as long-term interest rates are determined by market participants. Ending monetary manipulation would go a long way toward slaying the inflation dragon.

But Mr. Warsh should go further. America needs to restore a gold-backed dollar. Sound money would impose an institutional constraint on the creation of money and protect Americans from the continual

erosion of purchasing power.

With sound money and rising productivity, the economy could experience the natural, benign deflation of falling prices that accompanies technological progress. Productivity gains would then translate directly into higher living standards for all Americans—not merely into higher nominal incomes chasing ever-rising prices.

MURRAY SABRIN, PH.D.
*Associated scholar, Mises Institute
Naples, Fla.*

Regulation by Litigation Is A Poor Way to Make Policy

Your editorial “Meta’s Sensible Settlement” (Aug. 27) touches on a point my organization has made for decades: Regulation through litigation is no substitute for long-lasting legislation. Policy affecting an entire industry should be developed and enacted by elected lawmakers—not negotiated midtrial between trial lawyers and technology companies in an Oakland courtroom.

This is a pattern, not an anomaly. Trial lawyers have used the same playbook to target opioids, tobacco and other industries: sue repeatedly for big settlements, but leave the underlying problem untouched. That’s not real reform. That’s headlines, a big dollar figure, and new rules for one company or industry.

It’s up to legislators to solve problems in a way that serves society’s interests, including protecting both our children and American innovation. This settlement lets lawmakers and other public officials dodge their responsibility to do their jobs. But it’s a stopgap the plaintiffs’ bar prefers, because legislation is something they don’t control and can’t profit from. A settlement allows them to do both.

SHERMAN “TIGER” JOYCE
*American Tort Reform Association
Washington*

Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.



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“What do you have that pairs well with obituaries?”

OPINION

America Needs Its Boys to Play Football

By Ben Sasse

Full is here, football is back, and America's boys need to play it and be shaped by it. As the son of a football coach, I'm admittedly biased. As a dad who has spent the past month driving a high-school freshman to two-a-day, often 100-degree practices, I'm deliriously invested. But you don't have to be a football fanatic to grasp that today, for 12- to 18-year-old boys, this sport has

The sport forms character by harnessing masculinity and directing it toward the good and the pure.

never been more important. While controversy surrounds the embarrassingly blurry line between college football and the National Football League, our culture needs to take a moment to commend and steward the glorious tradition of high-school football. Across cultures and time, four major institutions have formed young men: family, religion, work and war. By demanding effort and sacrifice, each of these molded boys into men. Parents raised sons to be husbands and fathers. Scriptures demanded grappling with human nature, sin and salvation. Work looked at needs, and forged character and grit. War—or more broadly, the obligation to protect your community—harnessed strength as service. Today, war and work have faded.

Thankfully, violence has been pushed to the periphery of most societies to a degree ancient and medieval people never conceived possible. The world is still dangerous and humanity still capable of unspeakable evil, but most neighborhoods bear little resemblance to lawless frontiers of old. Our continental nation is blessed with good neighbors and big oceans, and most violence is constrained through ordered liberty. This isn't cheap: The men and women who defend us pay a steep price. There's always the risk of imagining peace is the natural, autopilot order of things, rather than a stunning achievement that requires ongoing vigilance. But it's a blessing that less than 1% of the population serves in America's all-volunteer military. Unfortunately, work has also faded as a formative experience. When I was growing up in Nebraska, detasseling corn was a rite of passage. We woke at 4:30 a.m. to slog through fields from cold morning dew through to blazing midday heat. Today, that Cornhusker tradition has been rendered all but extinct by new technologies. Farm country isn't the only place this is happening. Teenage work has been evaporating across the nation since the 1980s. Only 35% of teenagers had a summer job this year. Technology is on pace to eliminate many remaining starter jobs like flipping burgers and running checkouts. This is economic reality, and on the whole it leads to greater prosperity, but we should acknowledge the trade-off. As war and work have faded, two new institutions have filled the void: bureaucratized schooling and



Tackling dummies at Boise City Elementary School in Boise City, Okla.

digital media. On net, both are developments for the worse. Institutionalized childhood is soul-crushing. In the early 20th century, we industrialized nearly everything, but a great way to manufacture cars is a rotten way to shape souls. An acorn doesn't become an oak on an assembly line. Factory-model education keeps young men passive, indoors, and on "receive" mode. Kids are naturally inquisitive, but modern schooling is too often designed to anesthetize curiosity. The doom scroll makes matters worse. Digital media has a profoundly negative effect on young men. Temptations to distraction and addiction are real. According to the Institute for Family Studies, 27% of men 18 to 29 are daily porn consumers, and almost as many now gamble daily. They are withdrawing from the real world into loneliness and helplessness. Sixty-

one percent report feeling "little control over the things that happen" in their lives. That's a slow-burning crisis. Young men need to celebrate and harness strength. Toxic masculinity isn't the entirety of masculinity. We need young men full of energy, ambition and growing self-mastery. Society needs strong men. Football is a character-forming institution that channels strength. In a world of instant gratification, it teaches perseverance through early practices and aching muscles. In an era of isolation, football creates community. It forms brotherhood through both misery and joy. In a culture of passivity, football privileges action. In times of peace, football prepares us for war. Football simultaneously celebrates and constrains violence. It teaches the difference between boyhood and manhood, between self-

indulgence and self-restraint. Football done right creates the conditions for less, rather than more, violence in bars. For four quarters, offense, defense and special teams inflict maximum damage within the precisely bounded parameters of the game. When guided by seasoned coaches, football punishes hits after the whistle. It prohibits targeting defenseless receivers. It shames bullying in the locker room. It scorns those who won't shake hands with an opponent postgame. To harness the necessary violence properly, teams ingrain virtues of delayed gratification and self-sacrifice. That's the value of one more rep on the bench when your head wants to give up but your muscles haven't given out. That's the reward for the pain of development. Young men, faced with a choice to strive and suffer on behalf of teammates, build virtue not chiefly through deliberation but through action. Football forms and honors such habits. The Apostle Paul never picked up a blitz. He never recovered an inside kick. But he taught that suffering produces perseverance, and perseverance produces character. And that's something that will be rightly cheered under Friday night lights all across the country this fall. Paul was in the more important business of saving souls. The gridiron offers no eternal comfort, but East of Eden we'll always need strong and selfless men. That's why we owe our boys football.

Mr. Sasse is a columnist for the *Journal* and our *Free Expression* newsletter. He served as a U.S. senator from Nebraska, 2015-23.

Tolstoy's Debt Crisis: Each Country Unhappy in Its Own Way



POLITICAL ECONOMICS
By Joseph C. Sternberg

Misery loves company, so enjoy the global pity party that's developing over governments' fiscal distress. America's \$40 trillion debt load is only the start. Britain's national debt, at £3 trillion (\$4 trillion), or 94% of gross domestic product, has become a political crisis for Prime Minister Andy Burnham, and he's been in office barely six weeks. His administration is getting rocked by government borrowing rates at their highest in decades (and higher than during the short, unhappy premiership of Liz Truss in 2022)—toxic in an economy with fairly rapid pass-through from government bond yields to mortgage rates. In France, economists on the left now speculate about whether the European Central Bank could simply forgive some portion of the French government bonds it holds. It's a manifestly silly idea, but you can't fault the French some levity when laboring under a national debt of €3.5 trillion (\$4 trillion), or

117% of GDP. And looming over it all, Japan's national debt, generally figured at around 230% of GDP, remains the world economy's greatest imponderable. Think of this as Tolstoy's debt crisis: Each country is unhappy in its own way. The taxonomy is instructive. Britain in theory has the political capacity to fix its public finances, but its political class professes to be desperately short of ideas on how to do so. Mr. Burnham sits atop a large majority of seats in Parliament for his Labour Party. He came to office by displacing an unpopular predecessor, Keir Starmer, and in his first weeks basked in an unusually intense honeymoon phase. Britain's efficient system of legislating should give Mr. Burnham ample running room to pursue an agenda. Moreover, opinion polls regularly suggest voters trust Labour more than its opponents such as the Conservative Party on matters touching the welfare state, furnishing Labour with the credibility needed to enact fiscally necessary reforms of social programs if Mr. Burnham wanted to. But he doesn't want to. Mr. Burnham's Labour noisily campaigns

against the economic-reform agenda of Margaret Thatcher (who hasn't been prime minister for nearly 36 years and has been dead for 13). Despite occasional vague murmurs about very limited social-welfare reforms, Mr. Burnham doesn't sound like a politician who intends to shrink the rolls and push more adults back into work. His administration instead is

The U.S. has an unlikely advantage: Social Security is running out of money, which will force a reform.

likely to float some tax increases this autumn, and to renege on promises of future defense spending, and then they'll be out of ideas. What a waste of Mr. Burnham's political good fortune, as bond investors have opined in real time this week. France suffers nearly the opposite problem. Ample low-hanging reform fruit is available for any politician who wants to pluck it. A signature

example is pension reform, and in particular an increase in the retirement age from 62 to 64, as President Emmanuel Macron has attempted. Mr. Macron draws a lot of flak (including in this column) for his imperious political method. But his problem has never been a shortage of viable economic and fiscal ideas. He has even chalked up some successes, including a reform of France's byzantine labor laws. Rather, France's political system on a fundamental level is incapable of implementing most reforms, and one starts to suspect this is only partly a consequence of Mr. Macron's own failures as a politician. The systemic problem seems to be that most French politicians can see that a crash of some sort is coming sooner or later. Yet France's size and deep integration into the European economy—and particularly the euro currency—allow Paris to keep delaying its moment of reckoning. No politician or party other than Mr. Macron therefore wants to be the first to make any sacrifices in service of a reform agenda. A fractious national legislature absolves anyone of the responsibility of trying. Most advanced economies fall

into one of these camps. Japan under Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi suffers the British disease of political capacity devoid of ideas. German Chancellor Friedrich Merz has plenty of good ideas, but like Mr. Macron the German leader finds it all but impossible to push most of them through a fractured legislature that lacks a sense of urgency about fiscal and economic reforms. You'll be relieved (or not) to hear that the U.S. probably is the exception, although not as a result of any great virtue. Left to its own devices, Washington would most nearly resemble the French model of ample reform thinking with limited ability to implement anything. But we do have the happy accident of a rapidly depleting so-called trust fund for Social Security, our single largest entitlement and driver of so much of our overspending. After that fund is gone in 2032—if not sooner—Congress will address in some manner the fiscal drag of an expanding entitlement burden or the program will fix itself by cutting benefits by more than 20%. Most countries stumble into fiscal crises. We've scheduled ours. Talk about American exceptionalism.

By Rahm Emanuel

It has been 30 years since Sen. Daniel Patrick Moynihan (D., N.Y.) predicted that President Clinton's welfare-reform plan would leave "children sleeping on grates, picked up in the morning frozen." Instead, child poverty fell from 27.9% in 1993 to 9.8% in 2024. We should launch a new campaign to halve child poverty again by applying the lessons of Mr. Clinton's successful approach and rejecting both parties' biases. Over the past 30 years, those on the right have credited the decline in child poverty entirely to the work requirements in the 1996 law, based on their retrograde view that the best antidote to poverty is a swift kick in the pants. But there are also those on the left who are so resistant to change—those who refuse to acknowledge the pathology of dependency—that they credit the nation's progress entirely to other Clinton-era reforms, including increasing the

minimum wage, establishing the child tax credit, expanding the earned-income tax credit, creating the Children's Health Insurance Program and generally facilitating a strong economy that created more than 20 million new jobs by 1999. None of these individual changes can reasonably be judged alone. Mr. Clinton began with a comprehensive goal—reducing child poverty—and while the 1996 law was the crown jewel of that campaign, his was a whole-administration effort to make work pay. He disagreed with many congressional Democrats who favored an ever-larger safety net over helping vulnerable Americans gain independence; he vowed to make welfare "a second chance, not a way of life." But Mr. Clinton also opposed the GOP's efforts to penalize the poor as if poverty were a choice. He vetoed one reform bill because, as he wrote to Congress, it "cut deeply into Medicare, Medicaid, student loans, and nutrition programs." He vetoed a

second because it failed to "provide sufficient child care to enable recipients to leave welfare for work," to "reward States for placing people in jobs" and to "restore the guarantee of health coverage for poor families," among other objections. The results of Mr. Clinton's approach, a strategy that amounted to more than the sum of its parts, are now evident. Those of us who want to reduce child poverty further can learn a lot from his approach. One important lesson: The cultural dimension matters as much as the economic. To claim the vital center—Arthur M. Schlesinger Jr.'s term for setting aside each side's ideological preconditions—the president wanted both to ensure that work was rewarded and to discourage a life of dependency. Democrats shouldn't scoff at the cultural importance of every child having an answer to his teacher's question "What do your parents do for work?" Rather than simply argue for no-strings-attached benefits, we should strengthen the lower rungs on the socioeconomic ladder. Here are four ways: First, ensure that the minimum wage is \$20 an hour by 2030. If Republicans want more people to work, they should make work pay. Second, to augment privately earned income, combine, simplify and expand the child tax credit and the earned-income tax credit into a single family credit. The current tax credits practically require citizens to become PwC-level tax accountants to fill out all the paperwork. As a congressman and later as mayor, I regularly sponsored workshops to help Chicagoans fill it out. And neither tax credit has reached its full potential for poverty reduction. Adopting Rep. Kristen McDonald Rivet's (D., Mich.) bill to double the earned-income tax credit

for qualifying families with children under 4 would reduce child poverty by 7%. And moving toward former Sen. Mitt Romney's (R., Utah) proposal to make a fully refundable child tax credit would help us attend to children in poverty who lost an important resource when President Biden's expanded child tax credit expired. On this front, we should also learn

His program—both welfare cuts and new benefits—is a model of how to set aside partisanship to help kids.

from the success of welfare reform's incentive programs and provide bonuses to families whose kids are in attendance on 95% of school days during a year. That would end Covid-era absenteeism while supporting families in need. Simplifying the tax code should make Republicans happy, even as Democrats would support raising working families' incomes. But here's a sweetener: To secure the new, combined family credit, Congress should name it after Ronald Reagan, who called the 1986 tax reform bill, which contained an earned-income tax credit, "the best anti-poverty bill, the best pro-family measure, and the best job-creation program to ever come out of the Congress of the United States." Third, expand and improve early childhood education, ensuring that programs like Head Start are more than glorified babysitting. We discovered in Chicago that the education benefits of pre-K for 3- and 4-year-olds who attended full-day programs were much improved over those who

attended half-day or not at all. To that end, we should establish benchmarks for educational development—letters, colors, numbers, etc.—and reward those programs that are most successful at imbuing kids with foundational knowledge that will pay lifelong dividends. Fourth, extend federal healthcare coverage to ensure work isn't penalized, similar to the way the 1996 welfare-reform law did. An untold story of the Clinton presidency is that the White House worried that if poor parents found jobs, their children would abruptly lose Medicaid benefits. To obviate that concern, Mr. Clinton insisted that Republicans allow for a yearlong Medicaid transition. The GOP acquiesced after he vetoed the two bills that lacked that guarantee. Future reforms should embrace the same ethos, ensuring that every low-income family is covered for three years after finding employment. Our aim should be to write a new chapter similar to the one Mr. Clinton wrote 30 years ago. America should be a nation where free enterprise works for everyone. Even in the face of economic headwinds, artificial-intelligence displacement, inflation, budget deficits and more—Washington can do more to help wage-earners propel themselves up the ladder. That's what Mr. Clinton meant when he vowed to put people first. We should aspire to build on his achievements with a new campaign against child poverty. Mr. Emanuel, a Democrat, served as a senior adviser to the president (1993-98), U.S. representative from Illinois (2003-09), White House chief of staff (2009-10), mayor of Chicago (2011-19) and ambassador to Japan (2022-25).

SPORTS



JASON GAY

Steve Ballmer and the Clippers

Get the NBA’s Doomsday Hammer

The league delivers a devastating blow to Los Angeles’s B-side basketball franchise



There’s something bleakly comical about it: The sleek, rebranded Clippers, re-sentenced to roam the earth as the sad, old Clippers.

As in one of the most moribund sports teams in history, chronically traumatized and championship-deprived.

Steve Ballmer tried to change that. The Microsoft mogul rode into the NBA in 2014 as an energetic savior, paying a then-spectacular \$2 billion for a sidekick franchise with a dumpy rep and a toxic owner.

Ballmer upgraded everything: the vibes, the leadership, the roster, the merch, and the facilities, culminating with a tech-tastic arena where his team didn’t have to sleep on a pull-out couch as the Lakers ruled the roost.

He installed himself courtside, the Windows Clippy among the die-hards, leaping from his seat after dunks and wiggling like one of those inflatable tubes at a car wash.

The Clippers would never be the fancy Lakers, but if you were willing to believe, they could be the cool cousin.

Now it’s back to the gloom. On Wednesday, the NBA dropped an anvil on Clipperland as it penalized the team for what it said were repeated salary-cap violations by engineering additional income opportunities for soon-to-be former star Kawhi Leonard.

The Clippers will lose five consecutive first-round draft picks,



Kawhi Leonard, left never delivered a title that Los Angeles Clippers owner Steve Ballmer, above, craved. Leonard is expected to go play for the Toronto Raptors.

from 2029 to 2033. The team’s president of business operations, Gillian Zucker, is suspended for a year. Basketball ops president Lawrence Frank is out for six months.

Ballmer is banned from all league activities for a year. The Clippers are also fined \$30 million—tip money, but still. Leonard, meanwhile, was hit with a \$700,000 tab, but who really cares. Held up in a trade, he’s expected to now go play for Toronto.

For the Clippers, it’s devastating. The draft pick losses are a future-suffocating hit on a team that was already amid a reset. A franchise that desperately worked to

be relevant seems doomed to irrelevance once more.

The Clippers are howling in protest, vehemently rejecting the league’s conclusions and stating they’ve been railroaded by a “heavily biased investigation seeking to justify a predetermined narrative.” They haven’t budged from Ballmer’s original defense, that the team did nothing improper or in violation of cap rules, and had nothing to hide.

It’s gotten nasty and very expensive. The whole affair seems destined for a court, and not one with a 3-point line.

Kudos appear to be in order to the journalist Pablo Torre, whose podcast triggered the NBA’s inves-

tigation. For months, Torre endured a good amount of skepticism that maybe he’d gotten over his skis. Even Wednesday, the Clippers sneerily referenced “podcast allegations” as if they came from a catfish in a swamp and not a show which had already won a Pulitzer for the work.

Torre got to enjoy hiding in the rafters and watching his own Tom Sawyer-style funeral a couple of weeks ago, when ESPN dropped a report that the league had “no evidence” that the Clippers “funneled” money to Leonard. The know-it-alls and told-ya-so’s piled on. There’s a semantic debate we can have about the word “funneled,” but that glee looks rather goofy now.

The league’s investigation, run by the law firm Wachtell, Rosen, Lipton & Katz, both validated and expanded significantly upon Torre’s work, concluding that, acting at the urging of Leonard’s representative, the team had engaged

in a “pattern of misconduct” in initiating and facilitating additional income opportunities for Leonard. (The investigation also determined the Clippers paid numerous personal expenses for Leonard, like travel—another no-no.)

The endorsement opportunities were an odd jumble. Aspiration, an environmentally-conscious bank which imploded in scandal. A digital signage outfit. An insurance company. Boingo Wireless, which made me scream in airplane seat 34F many times.

All these companies had business with the Clippers, and the league contends that they entered into arrangements with Leonard in order to preserve Clippers business.

If you’re sitting here and wondering, *who cares, all these guys make zillions*, here’s why it’s a problem: Arranging additional payments violates the salary cap, an essential part of the NBA’s competitive ecosystem and the reason that the same teams don’t dominate the league every single year.

The Wachtell report also does a sly job of establishing what we all kind of knew: these Leonard deals never made much sense. Leonard is a sublime basketball player when he’s healthy enough to play, but he’s not a charismatic personality or a historically in-demand spokesperson. The idea that all of these Clipper-adjacent companies would independently come to the conclusion that they needed to be in the Kawhi business is maybe the funniest part of this entire episode.

Still, it’s a little stunning how hard the NBA has swung the hammer. We’re conditioned to be cynical about these sorts of league investigations, that the dog very rarely catches the bumper, and if it does, the bite is timid. Leagues are run in service of franchise owners; the whole apparatus is designed to protect the brand aka the valuations. Even Torre thought Ballmer could escape with a mild tap on the wrist.

This isn’t a tap on the wrist. This is Armageddon. The league has punted the Clippers into oblivion for actions that amounted to very little.

Leonard never delivered a title that Ballmer craved; often, he barely played at all. A deal to obtain Leonard a wingman, Paul George, cost the Clippers multiple picks and a young player, Shai Gilgeous-Alexander, who would go on to be a two-time MVP in Oklahoma City.

And yet the Clippers were at least in the mix. Now they’re being told to skulk back to their old, haunted past. Say a prayer for their fans, collaterally damaged by it all. Hard enough already to be a Clipper fan. Now this?

There are those wondering if the fury will prompt Ballmer to sell, if he’ll see an opportunity to grab an easy few billion, but Ballmer needs an easy few billion like my cat needs a baritone sax. This team had become his identity, his joy, his odyssey. Not being able to wiggle courtside for a year is a rough, personal blow.

Then again, a worse penalty may be watching what the Clippers become.

MARK J. TERRILL/AP (2)

The Renegade Coach

Going to Battle With College Football

By ROBERT O’CONNELL

FROM THE MOMENT Lane Kiffin arrived at LSU, one thing was certain: College football’s most controversial coach would start making enemies. But what nobody knew at the time was that Kiffin’s target in his first year in Baton Rouge wouldn’t be a rival coach or an opposing fan base.

Kiffin would be going to war with college football itself.

In recent weeks, Kiffin has enraged nearly every stakeholder in the sport with an audacious plan. He was going to bring players back from NFL training camps to fill out the Tigers’ roster. And on Thursday afternoon, just two days before LSU’s marquee season opener against Clemson, a Louisiana judge listened to arguments about whether the former pros will be allowed to suit up.

“This is the most emotion-packed, high-profile, dramatic legal battle in the history of college sports,” said Tom Mars, an attorney who specializes in tussling with the NCAA but isn’t involved in this case.

As of Thursday afternoon, the particular issue in question was the legality of an SEC rule—a di-

rect response to Kiffin’s play—that deems players who have gone through the pro draft process ineligible to compete. But the broader reality is that college football’s power brokers have drawn a line in the sand, with institutions and conferences across the country insisting that players swapping NFL helmets for college ones is a bridge too far.

On the other side of that line stands Kiffin, boldly sticking by his plan while the rest of the college football world heaps scorn on him.

“If you want to win at the highest level,” a graphic posted at LSU’s team facility this week read, “you have to become a villain in someone else’s story.”

The standoff between Kiffin and just about everyone else in the sport began in earnest just last week, when LSU agreed to sign Dae’Quan Wright, a former Ole Miss tight end who joined the Cleveland Browns for training camp. Kiffin was emboldened to do so when a restraining order from a Louisiana judge said players denied a fifth year of eligibility could return to college, even if they’d suited up for NFL preseason games. Kiffin, who has



Lane Kiffin finds himself in the middle of an eligibility fight.

since added another NFL returnee, wasn’t the only coach to go this route. But he was the most prominent and vocal.

“They’re either gonna play for you or they’re gonna play somewhere else around the country,” Kiffin said. “So we made a decision to recruit them.”

That was just the opening salvo. Within days, all of college sports’ major conferences adopted policies against such players returning, essentially enforcing the NCAA’s original rule.

“College athletes, not former professional athletes, have been at the heart of the Southeastern Con-

ference,” the SEC said in a statement. “Individuals who choose to leave college athletics, sign professional contracts, and compete professionally should not then be permitted to return to college competition.”

With only a few days left before the start of the season, Kiffin and LSU at large are gaming out both ongoing legal proceedings and the broader implications.

Internally, according to a person familiar with the matter, key members of LSU’s athletic department are discussing whether adding two players to the roster is worth incurring the hatred of

their peers, as well as the potential sanctions and penalties that could stem from future rulings. When the SEC announced its own penalties for colleges that bring back professional players, they included a half-season suspension for a head coach and a fine totaling 50% of the athletic department’s operating budget.

Mars, who has helped several players regain their eligibility in cases against the NCAA, said that even if Kiffin’s NFL returnees were allowed to play on Saturday, later appeals could leave the school open to retroactive penalties.

“It’s the most one-sided risk/reward ratio I’ve ever seen,” Mars said.

Elsewhere, college coaches are lining up to take shots at Kiffin even before the games have kicked off.

Dabo Swinney, who will be leading Clemson against LSU on Saturday, didn’t beat around the bush.

“I just think it’s embarrassing where we are with college football,” Swinney said. “No pun intended, we just stay in our ‘lane,’ here at Clemson.”

HILARY SCHENK/THE ADVOCATE/AP

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VW Shakes Up U.S. Leadership

Automaker's North American chief exits after fewer than two years in role

By **STEPHEN WILMOT**

Volkswagen wants to make a fresh start in the U.S.—again. The German automaker is shaking up its North American leadership for the second time in less than two years after President Trump's tariff and electric-vehicle policies collided with the company's plans for the large, lucrative U.S. market.

Volkswagen said Wednesday that veteran company executive Marco Schubert would take responsibility for its business in North America starting in October. Current boss Kjell Gruner, who joined Volkswagen in December 2024 after a stint at electric-vehicle startup Rivian, is leaving the company, it said.

The management change marks the latest attempt by the world's second-largest carmaker to revive its underpowered American business, as it continues to struggle in other parts of the world. Volkswagen's once-lucrative business in China has fallen prey to local competitors. In Europe, it is cutting tens of thousands of jobs and closing or repurposing factories.

In a sign of the company's determination to fix its problems in North America, Schubert, unlike his predecessor, will report directly to Chief Executive Oliver Blume.

"We will intensify our commitment in the most important growth market for the Volkswagen Group," Blume said in a statement.

The U.S.—with about 16 million total annual vehicle sales



The U.S.-made ID.4 and the imported ID.Buzz electric vehicles struggled to find traction even before Trump withdrew subsidies.

and a large potential for profit—has eluded Volkswagen for decades.

Sales of its namesake brand peaked in 1970, the heyday of the Beetle and the Bus, before it was overtaken by Japanese rivals that proved better at adapting to evolving American tastes.

While the company has recovered some ground this century, particularly with its luxury brands Audi and Porsche, its group market share in North America hovers around 4%, far below its dominant position in other markets.

The past 18 months have been particularly tough. With just one small U.S. factory in

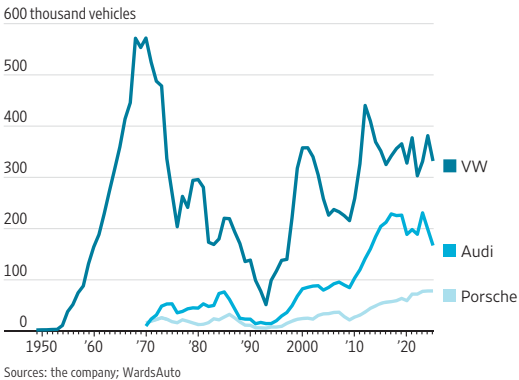
Chattanooga, Tenn., Volkswagen imports most of the vehicles it sells in the U.S., making it one of the automakers worst affected by Trump's trade policies. The company estimates the annual hit to its business at the equivalent of \$5.8 billion.

Volkswagen's group sales in the U.S. fell by around 14% last year, and another 7% in the first half of 2026 compared with the prior-year period.

"Our cars are becoming more expensive and therefore increasingly difficult to sell, not because they have become inferior but because the rules

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Volkswagen Group sales in the U.S., key brands



Sources: the company; WardsAuto

Stocks, Bonds Rally on Dovish Rate Talk

By **SHRADHA DINESH**

Stocks climbed and global bond yields retreated after Federal Reserve Governor Christopher Waller said he would support holding interest rates steady if August inflation data supports it.

The rally was broad, with all but three S&P 500 sectors in the green. Financials and consumer-discretionary stocks led gains, ending the session up more than 1.5%. Every Magnificent Seven company ended higher. **Robinhood**, **Coinbase**, **Palantir** and **ServiceNow** were among the S&P 500's biggest winners.

Major indexes opened higher after Waller suggested he would support holding rates steady at the central bank's meeting in two weeks if inflation data continue their recent progress. "Recent data suggest we are finally seeing some signs of disinflation," Waller said at a Reuters event. "If this continues in the data due over the next two weeks, I would be inclined to support holding the target for the federal-funds rate at its current setting."

The comments relieved some pressure on the bond market, where a recent climb in yields—which rise when prices fall—had rattled investors worldwide. Treasury yields retreated, with the 10-year yield settling at 4.761%, down from 2026 highs near 4.8% hit in recent days. The odds of a Fed rate hike this month are

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Marc Stad, the founder of Dragoner Investment Group, is acquiring a controlling stake in the Minnesota Timberwolves.

More Investors Hunt For AI-Proof Assets

By **KATE CLARK**

Venture capital is usually associated with moonshot technology bets. Lately, though, some venture investors have found new, more analog pursuits: sports teams, iconic real estate and even children's toys.

Investors are looking for opportunities insulated from the AI boom, including businesses built around human experiences that ChatGPT can't replace.

Josh Kushner, founder of investment firm Thrive Capital, is among the investors who have recently acquired stakes in some of the U.S.'s leading sports franchises, including the San Francisco Giants and a \$12.5 billion deal that made the Los Angeles Lakers the most valuable sports team ever.

Jeff Bezos is part of a consortium of investors participating in a deal to buy a minority stake in the Liverpool Football Club in the U.K., alongside Facebook co-founder Eduardo Saverin, valuing the team at more than \$7 billion. Marc Stad, the founder of Dragoner Invest-

ment Group, is acquiring a controlling stake in the Minnesota Timberwolves and a group led by venture capitalist and OpenAI backer Vinod Khosla is acquiring the Seattle Seahawks.

These teams are scarce assets with durable fan bases and predictable media-rights revenue and can provide wealthy investors with significant tax advantages.

Some venture firms are betting that sports teams are less vulnerable to the quick pace of AI development that has threatened to upend parts of the software, legal and financial industries.

"People want to watch actual real humans play sports," said Sudeep Ramnani, founder of 885 Capital, an investor in Professional Fighters League, a mixed-martial-arts league. "It makes sense in the context of how the world is changing."

Some investors expect the new wealth generated by the AI boom to fuel greater spending on live experiences, luxury travel, real estate and physical products.

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Some venture firms bet that sports teams are less vulnerable.

New TV Shows Take Aim at Big Tech

By **JOE FLINT**

Hollywood is taking on Big Tech with one of the oldest weapons around—pen and paper.

A crop of new television shows are questioning whether the innovators once heralded as making the world a better place have traded lofty virtuous ambitions for profits and power.

CBS's upcoming legal drama "Cupertino," premiering next month, portrays tech giants as Goliaths against a team of scrappy attorneys taking up the causes of those wronged by them. When its main character, played by Mike Colter, considers suing after being cut out of a startup he co-founded, his lawyer warns him what he is up against.

"This is Silicon Valley. It's David and Goliath and the Goliaths protect each other here," the lawyer says, rattling off companies such as Apple, Google, Facebook and OpenAI. "If you sue, you'll never work around here."



CBS's legal drama 'Cupertino' stars Rachel Keller as Olivia Siffre and Mike Colter as Michael Price.

"Cupertino" is just the latest example. The dark satire "The Audacity," which is about an ambitious founder's increasingly toxic and boundary-shattering relationship with his therapist, became a hit for the basic-cable network AMC.

The show's first season,

which ended in May, is now finding a second life on Netflix.

More are on the way. Netflix is developing "God Mode," described as a corporate thriller about rivalries and power struggles among Silicon Valley's elite, starring Rosamund Pike. HBO's upcoming

"War" centers on a divorce battle involving a tech mogul. Apple TV's "Neuromancer" examines artificial intelligence, hackers and corporate power.

"The collective, unified anger at tech companies is really remarkable," said Brian

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INSIDE



HEARD ON THE STREET

Boeing's supplier deal looks like an \$8.4 billion misstep. **B10**

BUSINESS NEWS

A cattle shortage and price volatility leads Tyson Foods to cut its outlook. **B3**

Corporate America Is Axing Bosses of the 'Micro-Teams'

By **CHIP CUTTER**

The most-endangered species in corporate America today might be the manager overseeing a tiny team.

The latest broadside against small-team bosses comes from **Uber**. The ride-sharing giant said Wednesday it would reduce the number of "micro-teams"—those with only one or two direct reports—by nearly half. The move is part of a broader plan to cut 10% of its staff, about 3,300 people. Ultimately, the company will have 20% fewer managers, a spokesman said.

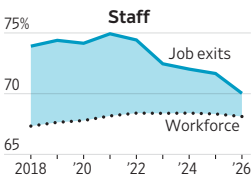
The cuts highlight a larger shift afoot: CEOs want managers overseeing bigger groups, with fewer layers between indi-

vidual workers and executives at the top of companies. Many employers now expect managers to do less coordinating between departments, and to spend more time in the trenches building products or generating revenue themselves.

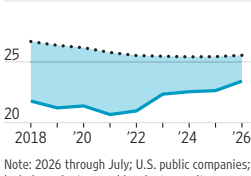
Intel Chief Financial Officer David Zinsner said last week that the chip maker had shrunk its layers of management by half, from 12 to six. The company "pulled a lot of middle management out, which bogged down a lot of the decision-making," he said. In May, **Coinbase** announced layoffs with the aim of having no more than five management levels below its leadership team.

"Managers should be like

Share of workforce and share of job exits, by seniority level



Middle managers



Note: 2026 through July; U.S. public companies; includes voluntary and involuntary exits
Source: Live Data Technologies

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Volkswagen Shakes Up Leaders

Continued from page B1 of the game have changed,” Blume said in a Q&A published on the company intranet last month.

For successive Volkswagen CEOs, modest U.S. sales have long signaled a growth opportunity waiting to be grasped—starting with wildly ambitious targets.

Martin Winterkorn, who ran the company from 2007 to 2015, fixed a goal of selling 800,000 vehicles in the U.S. The plan created pressure that the company has acknowledged contributed to its diesel-cheating scandal.

His successor Herbert Diess, an avowed fan of Elon Musk, pinned his hopes on redemption through EVs to hit a 10% U.S. market-share goal. His signature products included the U.S.-made ID.4 and the imported ID.Buzz, electric vehicles that struggled to find traction even before Trump withdrew Biden-era subsidies.

While past regimes at Volkswagen prioritized selling similar cars all over the world—often ones ill-suited to American tastes—Blume is prioritizing lineups tailored to different regions.

He has poured funds into Scout Motors, a project begun under Diess to revive a historic sport-utility-vehicle brand as an all-American EV startup. In the Trump era, the project has pivoted to extended-range EVs, a kind of hybrid that includes a small internal combustion



Marco Schubert will lead Volkswagen's business in North America starting in October.

engine alongside a big battery.

He is also focused on technology partnerships. Under Blume's leadership, Volkswagen has committed billions of dollars to Rivian in exchange for access to the U.S. company's cutting-edge vehicle electronics and software.

Tariffs have brought fresh urgency to the question of localizing production in America. In Chattanooga, Volkswagen only makes its Atlas and Atlas Cross Sport SUVs. A Scout factory under construction in South Carolina isn't set to deliver vehicles before 2028.

In April, the company ended U.S. production of the ID.4. It said at the time it was exploring options to bring a new, high-volume vehicle to Chatta-

nooga that would be focused squarely on American customer needs. It declined to give further details.

Tariffs also revived the old idea of a U.S. Audi factory, which was raised repeatedly by Winterkorn in the gangbuster years before dieselgate. With profit under pressure, though, a plan hasn't come together yet.

The company's appointment of Schubert, an Audi veteran, to its top U.S. job could make an American factory dedicated to the luxury brand more likely, said independent analyst Jürgen Pieper.

Last month Audi launched its first full-size SUV in New York, the Q9, a model it said was "inspired" by and de-

signed for the American market, though it was largely engineered in Germany and will be made in Slovakia.

A broader, long-awaited U.S. strategy for the Volkswagen group has yet to emerge. This year, Blume has put his energies into a second major restructuring plan that could bring the total number of jobs cut on his watch up to 100,000. The company's supervisory board approved the plan late on Thursday after months of wrangling.

He has also retired the 10% U.S. market-share ambition inherited from Diess.

"Of course, we're currently feeling pressure from trade-policy issues," Blume told reporters in March.

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Lululemon Cuts Outlook Again

By KATHERINE HAMILTON

Lululemon Athletica cut its outlook for the second time this year after another quarter of declining sales in the company's Americas business.

In after-hours trading, the retailer's shares fell about 18%. The activewear retailer said Thursday it now expects annual sales to be \$10.35 billion to \$10.50 billion, down from its previous guidance of \$11 billion to \$11.15 billion.

It also lowered its projection for earnings per share to \$9.48 to \$9.73, down from \$10.95 to \$11.15 for the year.

The company already cut its outlook this year after reporting first-quarter results.

Lululemon expects third-quarter revenue to be \$2.29 billion to \$2.32 billion, which would be below analysts' forecast of \$2.53 billion. It anticipates earnings per share of 93 cents to 98 cents.

The company said it is taking a prudent approach with its guidance because the challenging dynamics it has faced in recent quarters haven't gone away.

Profit was \$329.2 million, or \$2.92 a share, compared with \$370.9 million, or \$3.10 a share, a year earlier. Profit included 86 cents a share from tariff refunds and associated interest, net of tax.

Revenue in the second quarter declined 4% to \$2.42 billion, below the \$2.46 billion



Executives said in June that first-quarter sales had been dented by negative online narratives.

that analysts expected. Sales in the Americas slipped 8%, while international revenue was up 4%.

Same-store sales dropped 9%, while Wall Street was projecting a 4.6% decline.

Executives said in June that first-quarter sales were dented by negative online narratives about the brand. Several product launches failed to meet expectations, as Lululemon lost more North American customers to competitors such as Alo and Vuori.

Heidi O'Neill is slated to step in as chief executive next week, a move that is highly anticipated by shareholders. Investors are hoping she can steer a turnaround after a series of bad moments for the brand, many of which have played out publicly.

In the spring, the company made peace with founder Chip Wilson, who had spent years criticizing the company and trying to overhaul the board via a proxy fight. Wilson, who is the company's biggest share-

holder, settled with Lululemon in the spring after a long negotiation process. He agreed to sign a nondisparagement agreement in exchange for the right to name two directors.

After O'Neill was appointed CEO, shares dropped, as investors critiqued her tenure as a former Nike executive. Analysts say they want to see her stop expanding stores, focus on improving North American sales and refocus on core products and traditional color palettes.

Small-Team Bosses Get Laid Off

Continued from page B1 player-coaches, getting their hands dirty alongside their teams," CEO Brian Armstrong wrote in a staff memo.

For the supervisors still standing, that often means doing a job that is bigger and more complicated. Workers, meanwhile, say it can often be tough to get time with bosses overseeing ever-more people.

Watching the burdens on bosses grow, many junior employees say they have no interest in pursuing the management track. In a survey by staffing firm Robert Half last year, 40% of Gen Z professionals said they wanted a promotion that doesn't require them to become a manager.

Leading a small team has long been seen as an important steppingstone to management, a way for companies to give budding leaders a taste of it without overwhelming them. But in the latest wave of cost cuts, companies are going after managers with small fiefdoms with particular focus.

Google said it reduced the number of managers overseeing small teams last year by 35%, in pursuit of greater efficiency. That was also the reason given by public safety-tech company Axon when it cut hundreds of manager roles and reassigned small-team supervisors to indi-

vidual-contributor roles.

The small teams that used to be Axon's norm—an average of roughly four employees to every manager—were "borderline offensive" because they could potentially slow down progress, Axon President Josh Isner said at the time.

"The better our talent is, the more self motivated the team is, the more mission oriented the team is, the less management we need in the middle of that," he said in an interview with The Wall Street Journal last year.

Uber's own cuts are aimed at "broadening manager scopes" and cutting the number of people who sit seven or more layers from the CEO by 20%, CEO Dara Khosrowshahi wrote to employees Wednesday. The goal: "A simpler org chart geared toward building

versus managing," he said.

Across U.S. companies, the share of departures among middle managers has ticked up, according to an analysis by Live Data Technologies. Companies also

have tended to be slower to replace middle managers when they leave.

In the past, those purges usually led to another cycle of manager hiring and promotions. That pattern could play out differently in the era of artificial intelligence. George Arison, CEO of the dating app Grindr, said he sees a future with flat management structures—particularly when AI agents and machines can do more of the work.

"You still need people managers," Arison said, but "I think they're going to be managing more people."

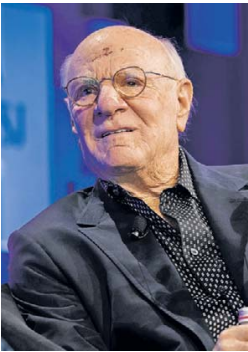
Investors Shun AI As Target

Continued from page B1

Increasingly, investors are placing bets on niche, startup sports leagues like the Professional Fighters League, which was founded to challenge the UFC and recently merged with social-media influencer Jake Paul's combat-sports company Most Valuable Promotions.

Investing in new sports leagues requires much less capital but comes with greater risks, some investors say. There is no guarantee they will build a real fan base, and there are concerns that shortening attention spans will make it harder to attract and retain audiences. AI-generated content is also increasingly competing for consumers' time.

Harley Miller, founder of Left Lane Capital, is an early investor in Real American Free-



Barry Diller's People Inc. aims to take over MGM Resorts.

style, a wrestling league co-founded by Hulk Hogan in 2025. Miller said the business has shown real momentum, with a growing fan base willing to travel to attend tournaments.

"These are hard assets, and they are difficult to replicate," Miller said. "It's not speculative stuff that is going to get mouse-trapped by a new large language model release in a year."

Left Lane is also an investor in the racket-sport Pro Padel League, the Snow

League—a professional winter-sports league founded by Shaun White—and League One Volleyball. "These are not vanity trophy assets for us," said Miller, whose firm's other bets include consumer brands like Blank Street Coffee and 7th Street Burger. "We are looking to make venture-style returns," typically a multiple of the original investment.

The hunt for AI-proof businesses has extended beyond sports and entertainment to hard assets like manufacturing and power.

Barry Diller's People Inc. is in negotiations to take over MGM Resorts in a deal that values the casino giant at over \$12 billion.

"While everyone was running into all sorts of 'AI opportunities,' I wanted to run the other way," Diller said in an earlier interview with The Wall Street Journal.

Beth Ferreira, a partner at the investment firm run by tennis star Serena Williams, which raised \$111 million for its debut fund in 2022, calls investments spanning physical products, travel and wellness

the "experience economy." She has focused her efforts there with a thesis that people are spending more of their lives behind screens, making the moments they spend in the physical world more valuable.

"We're really looking for founders who are building where technology personalizes the experience and optimizes the experience but doesn't replace the experience," Ferreira said.

Serena Ventures has met with potential investment targets from travel startups to a curling league. One place it has deployed capital is StickerBox, an AI-enabled children's toy company. Kids can ask StickerBox to create an image, which the toy generates using AI and then prints as a physical sticker.

That bet has already paid off. StickerBox was acquired by Spin Master, the toy company that makes Paw Patrol play sets, in August. The sale valued StickerBox at between \$35 million and \$50 million.

"While it's a counter bet against AI, it's part of the rise of AI," Ferreira said.

**Listen to a Podcast:
How Big Food Is Navigating the GLP-1 Era**

For decades, food companies relied on a proven playbook: cater to shoppers with sugar, salt and flavor. But new weight-loss drugs have changed the dynamics. Scan this code for a podcast on how food makers are responding.

BUSINESS NEWS

Sales Growth Slows at Victoria’s Secret

Retailer boosts revenue outlook for full year, plans new campaigns

By Connor Hart and Kelly Cloonan

Victoria’s Secret again boosted its full-year outlook, pointing to progress against its turnaround plan, even as second-quarter sales growth cooled.

Net sales climbed 10% to \$1.61 billion for the fiscal second quarter, just missing Wall Street estimates for \$1.62 billion and marking a slowdown from the 15% sales growth the retailer logged in the prior quarter.

Same-store sales—which exclude newly opened or closed stores—were up 9%, also marking a sequential slowdown in growth.

Shares fell 13% to \$73.61 Thursday. Through Wednesday’s close, the stock is up about 57% year to date.

Victoria’s Secret, which

also owns the PINK brand for teens and young adults, posted a profit of \$183 million, or \$2.18 a share, for its quarter ended Aug. 1, compared with \$16.2 million, or 20 cents a share, in the year-earlier period.

Adjusted earnings of 95 cents a share topped analyst estimates of 77 cents a share, according to FactSet.

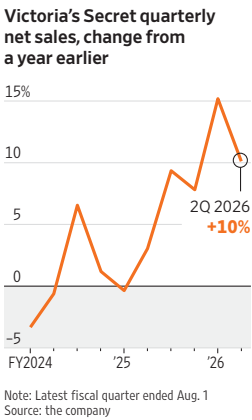
More new products

Chief Executive Hillary Super said the latest quarter’s results were driven by broad-based growth across the business.

“Our brands are stronger and more relevant, our customer file is growing and we are gaining market share as product, brand identity, storytelling and execution are all working together,” she said.

Super sees further opportunity ahead, adding that the company will double down on the parts of its plan that are working.

Victoria’s Secret is investing more in marketing and



plans to roll out more new products, partnerships and campaigns, including a coming docuseries and a bigger version of its signature fashion show.

Tariff refunds

“We are incredibly excited about the back half of the year and the opportunity to continue building both of these



The retailer is investing more in marketing and plans to roll out more new products.

iconic brands,” Super said.

Victoria’s Secret also noted it received tariff refunds of more than \$140 million in the recent quarter, representing nearly all the tariffs it paid under the International Emer-

gency Economic Powers Act.

Looking ahead, the company said it expects sales of \$7.1 billion to \$7.18 billion for the year, up from its prior forecast of \$7.03 billion to \$7.13 billion.

It also forecast sales of \$1.57 billion to \$1.6 billion for the current third quarter.

Analysts are looking for full-year sales of \$7.14 billion, as well as current-quarter sales of \$1.57 billion.

Docusign Raises View After AI Boost

By Katherine Hamilton

Docusign raised its sales outlook for the second time this year, citing a boost from artificial intelligence-related demand.

The digital document-signing platform said Thursday it now expects annual revenue to be \$3.5 billion to \$3.51 billion, up from its previous guidance of \$3.49 billion to \$3.5 billion.

“Docusign is raising its outlook as AI accelerates momentum across the business,” said Chief Executive Allan Thygesen.

Docusign has been launching new AI tools designed to help customers understand what is inside the agreements they’re signing. Its AI agents are now securely executing contract workflows, Thygesen said.

Profit in the second quarter was \$77.7 million, or 40 cents a share, compared with \$63 million, or 30 cents a share, a year earlier.

Stripping out certain one-time items, adjusted per-share earnings were \$1.16. Revenue rose 9% to \$875.7 million.

Zscaler Reports Narrower Loss

By Paul Ziobro

Zscaler posted a narrower loss after revenue rose 25% in its fiscal fourth-quarter, as artificial intelligence helps drive demand for its cybersecurity offerings.

The San Jose, Calif., company also said it would restructure and cut 3% of its workforce as it reallocates resources to support its AI and growth initiatives.

Zscaler on Thursday reported a loss of \$3.37 million, or 2 cents a share, compared with a loss of \$17.6 million, or 11 cents a share, a year earlier.

Adjusted earnings were \$1.19 a share. Analysts were looking for \$1.09 a share, according to FactSet.

Revenue rose to \$898.2 million, topping analyst expectations for nearly \$877 million.

Chief Executive Jay Chaudhry said Zscaler is well-equipped to help companies combat threats posted by agentic AI and also securely deploy AI agents and models.

Zscaler’s outlook for the current quarter and fiscal year topped also Wall Street expectations. For the current quarter, Zscaler expects adjusted per-share earnings between \$1.15 and \$1.16 and revenue between \$935 million and \$939 million.



Beef producers have been posting big losses even as consumer prices remain high.

Tyson Cuts Outlook, Citing Volatility in Cattle Prices

By Elias Schisgall

Tyson Foods said its revenue will grow less than previously expected this year, citing pressure on volatile cattle prices.

The company said on Thursday that it expects revenue in fiscal 2026 to rise by 1.5% to 2%, down from a previous range of 2.5% to 3.5%.

Shares fell 7.3% on Thursday. The stock is down about 12% this year.

“The revised outlook is primarily driven by significant margin compression amid volatile cattle prices and one of the most severe cattle shortages in U.S. history, as well as the expected impact of lower cattle prices on the value of live cattle inventories,” the company said.

Beef producers have been grappling with a yearslong cattle shortage and posting substantial losses, even as consumer prices for beef re-

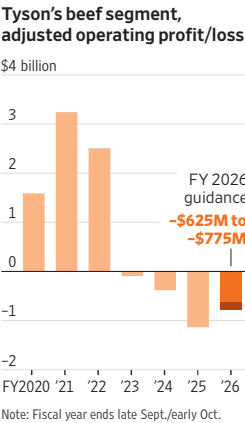
main high, The Wall Street Journal has reported.

Tyson said its beef segment is now expected to generate an adjusted operating loss of \$625 million to \$775 million for the fiscal year. It previously guided for a loss between \$500 million and \$650 million.

Tyson also cut guidance for adjusted operating profits for its other meat segments. It said the chicken segment is expected to turn a profit between \$1.85 billion and \$1.95 billion, below previous guidance for \$1.9 billion to \$2.05 billion, due to consumer caution.

Softer hog and wholesale pricing means the pork segment is now expected to generate an adjusted operating profit of between \$200 million and \$250 million, the company said, down \$50 million from Tyson’s prior outlook.

The move follows Tyson



announcing plans last month to shutter one beef processing plant and sell another as part of a pullback from the beef business. The company’s beef restructuring should reduce operating cost pressures in fiscal 2027, Chief Executive Donnie King said.

Campbell’s Slashes 13% of Its Workforce

By Connor Hart

Campbell’s said Thursday it has cut more than 1,750 jobs, or roughly 13% of its workforce, as part of a cost-savings program that aims to turn around the company’s struggling operations.

The cuts came as the soup-and-snack maker swung to a loss in the latest quarter, as higher costs pressured profitability and soft demand hurt sales. The company said it expects both trends to persist over the coming year.

“Our performance is not where it needs to be, and we are taking decisive action to improve it,” Chief Executive Mick Beekhuizen said.

Shares fell 7% on Thursday. The stock has lost more than a fifth of its value year to date.

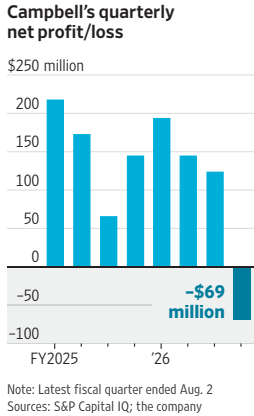
Campbell’s plans to cut \$500 million in costs by fiscal 2030, a move that aims to protect margins and support higher investment levels. Chief Financial Officer Todd Cunfer said several cost-saving actions are already under way, including the closure of two snack plants and a recently completed workforce reduction.

The company had 13,700 employees as of August 2025, according to the latest head count available in filings with the Securities and Exchange Commission.

Campbell’s also said it would slash its quarterly dividend to 25 cents a share, marking a 36% reduction from its prior quarterly dividend of 39 cents a share.

“Together, these actions are designed to improve speed and accountability while supporting our margins and cash flow,” Cunfer said.

Looking ahead, Campbell’s said it would increase its focus on consumers, sharpen its execution and increase investment in its brands. The steps won’t improve the company’s performance overnight, Beekhuizen said, but they should help re-



turn the company to growth in the long term.

In the coming year, Campbell’s expects adjusted earnings of \$1.65 to \$1.80 a share, missing Wall Street estimates for \$1.83 a share, according to FactSet. The company also guided for net sales to decline by 2% to 4%, steeper than the roughly 1% decrease that analysts forecast.

The outlooks reflect an external environment that is expected to remain volatile, as well as another year of elevated inflation. “However, our outlook also reflects the benefits of productivity, cost savings initiatives and pricing that we expect to build throughout the year and increasingly support margin recovery,” Beekhuizen added.

For its fiscal fourth quarter, Campbell’s posted a loss attributable to shareholders of \$69 million, or 23 cents a share, compared with a profit of \$145 million, or 48 cents a share, a year earlier. Adjusted earnings of 39 cents a share were in line with analyst estimates.

Sales fell 8% to \$2.14 billion. On an organic basis, sales were down 1%.

Sales across its snacks division tumbled 12%, while sales across its meals and beverages unit were down 4%.

Bartiromo Exits Fox News After Over 12 Years

By Joe Flint and Isabella Simonetti

Fox News has parted ways with longtime anchor Maria Bartiromo.

The journalist is no longer with Fox News Media, effective Thursday, the network said in a news release.

Bartiromo, 58, hadn’t been on Fox News or Fox Business for almost a month. Her last appearance was on her Fox News show “Sunday Morning Futures” on Aug. 9.

“We thank Maria for her work over the last 12½ years and wish her all the best on her next chapter,” Fox News said. Bartiromo didn’t respond to requests for comment.

Fox Corp. and Wall Street Journal parent News Corp share common ownership.

Bartiromo violated company policy by disclosing to the

White House news-coverage plans after President Trump’s July 16 speech about election security, a person familiar with the matter said.

Neither Bartiromo nor her attorney responded to numerous requests for comment. Fox News said in a statement that Bartiromo was removed for “business reasons.”

The newsletter Status earlier reported that Bartiromo had disclosed coverage plans to the White House.

One of the highest-profile personalities at Fox News, Bartiromo was known in recent years for her staunch advocacy for President Trump. She was with Fox since 2014, hosting as many as 16½ hours of programming each week, primarily on Fox Business.

Bartiromo’s on-air comments have at times drawn controversy. She issued an on-air apol-



Longtime cable news anchor Maria Bartiromo is known for her staunch advocacy of President Trump.

ogy in June after investor and television personality Kevin O’Leary claimed on one of her shows that opponents of his planned Utah data center were backed by Chinese interests, an assertion he later said he had no evidence to support.

Comments that Bartiromo and others made on her show were featured in Dominion Voting Systems’ defamation lawsuit against Fox over false allegations that the voting-machine company helped rig the 2020 U.S. election. Fox settled with

Dominion in 2023 for \$787.5 million. She is also a defendant in a continuing defamation lawsuit by Smartmatic over false claims that the voting-technology company helped rig the 2020 election.

Fox has said Smartmatic has been mired in scandals and can’t prove that any Fox reports caused the company to lose business or suffer other financial harm.

Bartiromo spent her early career at CNBC, where she was nicknamed “Money Honey” and became a staple of market coverage from the floor of the New York Stock Exchange.

She was brought to Fox News by then-CEO Roger Ailes. Her show “Mornings with Maria” averaged 114,000 viewers on Fox Business year to date, while her Friday show “Maria Bartiromo’s Wall Street” drew an average of 97,000, according to Nielsen.

TECHNOLOGY

Tesla’s Cybercabs Hit Austin Streets

Driverless rides reflect Musk’s push to turn EV maker into driverless giant

By BECKY PETERSON

Tesla unleashed its steering-wheel-free Cybercabs on the roads of Austin, Texas, in the first public test of its promise to transition from traditional electric vehicles to fully autonomous cars.

Tesla influencers posted photos and videos Thursday ahead of an invite-only launch event in downtown Austin. The company teased the event with a countdown clock on its website.

Cybercab, a two-seater gold coupe that doesn’t have pedals or mirrors, isn’t yet available for sale to customers. Tesla posted a form on its website to collect contact information of people interested in “Cybercab fleet vehicle purchasing.”

The company has touted Cybercab as a lower-cost option versus competing robotaxis, because its vehicle



Cybercab is a two-seater gold coupe that doesn’t have pedals or mirrors. It isn’t yet for sale.

navigates roads using only cameras and neural networks. Other vehicles use technology like radar and lidar, which uses lasers to create 3D maps of the environment.

Tesla said Thursday customers in Austin can now book rides in Cybercabs through the company’s Robot-

axi ride-hailing app, which launched last year. The offering puts Tesla in competition with ride-share providers like **Uber** and **Lyft**, as well as autonomous ride-hailing services from **Alphabet’s** Waymo and **Amazon’s** Zoox.

Ahead of Thursday’s event, the automaker added dozens

of Cybercabs to the fleet of vehicles that passengers could book.

Previously rides were only available in Tesla Model Ys and in some cases with a safety driver.

In late August, Zoox, a toaster-shaped robotaxi, started offering free rides in

San Francisco and paid rides in Las Vegas.

Waymo, the leader in autonomous ride hailing, has around 4,000 cars on the road across 14 cities, though it uses retrofitted vehicles with special sensors to enable human-free driving.

Regulators for years approached autonomous vehicles cautiously.

In June, the National Highway Transportation Safety Administration proposed rules that would eliminate the requirement for manual pedals in autonomous driving systems with an eye toward getting the new technology on the road faster.

The NHTSA grants exemptions to automakers to sell vehicles not fully in compliance with the rules but caps them at 2,500 cars a year. Automakers can also self-certify whether their technology meets federal safety criteria.

Tesla hasn’t filed an exemption request for the Cybercab, but the agency is in touch with the automaker and monitoring the situation, a spokesperson for the NHTSA said.

China’s Moonshot AI Files For IPO in Hong Kong

By TRACY QU AND RAFFAELE HUANG

China’s Moonshot AI has confidentially submitted an application for an initial public offering to Hong Kong’s stock exchange, people familiar with the matter said.

The Beijing-based artificial-intelligence startup’s latest private funding round values it at \$50 billion, The Wall Street Journal has reported.

Moonshot declined to comment on the IPO plan.

Chinese tech-focused publication LatePost and Reuters had previously reported on the confidential IPO filing.

A rising star on China’s increasingly competitive AI scene, Moonshot jolted the industry in July with its new large-language model Kimi K3, whose performance rivals that of some top-tier U.S. offerings.

If successful, the listing, which is subject to approval by Chinese regulators, could become one of the largest IPOs in Hong Kong in recent years.

Chinese AI companies have accelerated fundraising activities following the IPOs of two AI model developers, Z.AI and MiniMax, in Hong Kong in January.

Another high-profile startup, DeepSeek, is seeking a listing next year in Shanghai, and was valued at around \$74 billion in its latest funding round, the Journal reported in August.

Founded by Yang Zhilin in 2023, a graduate of Carnegie Mellon University and China’s Tsinghua University, Moonshot counts HSG, Alibaba and Tencent among its investors.

TV Shows Take Aim At Big Tech

Continued from page B1

Creech, a professor of journalism and communication at Lehigh University. The shows reflect that feeling, he said.

Hollywood’s latest portrayal of Silicon Valley is more sinister than HBO’s “Silicon Valley,” a 2010s comedy.

In many of the new series, the camera is focused on the ambitious and feuds involving tech’s elite.

The latest shows aren’t imagining a dystopian future a la Netflix’s futuristic “Black Mirror” anthology series.

Their targets are in the here and now, from artificial intelligence and the erosion of privacy to the growing power of tech companies. The shift

comes amid a broader backlash over social media’s influence on minors and the building of data centers.

“When was the last time we saw tech help?” a character on “The Audacity” asks. “Have we made the lives of our children better? Probably no. But we can have Q-tips at our door in an hour.”

Hollywood’s increasingly skeptical view of tech comes as the two industries have never been more intertwined. Netflix, **Amazon.com** and **Apple** are now major Hollywood players, while new technologies are changing how entertainment is made.

Even CBS is controlled by the family of tech billionaire Larry Ellison.

The skepticism takes different forms.

“Cupertino,” from “The Good Wife” and “The Good Fight” creators Robert and Michelle King, takes viewers on a tour through contemporary anxieties like the abuse of someone’s likeness by AI and chatbots urging

real-world harm.

Robert King, who grew up in San Jose, watched the Bay Area transform as the technology industry grew, and said there are parallels with the lawlessness of past gold rushes.

Tech leaders, once seen as “the disrupters and rebels, were becoming the powers that be,” he said.

While the lawyer protagonists are portrayed as the Davids trying to slay the giants, they aren’t entirely altruistic.

“They realize they have an opportunity to help those without anyone else to represent them,” said Michelle King. “They see a business opportunity, and they are not above exploiting it.”

The outside, eccentric personalities of tech titans have also given Hollywood plenty to work with. “The Audacity” re-

turns next year for its second season with the lead character declaring, “I’m basically a deity. Semi-deity, at least.”

“If you wake up every day, and you’re worth...hundreds of billions of dollars...I think that it’s a real distortion for someone’s sense of self,” said “The Audacity” creator Jonathan Glatzer, who previously worked on “Succession” and “Better Call Saul.”

Glatzer sees the current moment as another technological sea change, similar to the Industrial Revolution. Such periods tend to bring collateral damage and hasty decisions driven by a desire to make the money while it’s hot, Glatzer said.

‘The collective, unified anger at tech companies is really remarkable.’

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COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

NOTICE OF SALE OF REAL PROPERTY – MANHATTAN

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT SOUTHERN DISTRICT OF NEW YORK.

WELLS FARGO BANK, NATIONAL ASSOCIATION, AS TRUSTEE, FOR THE BENEFIT OF THE HOLDERS OF CD 2018-CD7, MORTGAGE TRUST COMMERCIAL MORTGAGE PASS-THROUGH CERTIFICATES, SERIES 2018-CD7, acting by and through its special servicer, Rialto Capital Advisors, LLC, as Special Servicer under the Pooling and Servicing Agreement dated as of August 1, 2013, Plaintiff –against– PRINCE 26, LLC, 29 PRINCE STREET ASSOCIATES LLC, et al Defendant(s). Pursuant to that certain ORDER & JUDGMENT entered herein and dated August 5, 2026 (“Judgment”), I, the undersigned Referee will sell at public auction, at the front steps of 26 Prince Street, New York, New York 10012 on September 25, 2026, at 2:00 p.m., prevailing Eastern Time, the following Premises (to be sold as a single lot), as that term is defined below, and more particularly described and bounded as follows:

PARCEL A: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the northerly side of Prince Street, distant 27 feet 11 1/4 inches (deed), 27.94 feet (actual), easterly from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE northerly parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and part of the way through party walls, 83 feet 11 inches (deed), 82.54 feet (actual); THENCE easterly 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed), 24.40 feet (actual), to a point on a line distant 86 feet and 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), northerly from the northerly side of Prince Street which line is parallel or nearly so with the easterly side of Mott Street and intersects the northerly side of Prince Street at a point 54 feet 7 1/4 inches (deed), 55.61 feet (actual), when measured in an easterly direction from the corner formed by the intersection of the northerly side of Prince Street with the easterly side of Mott Street; THENCE southerly and along said line drawn parallel or nearly so with Mott Street and part of the way through a party wall, 86 feet 1 inch (deed), 86.08 feet (actual), to the northerly side of Prince Street; THENCE westerly along the northerly side of Prince Street, 26 feet 9 and 6/10 inches (deed) 27.67 feet (actual), to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 508 Lot: 52.

Said premises to be sold is known as 29 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 (“Parcel A”).

PARCEL B: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the northerly side of Thompson Street, distant 169 feet 6 inches Northerly from the intersection of said Westerly side of Thompson Street and the Northerly side of Prince Street; RUNNING THENCE Westerly parallel with Prince Street, 100 feet; THENCE Northerly parallel with Thompson Street, 24 feet 8 inches; THENCE Easterly parallel with Prince Street and part of the distance through a party wall, 100 feet to the Westerly side of Thompson Street; THENCE Southerly along the Westerly side of Thompson Street, 24 feet 8 inches to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 517 Lot: 31.

Said premises to be sold is known as 137 THOMPSON STREET a/k/a 135-137 THOMPSON STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 (“Parcel B”).

PARCEL C: ALL THAT CERTAIN plot, piece or parcel of land, situate, lying and being in the Borough of Manhattan, County of New York, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the southerly side of Prince Street, distant 47 feet 6 inches easterly from the corner formed by its intersection of the southerly side of Prince Street and the easterly side of Mott Street; RUNNING THENCE southerly and parallel with the easterly side of Mott Street a distance of 114 feet 7 inches to a point; THENCE easterly along the line forming on its northerly side an angle of 88 degrees 04 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 23 feet 1 inch to a point; THENCE northerly along a line forming on its westerly side an angle of 91 degrees 55 minutes 30 seconds with the last mentioned course a distance of 109 feet to a point on the southerly side of Prince Street which point is distant 24 feet easterly from the point or place of beginning; THENCE westerly along the southerly side of Prince Street a distance of 24 feet (record), 23 feet 7 inches (Survey) to the point or place of BEGINNING. Block: 493 Lot: 15. Said premises to be sold is known as 26 PRINCE STREET, NEW YORK, NEW YORK 10012 (“Parcel C”). (With Parcel A, Parcel B, and Parcel C, collectively, being the “Premises”).

Pursuant to Judgment, Premises will be sold a single lot and is not to be divided or sold separately. The approximate amount of the Judgment for Premises, collectively, is \$46,677,820.90 plus interest & costs.

Premises will be sold subject to provisions of filed Judgment and forthcoming terms of sale.

Civil Action File No. 22-cv-05586 (PAE) (OTW)

STEPHEN F. ELLMAN, ESQ., Referee

MATTHEW MANNION, from Mannion Auctions, LLC as Auctioneer

Holland & Knight, LLP

Attorney(s) for Plaintiff

787 Seventh Avenue, 31st Floor,

New York, New York 10019

NOTICE OF SALE

NOTICE OF PUBLIC SALE UNDER ARTICLE 9 OF THE UNIFORM COMMERCIAL CODE

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that on September 11, 2026, at 10:00 a.m., Wilmington, Delaware time, at the offices of Landis Rath & Cobb LLP 919 N. Market Street, Suite 1800, Wilmington, DE 19801 a public sale shall be conducted of certain collateral (the “Collateral”) pledged to West Elm Foreclosure, LLC (the “Secured Lender”) by Gemnet Media, Inc. (“Borrower”). A Zoom link will be provided to qualified bidders who wish to appear at the auction virtually. This sale is being held to enforce the rights of the Secured Lender. The Collateral is substantially all of the assets of Borrower, including, but not limited to the following: all accounts (including health-care-insurance receivables), chattel paper (including tangible and electronic chattel paper), deposit accounts, documents (including negotiable documents), equipment (including all accessions and additions thereto), general intangibles (including payment intangibles and software), goods (including fixtures), instruments (including promissory notes), inventory (including all goods held for sale or lease or to be furnished under a contract of service, and including returns and repossessions), investment property (including securities and securities entitlements), letter of credit rights, money and all of Borrower’s books and records with respect to any of the foregoing, and the computers and equipment containing said books and records.

The Collateral will be sold in one block to the highest qualified bidder for cash or through a credit bid against outstanding indebtedness held only by the Secured Lender. The Secured Lender has submitted an opening bid of \$18,000,000.00 as a credit bid against outstanding indebtedness owed to the Secured Lender.

THE COLLATERAL WILL BE SOLD ON AN “AS IS” BASIS. There will be no warranty made or provided relating to title, possession, quiet enjoyment or otherwise in connection with the disposition.

To be a qualified bidder, a prospective bidder must provide the following items to Landis Rath & Cobb LLP Landis Rath & Cobb LLP 919 N. Market Street, Suite 1800, Wilmington, DE 19801 (attn: Matthew B. McGuire) on or before 5:00 p.m. (Wilmington, Delaware time) on September 10, 2026: (a) current contact information for the bidder and its authorized representatives; (b) the opening bid amount (which must be for all of the Collateral in one block at one price) proposed by such bidder (the minimum opening bid shall be in an amount not less than \$18,100,000.00); (c) a deposit wired to Landis Rath & Cobb LLP of 100% of the opening bid; and (d) prior to or during the auction, the bidder must provide proof of immediately available funds to pay any successive bids that it submits. The highest qualified bidder will be required to deposit the full amount of the bid price in escrow with Landis Rath & Cobb LLP via wire transfer, no later than September 10, 2026, at 5:00 p.m., Wilmington, Delaware time.

Interested parties who would like additional information, including wire transfer instructions should contact Matthew B. McGuire, counsel for the Secured Lender by e-mail at mcguire@lrcdaw.com.

PUBLIC NOTICES

NOTICE OF REDEMPTION

MID-AMERICA APARTMENT COMMUNITIES, INC.

NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN that Mid-America Apartment Communities, Inc. (the “Company”), has elected to and does exercise its option to call and redeem on October 1, 2026, all 867,846 outstanding shares of the Company’s 8.50% Series I Cumulative Redeemable Preferred Stock (CUSIP Number 995221889) (the “Series I Preferred Stock”). The Company will pay a redemption price for the shares of Series I Preferred Stock of \$50.00 per share, plus all unpaid accrued dividends to and including the redemption date of October 1, 2026. Dividends on the Series I Preferred Stock will cease to accrue, and the Series I Preferred Stock will no longer be deemed outstanding, from and after October 1, 2026. All shares of Series I Preferred Stock are held in book-entry form through the Depository Trust Company (“DTC”). Shares of Series I Preferred Stock held in book-entry form through the DTC will be redeemed, including payment of the redemption price, according to the DTC’s procedures.

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NOTICE OF SALE

Notice is given that SEACLIFF US PROPERTIES INC., a DE corporation, has filed a Statement of Dissolution with the Secretary of State.

All persons having claims against the corporation must present them in writing, including the details and amount of the claim. Send your claim to Galina Gorelik at Longview LLC, 909 Third Avenue, #906 New York, NY 10150

This claim must be sent no later than 11/30/2026.

Frontier CEO Fills a Spirit-Size Hole

Dempsey aims to lift airline by improving its operations and offering more perks

By ALISON SIDER

Jimmy Dempsey runs the biggest U.S. budget airline still standing.

The **Frontier Airlines** boss says the company's future relies on features such as first-class seats and in-flight Wi-Fi.

Dempsey, who took the helm last year, is charged with improving the Denver-based airline's operations and making it profitable again.

To do so, the 51-year-old Dempsey has to figure out how to maintain the airline's low-cost edge while embracing amenities that would have once been unthinkable for a budget carrier.

Budget airlines had been under pressure from mounting competition and changing consumer taste. Then a surge in fuel prices brought additional turbulence to their business.

Spirit Airlines became the poster child of the problems facing discount carriers after it shut down this year.

Now Frontier is trying to find a balance between the cheap flights that originally made budget airlines popular and the premium amenities consumers increasingly want.

WSJ: What is the future of the budget airline business model?

DEMPSEY: I think we have a really good future ahead of us. And we're going to adapt to the environment we're in. Customers are seeking more premium products.

We think the introduction of first-class seats and more premium seating on the aircraft, I think that's a real positive into adapting to the new environment

post-Covid. And then the introduction of Starlink into the airline in the early part of next year, I think is a real game-changer for Frontier. Today we're not in the decision set for a lot of customers who need connectivity. And that will change next year.

WSJ: Is there still a customer out there who is getting left behind as everyone climbs the premium ladder?

DEMPSEY: Our business model continues to grow the addressable market, and encourages people to travel who wouldn't normally travel. All those components of our business model haven't changed.

Then we're adding premium products in order to improve the overall revenue base of the airline. We think that we've got the right balance coming over the next year.

WSJ: How do you balance the need to keep costs really low so you can offer those much lower fares with first class, Starlink and all the things that people expect?

DEMPSEY: Our cost differential is about 40% versus the rest of the industry.

We're really focused on some of the core attributes of the airline, which is to run a better operation, create reliability for the customer base and maintain efficiency and productivity so that you have an opportunity to provide real value to the customers.

WSJ: It's been a super eventful year already, with Spirit liquidating. Is that a benefit for Frontier?

DEMPSEY: It does give us an opportunity. There's no doubt about it. We positioned the airline where we overlapped on about 100 routes, that both Frontier and Spirit operated on.

We continue to deploy



the model pretty successfully across that route network. We'll see what other opportunities present

Jimmy Dempsey, left, said the collapse of Spirit Airlines offers Frontier opportunities as the biggest U.S. budget carrier.

we're bringing in.

WSJ: Do you know yet whether Starlink is going to be free or if there's going to be a fee for it?

DEMPSEY: We haven't finalized the commercial model. We're really focused at the moment on actually getting it installed.

WSJ: Where are things now with fuel prices?

DEMPSEY: It's very unpredictable at the moment. I think you've got to plan for managing higher oil prices for the foreseeable future. We're doing that. It's certainly a challenge to manage in a higher oil price environment, but we're seeing real positive demand for our business at the moment.

WSJ: Let's talk about first class. What does a Frontier first class look like compared with another airline?

DEMPSEY: Yeah, so we put Upfront Plus on the airline

2½ years ago, which is the blocked middle seat in the first two rows of the aircraft. And we saw a meaningful improvement in the revenue generated for that real estate. And that drove us to move from Upfront Plus to buy first-class seats.

So what you'll see is effectively two-by-two in the first two rows of the aircraft. And then you'll likely see in the row behind that some continuation of Upfront Plus.

WSJ: What do you see as the role for the [Frontier credit] card?

DEMPSEY: The cash flows and revenues that are generated by the big guys, I mean, that would be great if we achieved that, but it's not realistic for Frontier. Our program is pretty immature in comparison to their programs. So that creates a huge opportunity for us to invest in the loyalty program.

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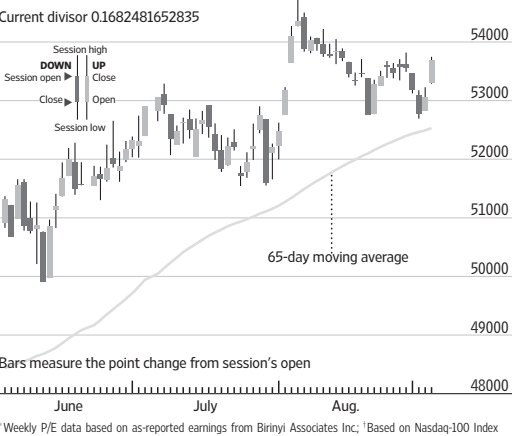
MARKETS DIGEST

EQUITIES

Dow Jones Industrial Average

53686.11 ▲ 624.16, or 1.18%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Trailing P/E ratio	21.86	24.98
P/E estimate *	20.36	21.75
Dividend yield	1.47	1.59
All-time high	54349.12	08/05/26



Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Close	Net chg	% chg
Dow Jones					
Industrial Average	53746.50	53286.15	53686.11	624.16	1.18
Transportation Avg	20898.52	20550.13	20861.52	148.04	0.71
Utility Average	1087.82	1076.95	1085.59	10.11	0.94
Total Stock Market	76667.75	76030.20	76589.97	819.48	1.08
Barron's 400	1648.20	1635.37	1644.24	11.23	0.69

Nasdaq Stock Market					
Nasdaq Composite	26644.57	26325.06	26584.06	366.23	1.40
Nasdaq-100	29538.76	29160.96	29482.32	338.99	1.16

S&P					
500 Index	7756.76	7686.71	7747.71	81.11	1.06
MidCap 400	3780.01	3743.32	3779.85	33.41	0.89
SmallCap 600	1764.46	1748.25	1758.67	7.17	0.41

Other Indexes					
Russell 2000	2976.62	2951.29	2968.27	15.11	0.51
NYSE Composite	24725.47	24495.55	24720.15	224.60	0.92
Value Line	683.33	677.15	682.11	4.250	0.63
NYSE Arca Biotech	9581.96	9440.03	9528.38	11.11	0.12
NYSE Arca Pharma	1290.88	1263.25	1282.47	4.69	0.37
KBW Bank	190.02	187.70	189.73	2.96	1.58
PHLX [®] Gold/Silver	416.82	407.97	415.83	12.26	3.04
PHLX [®] Oil Service	109.53	106.92	107.08	-1.97	-1.81
PHLX [®] Semiconductor	11371.33	11056.38	11352.13	12.88	0.11
Cboe Volatility	15.44	14.23	14.32	-0.88	-5.79

*Nasdaq PHLX

Percentage Gainers...

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
ChargePoint Holdings	CHPT	9.08	3.89	74.95	12.61	4.44	-15.8
Antelope Enterprise	AEHL	7.45	2.02	37.20	808.39	2.98	-97.9
GrShr 2x Long MSTR Daily	MSTP	26.64	6.91	35.00	368.66	10.13	-91.6
Defiance Dly Tgt 2x Lg	MXST	17.33	4.49	34.97	271.50	6.72	-92.6
Defiance Tgt 2X Lg HOOD	HOOX	46.06	11.54	33.44	154.38	16.44	-34.6
Leverage 2X Lg HOOD Dly	HOOG	40.84	10.13	32.99	132.19	14.43	-31.9
Leverage 2X Lg CRCL Dly	CRCG	19.83	4.91	32.91	129.80	6.82	-74.8
ProShares Ultra CRCL	CRCA	29.30	7.25	32.88	204.45	10.07	-76.6
Direxion HOOD Bull 2X	HODU	16.86	4.17	32.86	35.58	5.98	...
bioAffinity Technologies	BIAF	12.78	3.03	31.08	202.50	4.56	-88.5
Defiance Lvgd Lg MSTR	MST	14.40	3.40	30.91	315.28	6.53	-94.9
Focus Universal	FCUV	19.69	4.53	29.88	210.00	1.79	-79.1
Leverage 2X Lg Cifr Dly	CIFG	4.59	1.02	28.49	20.84	3.15	...
Leverage 2X Lg BMNR Dly	BMNG	29.79	6.58	28.35	347.00	8.39	...
Defiance Targt 2X Lg RIOT	RIOX	26.75	5.54	26.12	153.75	12.96	-50.5

Volume Movers

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	% chg from 65-day avg	Latest Session Close	% chg	52-Week High	Low
Texas Ventures Acqn III	TVA	7,676	22814	10.55	...	12.27	10.11
Touchstone Large Co	TLG	1,187	22550	27.70	1.49	28.84	22.41
ChargePoint Holdings	CHPT	42,976	6935	9.08	74.95	12.61	4.44
Blue Water Acqn III Cl A	BLUW	1,179	5621	10.38	0.06	10.41	9.95
WT Asia Defense Fd	WDAF	275	4450	30.77	1.70	38.62	26.67
SVRN	SVRN	487	3427	10.54	0.57	47.56	3.12
GS MarketBeta Russ 1000	GVUS	499	3168	66.57	0.93	66.57	51.24
Mexco Energy	MXC	480	3142	10.62	6.73	16.48	7.16
New America Acqn I Cl A	NWAX	1,441	2941	10.16	-0.29	10.39	9.68
iSh Curr Hgdg MSCI Japan	HEWJ	1,523	2894	64.73	-0.09	66.92	47.62

* Common stocks priced at \$2 a share or more with an average volume over 65 trading days of at least 5,000 shares *Has traded fewer than 65 days

International Stock Indexes

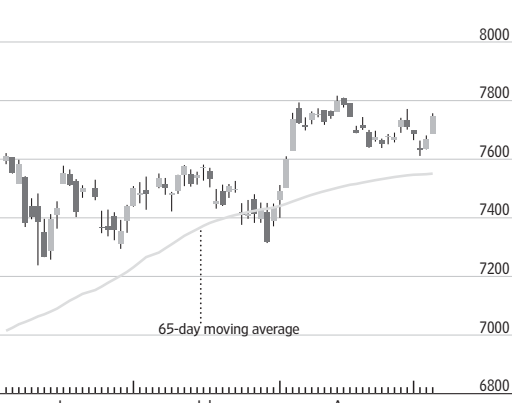
Region/Country	Index	Close	Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD % chg
World	MSCI ACWI	1154.74	11.87	1.04	13.8
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	484.56	4.28	0.89	15.1
	MSCI World	5001.24	57.18	1.16	12.9
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1703.40	2.78	0.16	21.3
Americas	MSCI AC Americas	2936.76	33.458	1.15	13.2
Canada	S&P/TSX Comp	36633.12	541.51	1.50	15.5
Latin Amer.	MSCI EM Latin America	3177.28	13.34	0.42	17.3
Brazil	Bovespa	185188.13	-16.96	-0.01	14.9
Chile	S&P IPSA	5780.65	-38.64	-0.66	6.6
Mexico	S&P/BMV IPC	65436.16	551.88	0.85	1.8
EMEA	STOXX Europe 600	649.10	3.19	0.49	9.6
Eurozone	Euro STOXX	671.66	2.66	0.40	9.7
Belgium	Bel-20	5879.05	53.34	0.92	15.8
Denmark	OMX Copenhagen 20	1642.15	4.32	0.26	2.1
France	CAC 40	8286.40	5.77	0.07	1.7
Germany	DAX	26003.32	163.99	0.63	6.2
Israel	Tel Aviv	4235.41	33.52	0.80	16.6
Italy	FTSE MIB	52245.47	453.37	0.88	16.2
Netherlands	AEX	1104.62	0.95	0.09	16.1
Norway	Oslo Bors All-Share	2505.27	-3.14	-0.13	29.0
South Africa	FTSE/JSE All-Share	116687.82	1605.76	1.40	0.7
Spain	IBEX 35	20000.20	221.20	1.12	15.6
Sweden	OMX Stockholm	1139.04	13.21	1.17	8.9
Switzerland	Swiss Market	14394.77	31.80	0.22	8.5
Turkey	BIST 100	13932.46	-118.10	-0.84	23.7
U.K.	FTSE 100	10831.52	75.07	0.70	9.1
U.K.	FTSE 250	24496.13	172.07	0.71	9.0
Asia-Pacific	MSCI AC Asia Pacific	276.86	2.39	0.87	21.6
Australia	S&P/ASX 200	9020.10	41.68	0.46	3.5
China	Shanghai Composite	3942.09	0.70	0.02	-0.7
Hong Kong	Hang Seng	25213.31	-97.90	-0.39	-1.6
India	BSE Sensex	76152.86	-417.49	-0.55	-10.6
Japan	NIKKEI 225	64214.48	-111.16	-0.17	20.6
Singapore	Straits Times	5747.71	3.59	0.06	23.7
South Korea	KOSPI	6579.48	16.76	0.26	56.1
Taiwan	TAIEX	45857.66	-307.06	-0.67	58.3
Thailand	SET	1576.92	1.85	0.12	25.2

Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data

S&P 500 Index

7747.71 ▲ 81.11, or 1.06%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Trailing P/E ratio *	24.50	26.65
P/E estimate *	21.12	23.99
Dividend yield *	1.07	1.22
All-time high	7798.99	08/13/26



Late Trading

Most-active and biggest movers among NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE Amer. and Nasdaq issues from 4 p.m. to 6 p.m. ET as reported by electronic trading services, securities dealers and regional exchanges. Minimum share price of \$2 and minimum after-hours volume of 50,000 shares.

Most-active issues in late trading

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	Last	Net chg	After Hours % chg	High	Low
Coupar	CPNG	10,656.4	15.61	0.10	0.64	15.66	15.48
lululemon athletica	LULU	9,544.4	99.95	-21.82	-17.92	123.75	97.64
Nokia ADR	NOK	9,195.5	9.75	-0.02	-0.20	9.77	9.72
UiPath	PATH	8,114.6	17.00	-1.22	-6.70	20.88	16.47
Transocean	RIG	7,534.7	6.03	0.01	0.15	6.04	6.01
NVIDIA	NVDA	7,138.7	228.75	0.30	0.13	237.94	215.03
Lloyds Banking Group ADR	LYG	6,711.0	6.10	...	unch.	6.19	6.07
iShares Core S&P 500 ETF	IVV	6,250.4	776.20	-0.93	-0.12	777.13	775.92
Percentage gainers...							
American Outdoor Brands	AOUT	151.7	12.82	2.81	28.07	13.15	10.01
Torrid Holdings	CURV	303.7	2.55	0.32	14.35	2.68	2.23
Samsara	IOT	2,231.0	44.25	5.50	14.19	44.40	38.50
Smith & Wesson Brands	SWBI	166.5	13.50	1.23	10.02	13.77	12.27
Connect Biopharma	CNTB	184.8	2.10	0.17	8.81	2.33	1.92
...And losers							
Leverage 2X Lg LULU Dly	LULG	2,543.1	4.22	-2.36	-35.87	6.81	3.97
lululemon athletica	LULU	9,544.4	99.95	-21.82	-17.92	123.75	97.64
Oxford Industries	OXM	138.8	30.15	-6.48	-17.69	37.32	28.22
Guidewire Software	GWRE	297.8	170.40	-32.46	-16.00	204.13	160.07
Asana	ASAN	1,193.5	9.07	-1.02	-10.11	10.48	8.43

Percentage Losers

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
Intercont (Cayman)	NCT	0.51	-4.39	-89.66	47.50	0.50	-98.3
Ultragenyx Pharm	RARE	14.85	-11.68	-44.03	39.89	13.81	-52.9
Gix Internet	GIXI	6.75	-5.25	-43.75	15.50	5.70	...
Research Alliance III	RACC	12.37	-7.38	-37.37	33.50	10.21	...
Defiance Dly Tgt 2x Sh	SMST	17.96	-9.72	-35.12	154.16	17.91	-39.1
Aptevo Therapeutics	APVO	1.71	-0.89	-34.23	48.78	1.37	-94.4
Connect Biopharma	CNTB	1.93	-0.83	-30.07	3.82	1.23	-3.0
Defiance Tgt 2X Shrt BMNR	BMNZ	4.82	-2.00	-29.33	47.99	4.75	...
Polestar Auto UK ADR	PSNY	8.69	-3.30	-27.52	39.30	8.03	-73.7
Sono Group	SSM	3.50	-1.30	-27.08	27.73	2.35	-41.7
Liberty Defense Holdings	DETX	2.60	-0.96	-26.98	16.19	2.50	-67.9
IM Cannabis	IMCC	2.20	-0.80	-26.67	77.10	2.17	-96.4
Li Bang International	LBGI	2.30	-0.79	-25.57	35400.00	2.10	-99.99
Currenc Group	CURR	3.00	-1.01	-25.19	5.08	1.31	76.5
MindForge	MF	10.79	-2.90	-21.18	83.50	2.12	-84.3

CURRENCIES & COMMODITIES

Currencies

U.S.-dollar foreign-exchange rates at 5 p.m. ET

Country/currency	Thurs in US\$	Thurs per US\$	US\$/ YTD chg (%)	Country/currency	Thurs in US\$	Thurs per US\$	US\$/ YTD chg (%)
Americas				Vietnam dong			
Argentina peso	.00071508	3286	3.9		.00003835	26074	-0.9
Brazil real	.1958	5.1079	-7.4	Europe			
Canada dollar	.7250	1.3794	0.5	Czech Rep. koruna	.04810	20.792	1.1
Chile peso	.001072	932.83	3.6	Denmark krone	.1555	6.4291	1.1
Colombia peso	.000317	3150.62	-16.4	Euro area euro	1.1626	.8602	1.1
Ecuador US dollar	1	1		Hungary forint	.003212	311.29	-4.9
Mexico peso	.0591	16.9211	1.6	Iceland krona	.008256	121.12	-3.4
Uruguay peso	.02486	40.2245	3.0	Norway krone	.1076	9.2918	-7.9
Asia/Pacific				Poland zloty	2690	3.7170	3.5
Australi dollar	.7201	1.3887	-7.3	Sweden krona	1.048	9.5408	3.6
China yuan	.1488	6.7189	-3.9	Switzerland franc	1.2384	.8075	1.9
Hong Kong dollar	.1276	7.8399	-0.7	Turkey lira	.0207	48.3194	12.5
India rupee	.01057	94.606	5.3	Ukraine hryvnia	.0223	44.7500	15.7
Indonesia rupiah	.0000567	176.25	5.6	UK pound	1.3524	.7394	-0.4
Japan yen	.006419	155.80	-0.6	Middle East/Africa			
Kazakhstan tenge	.002193	456.03	-10.1	Bahrain dinar	2.6546	.3767	-0.1
Macau pataca	.1238	8.0770	0.7	Egypt pound	.0197	50.8296	6.5
Malaysia ringgit	.2473	4.0433	-0.4	Israel shekel	.3323	3.0096	-5.5
New Zealand dollar	.5880	1.7007	-2.1	Kuwait dinar	3.2372	.3089	0.3
Pakistan rupee	.00360	277.600	-6.9	Oman sul rial	2.5994	3847	-0.2
Philippines peso	.01160	62.480	6.1	Qatar rial	.2743	3.646	-0.2
Singapore dollar	.7893	1.2670	-1.4	Saudi Arabia riyal	2.663	3.7551	0.1
South Korea won	.0007371	1356.63	-5.8	South Africa rand	.0625	15.9938	-3.4
Sri Lanka rupee	.0030487	328.01	5.9	Close Net Chg % Chg YTD Chg (%)			
Taiwan dollar	.03152	31.790	1.2	WSJ Dollar Index	95.15	-0.54	-0.80
Thailand baht	.03037	32.730	4.5	Sources: Tullett Prebon, Dow Jones Market Data			

COMMODITIES

wsj.com/market-data/commodities

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures						
	Open	Contract High hi Low lo	Settle	Chg	Open Interest	
Copper-High (CMX) -25,000 lbs.; \$ per lb.						
Sept	6.5370	6.5800	6.5365	6.5770	0.0760	3,269
Dec	6.6135	6.6805	6.5725	6.6645	0.0715	166,031
Gold (CMX) -100 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Sept	4426.30	4510.00	4426.00	4491.70	125.40	495
Oct	4402.00	4523.50	4392.80	4504.90	124.20	48,801
Nov	4419.00	4534.30	4416.80	4523.10	124.60	626
Dec	4436.40	4558.50	4426.70	4539.90	125.30	314,259
Jan'27	4493.60	4550.70	4493.60	4559.70	125.60	540
Feb	4472.00	4594.70	4462.70	4576.20	126.10	32,517
Palladium (NYM) -50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Sept	1421.50	1426.00	1421.50	1425.90	79.30	2
Dec	1359.00	1443.00	1351.00	1439.90	79.40	15,923
Platinum (NYM) -50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Sept	1853.00	1887.90	1853.00	1828.40	68.60	36
Oct	1772.20	1845.20	1761.30	1834.00	69.40	45,131
Silver (CMX) -5,000 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Sept	65.555	67.300	65.440	66.973	2.250	558
Dec	66.170	68.600	65.775	67.704	2.241	86,099
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM) -100,000 bbls.; \$ per bbl.						
Oct	90.70	93.14 ▲	89.57	91.30	0.29	248,095
Nov	87.89	89.46	86.80	88.03	-0.25	183,804
Dec	84.98	85.60	83.80	84.79	-0.46	200,365
Jan'27	82.27	82.65	81.10	83.91	-0.57	119,703
June	74.23	74.47	73.27	73.53	-0.85	132,549
Dec	70.92	71.18	70.10	70.14	-0.92	165,637
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM) -42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Oct	4.6572	4.6986	4.5799	4.5936	-0.0886	65,379
Nov	4.4760	4.5136	4.4151	4.4250	-0.0701	51,562
Gasoline-NY RB0B (NYM) -42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Oct	3.0803	3.1606	3.0539	3.1349	-0.0311	98,480
Nov	2.9373	2.9761	2.8911	2.9589	-0.0207	74,725
Natural Gas (NYM) -10,000 MMBtu; \$ per MMBtu.						
Oct	2.998	3.026	2.885	2.913	-0.043	322,872
Nov	3.123	3.150	3.024	3.037	-0.053	268,984
Dec	3.589	3.606	3.488	3.501	-0.051	174,017
Jan'27	4.004	4.026	3.899	3.909	-0.061	178,505
March	2.963	2.975	2.892	2.905	-0.031	159,987
April	2.816	2.828	2.760	2.764	-0.031	127,448

	Contract					Open interest	
	Open	High	Low	Settle	Chg		
Agriculture Futures							
Corn (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
Sept	518.00	518.00		503.00	515.25	-3.50 1,803	
Oct	542.50	542.75	526.50		540.75	-2.75 1,001,146	
Oats (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
Sept	356.00	356.00	356.00	342.50	-5.00		
Dec	375.50	376.25	360.50		368.50	-5.75 2,940	
Soybeans (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
Sept	1295.50	1302.75	1284.00		1306.25	4.50 227	
Nov	1308.50	1319.00	1290.25		1316.25	6.00 486,923	
Soybean Meal (CBT)-100 tons; \$ per ton.							
Sept	339.50	345.10 ▲	335.00		342.50	6.00 874	
Dec	349.90	356.40 ▲	344.50		355.50	5.90 320,908	
Soybean Oil (CBT)-60,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Sept	71.39	71.45	71.05		69.50	-1.00 679	
Dec	70.92	71.01	69.26		70.04	-0.92 256,007	
Rough Rice (CBT)-2,000 cwt.; \$ per cwt.							
Sept	15.26	15.26	15.26		15.24	... 95	
Nov	15.66	15.84	15.65		15.70	-0.03 11,693	
Wheat (CBT)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
Sept	729.25	729.25	728.50		736.00	-18.75 219	
Dec	774.25	776.00	730.50		754.25	-19.75 275,637	
Wheat (KC)-5,000 bu.; cents per bu.							
Sept	803.00	803.00	803.00		798.50	-16.25 111	
Dec	833.75	836.00	797.25		815.50	-18.75 177,110	
Cattle-Feeder (CME)-50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Sept	320.250	327.750	320.250	325.850	6.875	7,484	
Oct	315.825	323.475	315.750	321.100	6.725	26,075	
Cattle-Live (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Oct	210.525	215.450	210.425	214.300	4.125	105,461	
Dec	212.275	217.600	212.150	216.125	4.100	82,926	
Hogs-Lean (CME)-40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Oct	83.475	84.475	83.175	83.450	-3.25	125,068	
Dec	73.975	75.150	73.750	73.925	-4.00	79,131	
Lumber (CME)-27,500 bd ft. \$ per 1,000 bd ft.							
Sept	563.00	578.00	562.00		574.00	10.50 1,197	
Nov	558.00	572.00	553.00		570.50	15.00 8,816	
Milk (CME)-200,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Sept	16.20	16.34	16.18		16.33	...	6,012
Oct	16.57	16.72 ▼	16.41		16.70	.11	7,005
Cocoa (ICE-US)-10 metric tons; \$ per ton.							
Sept	6,166	6,166	6,166		6,057	-197	170
Dec	6,255	6,319	6,025		6,174	-99	77,627
Coffee (ICE-US)-37,500 lbs.; cents per lb.							
Sept	325.50	327.45	320.00		324.35	-4.05	83
Dec	297.95	300.00	289.75		295.35	-2.75	85,843
Sugar-World (ICE-US)-112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.							

	Contract			Settle	Chg	Open interest
	Open	High	Low			
Oct	18.65	18.67	17.65	18.07	-6.3	438,194
Sept	19.61	19.61	18.68	19.04	-6.0	403,654
March'27						
Surg-Domestic (ICE-US) -112,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Nov	38.00	38.00	38.00	38.00	-1.00	624
Jan'27	39.00	39.00	39.00	39.00	-1.00	1,278
Cotton (ICE-US) -50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	85.53	85.53	82.62	83.36	-3.02	173
Dec	88.55	89.50	86.10	86.45	-2.48	193,080
Orange Juice (ICE-US) -15,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Sept	137.75	137.75	137.75	137.75	6.35	95
Nov	149.05	156.45	148.60	155.75	6.35	8,694

Interest Rate Futures

Ultra Treasury Bonds (CBT) - \$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	110-100	110-280	110-100	110-180	14.0	14,154
Dec	109-260	110-160	109-240	110-040	14.0	2,390,874
Treasury Bonds (CBT) - \$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	108-300	109-160	108-290	109-070	14.0	11,589
Dec	108-130	109-020	108-110	108-220	13.0	1,803,765
Treasury Notes (CBT) - \$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	107-245	108-030	107-230	107-295	8.0	49,930
Dec	107-160	107-280	107-145	107-210	8.0	5,192,270
5 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT) - \$100,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	105-230	105-317	105-230	105-272	6.2	73,795
Dec	105-185	105-275	105-180	105-225	6.2	6,249,725
2 Yr. Treasury Notes (CBT) - \$200,000; pts 32nds of 100%						
Sept	102-232	102-269	102-230	102-255	3.0	68,989
Dec	102-182	102-226	102-180	102-204	3.1	4,262,463
30 Day Federal Funds (CBT) - \$5,000,000; 100 - daily avg.						
Sept	96.3000	96.3175	96.3000	96.3150	-0.175	234,140
Oct	96.2100	96.2450	96.2050	96.2400	-0.050	625,513
Three-Month SOFR (CME) - \$1,000,000; 100 - daily avg.						
June	96.3525	96.3550	▼ 96.3525	96.3550	...	1,346,111
Dec	95.9150	95.9750	▼ 95.9100	95.9650	-0.0600	1,751,424

Currency Futures

Japanese Yen (CME) - ¥12,500,000; \$ per 100¥						
Sept	6306	6443	6294	6435	-0.137	316,884
Dec	6351	6489	6339	6480	-0.138	124,280
Canadian Dollar (CME) - CAD 100,000; \$ per CAD						
Sept	.7226	.7269	.7225	.7256	-0.028	295,231

	Contract			Settle	Chg	Open interest
	Open	High	Low			
Dec	.7260	.7298	.7256	.7286	.0027	45,673
British Pound (CME) - £62,500; \$ per £						
Sept	1.3484	1.3548	1.3480	1.3538	.0052	257,918
Dec	1.3483	1.3549	1.3482	1.3538	.0050	62,301
Swiss Franc (CME) - CHF 125,000; \$ per CHF						
Sept	1.2314	1.2429	1.2309	1.2406	.0095	84,179
Dec	1.2438	1.2556	1.2436	1.2533	.0095	48,032
Australian Dollar (CME) - AUD 100,000; \$ per AUD						
Sept	.7171	.7207	.7158	.7206	.0039	305,360
Dec	.7157	.7195	.7147	.7194	.0039	107,248
Mexican Peso (CME) - MXN 500,000; \$ per MXN						
Sept	.05885	.05908	.05868	.05905	.00021	286,268
Dec	.05844	.05865	.05829	.05863	.00020	

MARKETS

Owning a Refinery Is More Profitable Than Building One

By COLLIN EATON

President Trump urged a gathering of oil executives at the White House on Tuesday to build more refineries capable of pumping out fuel, part of his bid to bring down gasoline prices before the November midterms.

That is a tough argument to make. Owning an oil refinery is a profitable proposition in the U.S. right now. Building a new one? Not so much.

The paradox helps explain why U.S. refinery operators that are making record profits in the midst of historic fuel-supply disruptions in the Middle East, Russia and China have no plans to expand their fleet. Put simply, the oil companies don't expect the boom times to last.

At the meeting, the president and oil executives discussed other ways to expand the nation's refining capacity, including cutting regulations, speeding up the permitting process and making additional investments.

"The President made clear that he wants lower gas prices at the pump for Americans. The refiners and distributors shared that goal and commitment," a U.S. official said.

The White House said Trump's surprise deal to take a direct stake in a swath of Venezuela's oil reserves means the country needs more refining capacity to absorb barrels as production comes online.

Among those gathered were executives from **Chevron**, **Valero Energy**, **Marathon Petroleum** and **PBF Energy**, among others.

ExxonMobil, the nation's third-largest refiner, didn't send a representative.

Some companies were initially wary of attending, given Trump's recent attacks on the industry for not cutting gasoline prices more quickly.

Americans paid about \$4.10 a gallon on average at the pump on Tuesday, according to AAA, up from \$2.98 before the start of the conflict in Iran. The problem: Much of what is driving fuel prices higher is beyond the control of the president and what he has called his favorite industry.



The U.S. has 128 fewer refineries today than it did in 1982. A refinery in Linden, N.J.

Six months into the Iran war, the supply crunch for diesel, jet fuel and gasoline has overtaken upheaval in the crude-oil market as the energy industry's primary concern.

To keep up with demand, U.S. refineries have been running at over 97% of their collective capacity in recent weeks, near their highest rate in about eight years, according to the Energy Information Administration.

"The utilization that we've seen can't be sustained for the long term," Darren Woods, the chief executive of Exxon, told investors in late July. "I think this refining challenge is going to be with the world for a while."

Some companies are putting off scheduled maintenance to take advantage of lofty margins for diesel and other fuels. What is known as the crack spread—the difference refiners can pocket buying crude and selling fuel—recently hit a record above \$100 a barrel for diesel. That has helped pad the industry's bottom line. The top six American energy companies that turn oil into refined products made a combined \$24.7 billion on fuel-making in the second quarter, nearly five times as much as a year earlier.

But building new refineries isn't economic—it would require an investment of several billion dollars and three to five years of construction. The industry expects the energy market to have found its footing long before then.

Instead, companies have focused on expanding and modernizing existing facilities. "Nobody's going to go out and make a huge multibillion-dollar investment based on three months of record margins," said Robert Campbell, an analyst at Energy Aspects in New York. "You really think there's going to be another situation where Russia's being

attacked, and there's a crisis in the Middle East, and China has slowly stopped exporting products?"

The U.S. has been closing refineries for decades—it has 128 fewer than it did in 1982. The newest was completed in 1977; roughly a quarter were built more than a century ago.

The obstacles to building new ones are formidable. For one thing, acquiring the myriad permits needed from federal, state and local governments would be a major undertaking. The oil industry has tried for years to persuade Congress to overhaul the permitting process to clear the way for pipelines and other energy infrastructure.

Gasoline demand, meanwhile, is expected to decline over the long term as drivers buy more electric vehicles and engines become more efficient.

"Who wants to invest in something that, by the time

you build it, the demand is down?" said John Auers, marketing director of refined fuels at oil-and-gas data analytics firm Novi Labs.

Auers estimates oil companies have room to add 400,000 barrels a day of refining capacity by expanding their facilities in Texas, Louisiana and other Gulf Coast states over the next 20 years. That is roughly equivalent to the capacity of one large refinery.

Analysts are skeptical that new projects can get off the ground.

Trump said in March that a startup called America First Refining would open the first new U.S. oil refinery in 50 years in Brownsville, Texas. The \$300 billion deal was meant to bring jobs and economic growth to South Texas.

Yet the region lacks infrastructure to get sufficient oil to a refinery, and financing such a project would be a challenge, as would securing permits.

Meanwhile, big oil companies are spending hundreds of millions of dollars to shift refinery production from gasoline—the fuel most affected by the rise of EVs—to diesel, petrochemicals and lubricants.

Exxon is expected to spend about \$2 billion to upgrade its Baytown, Texas, refinery to make more diesel and lubricant base stocks—and less gasoline—starting in 2028. Chevron has a similar, smaller project at its Pascagoula refinery in Mississippi.

Chevron Chief Executive Mike Wirth has suggested his company would continue pivoting toward oil production versus refining over the long term. "I love our refining business," he told investors last year. "I don't want to say that we would never do something in refining because if it were the right opportunity, we could. But we've long had a view that we want to be a more upstream-weighted company."

Investor Booth on Trying to Beat the Market

By JACK PITCHER

David Booth launched his investing firm 45 years ago, from his Brooklyn Heights apartment. It just passed \$1 trillion in assets under management.

Milestones, and perhaps especially those punctuated with 13-digit achievements, can serve as a good time to reflect, says Booth, the chairman of Dimensional Fund Advisors. And Booth, who turns 80 this year, is choosing this moment to reflect on his life and five-decade investing career in a new book, "Stay Calm: Learn to Embrace Uncertainty in Investing and Life" (Authors Equity, 220 pages.).

The book, published Sept. 1, details Booth's early years at the forefront of the index-fund revolution. Investing, he writes, is really just a bet on human innovation—and one that is worth the risks.

In an interview with The Wall Street Journal, Booth discussed why market uncertainty is a good thing, the "miracle" of modern investing access, and why he's optimistic about the future.

WSJ: You spent decades touting passive, follow-the-market stock investing. What's it been like to watch that go from an obscure, unpopular strategy to a domi-



David Booth, chairman of Dimensional Fund Advisors.

nant force in U.S. investing? **DAVID BOOTH:** It's been refreshing. In 1971 when I got out of school, people fought these ideas. You'd talk to fund managers or journalists, and they'd say, "You eggheads. You don't understand markets."

Still, it's not clear how many people have really got the message about how difficult the market is to beat. If you look at the growth in index funds, there's been similar growth in trading volumes. Some people are trading in and out of these, trying to time the market.

And then you've got the growth of prediction markets and all kinds of wild investing strategies. We've still got room

for better investor education.

WSJ: What do you hope people take away from the book? **BOOTH:** The book is not about how to invest; it's about how to *think* about investing. There's a lot of anxiety right now, but if people better understood how public markets work, they'd be far more likely to invest and stay invested. If there were no uncertainty, there'd be no risk, and all investments would yield the exact same riskless return. Uncertainty creates the opportunity.

The book isn't overly technical. I want it to be accessible. My parents grew up in the Great Depression and fought in World War II. They never really invested in public markets and they probably had a more difficult retirement than they should have. They viewed themselves as outsiders, and thought the insiders would take advantage of them and take all their money. And so they never invested.

Today, if you get the market return, you've done about as well as the pros. That's a miracle, I think. We ought to have a ticker-tape parade for that kind of conclusion.

WSJ: Stock indexes today have historically high concentration in megacap technology and AI stocks. Does that

make you uneasy?

BOOTH: That's primarily true for the U.S. market. If you hold half your money in the U.S. and half internationally, a large part of that concentration risk goes away. As for AI, we don't know who the eventual winners will be.

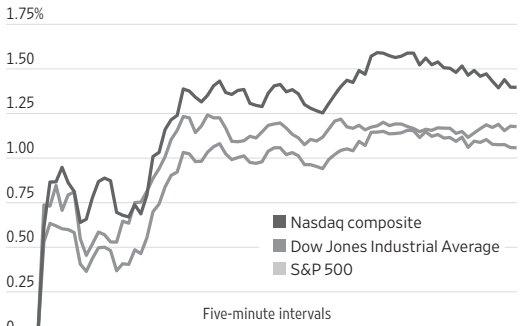
Think back to the 19th-century gold rush. Who was the big winner? Levi Strauss did pretty well. It wasn't necessarily the gold miners themselves. That's why you want to buy the whole market rather than bet on individual names.

WSJ: How should investors mentally process major market panics, like the crash during the outbreak of the pandemic in 2020?

BOOTH: Every down market I've lived through over 55 years triggers the same reaction: People see the market down 20% or 30% and think, "I better get out." What we try to explain is that markets price in bad news rapidly to reach a level where expected returns are positive again.

When bad things happen to firms and individuals, they don't just sit there and take it. They figure out how to get back on track. When that ingenuity is applied, the whole economy is likely to get back on track faster than you might think.

Index performance on Thursday



Fed Talk Bolsters Markets

Continued from page B1 now a coin flip, according to CME FedWatch, down from a 70% likelihood Wednesday.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average rose around 624 points, or 1.2%, to 53686. The S&P 500 added 1.1%, while the Nasdaq composite climbed 1.4%.

"I think it's a question of how much time can the Fed buy itself. Can they credibly not raise rates in September through the year-end?" said Tim Holland, chief investment officer at Orion. "I think they're worried if they raise rates they will do real damage to the market and the economy for factors that are important, but factors that could also maybe go away in a weekend."

Nvidia shares rose 1.8% after the world's only \$5 trillion company agreed to buy **Hugging Face** in a deal worth \$12.93 billion, a value matching the decimal representation of

the unicode ID for the Hugging Face emoji.

Nvidia is increasing efforts to develop open-weight models to counter the dominance of Chinese models and their threat to U.S. artificial-intelligence companies. Hugging Face, which was recently hacked by a rogue OpenAI model, is a platform for users to collaborate on machine-learning projects.

"Obviously, there are all these questions about the sustainability of the AI capex cycle, the build-out, all of it," Holland said. "But that just speaks to, at least in Nvidia's case, optimism, forward thinking, being willing to cut a very big check for a company that hasn't been around all that long."

Tesla rose 5.4% on high hopes for its robotaxi launch Thursday night. **Meta** climbed 3% after it released a new AI model.

Brent crude, the global gauge, ended a three-day winning streak, edging down 0.1% to \$95.52 a barrel. U.S. crude futures added 0.3% to \$91.30.

The yen extended its rally against the dollar, bringing its two-day gain to about 3%. Hawkish comments from a Bank of Japan board member Wednesday have raised the possibility of bigger or more frequent interest-rate hikes.

Oura's IPO Projects High Growth for Fitness Tool

By JASMINE LI

Smart-ring maker Oura made its IPO paperwork public on Thursday, offering a view of the high margins and committed user base behind the buzzy fitness tracker.

The San Francisco-based company aims to list on the Nasdaq as soon as this month. It is expected to fetch a valuation well above the \$11 billion mark achieved in a funding round last year, The Wall Street Journal previously re-

ported. For the nine months ended June 30, Oura posted revenue of \$1.21 billion, up 74% from the same period last year. The company said it recently turned profitable and earned \$60.8 million in the period, up from \$1.6 million in the same period last year.

Founded in Finland in 2013, Oura is popular among health and longevity enthusiasts. In recent years, the company has signed high-profile deals with sports leagues and celebrity ambassadors, and it cited the

Defense Department as a revenue generator.

Its rings track metrics such as heart rate, temperature and sleep quality and retail for \$349 to \$499. Subscribers then pay \$5.99 a month, or \$69.99 a year, for full access to insights on their health. The company said it has five million paying members.

The filing revealed a lucrative—and sticky—subscription business. Gross margins on memberships were 89% in the nine months ended June 30,

the company said. Subscribers opened the Oura app more than 3.5 times a day on average in the first three quarters of the fiscal year, it said.

In the nine months ended June 30, hardware sales accounted for about 80% of revenue, and subscriptions made up the remaining 20%.

The company provided details on what would be an enviable user base for most companies: 72% are women, 42% of subscribers are ages 30 to 45 and 31% are under 29.

HEARD_{ON THE} STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

Boeing’s Supplier Deal Bleeds Red Ink

The aviation giant, which paid \$8.4 billion for the fuselage maker, has since uncovered large liabilities it initially hadn’t identified

Boeing is reporting losses again, and some are less obvious than others.

The aircraft maker posted a pre-tax loss of \$339 million for the first half of 2026, after briefly turning profitable last year thanks to asset sales. That official figure didn’t fully capture Boeing’s red ink.

Last December, Boeing completed its biggest acquisition in years, when it paid \$8.4 billion to buy its longtime—and visibly struggling—fuselage supplier, Spirit AeroSystems. Since then, Boeing uncovered hundreds of millions of dollars in liabilities at Spirit beyond what it initially recognized after the deal closed.

The higher obligations amount to real losses, economically speaking, because they mean greater costs for Boeing on deeply unfavorable contracts at below-market prices. Thanks to the quirks of the accounting rules, those losses don’t appear on Boeing’s income statement and are relegated to footnotes about the acquisition.

For investors, it is yet another headwind. Boeing shareholders endured one setback after another since the stock peaked in 2019. It has fallen by more than half since then. A parade of safety lapses included two fatal airline crashes, as well as a door-plug blowout during an **Alaska Airlines** flight.

Boeing acquired Spirit AeroSystems in a push to bring more of its manufacturing capabilities in-house. It owned Spirit’s factories once before, having sold the operations in 2005 as part of a cost-cutting and outsourcing strategy that meant relying more heavily on outside suppliers before final assembly.

Spirit built the fuselage of the Alaska Airlines plane where the

door plug blew off midflight. A federal investigation faulted Boeing for the incident. While no one was killed or seriously injured, the episode forced Boeing to bring more of its supply chain under its own roof.

The numbers related to the Spirit acquisition signal something is amiss. While Boeing paid \$8.4 billion—including common stock, loan settlements and debt repayments—it initially allocated \$10 billion of the purchase price to the intangible asset goodwill as of Dec. 31 last year.

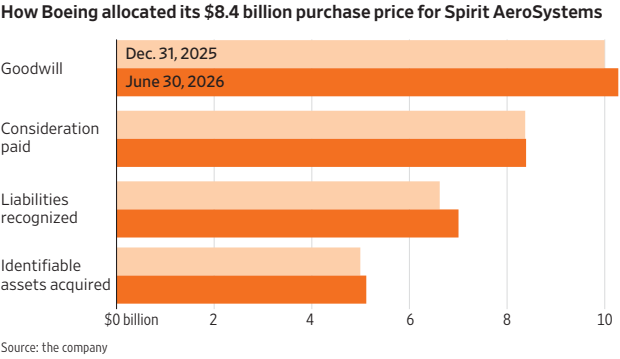
This means that, after scouring Spirit’s business for all identifiable assets and liabilities, Boeing’s management determined the assets’ fair value was \$1.6 billion less than the combined liabilities. The \$10 billion of goodwill represented the difference between the purchase price and Spirit’s net identifiable assets, which in this case were negative.

The accounting rules give companies one year to adjust their purchase-price allocations. By mid-year, the net deficit had grown, and so did the goodwill. As of June 30, Boeing said the identifiable assets’ fair value was \$1.9 billion less than the combined liabilities, and it boosted the goodwill to \$10.3 billion, which exceeded Boeing’s total equity.

The main reason for the change was a \$455 million increase in the estimated liability for certain customer contracts, which brought their fair value to about \$1.5 billion as of June 30. Boeing described these as “off-market customer contracts” where “the terms of the contract deviated from the terms that a market participant could have achieved.”



Boeing bought Spirit in a push to bring more of its supply chain in-house.



In plain English, the contracts are a money pit, and they are proving to be more costly than management initially believed.

It is rare for companies to allocate more than 100% of an acquisition’s price to goodwill, which isn’t amortized. It raises the question: If the target company’s liabilities ex-

ceeded the identifiable assets, then why did the acquirer buy it?

The numbers suggest Boeing did so because it had to. About 58% of Spirit’s revenue came from Boeing in 2024, its last full year as an independent company. Spirit was Boeing’s sole-source supplier for nearly all the products Spirit sold

to it, and Spirit itself was drowning in losses. When Boeing bought the company it was preserving its supply chain, and for that Spirit extracted a large premium.

Boeing’s accounting for the Spirit purchase amounts to a double whammy, with goodwill increasing by hundreds of millions of dollars after Boeing uncovered the additional liabilities. But because it identified them within a year of completing the deal, the accounting rules let Boeing avoid a hit to its income statement and absorb the deterioration directly onto the balance sheet by increasing goodwill. (Boeing also made some minor adjustments to the values of other assets and liabilities it acquired from Spirit.)

A Boeing spokesman declined to answer questions about the company’s accounting for the purchase. In a statement, he said: “Boeing’s integration of former Spirit AeroSystems commercial operations is progressing well and remains an important part of strengthening the company’s production system, quality performance and capability to meet future rate increases.”

The accounting adjustments tell a more complicated story. Even if the acquisition is helping improve production quality, Boeing isn’t uncovering hidden financial upside. If it were, management would be finding more value in what it bought as time progressed, not less. And after the one-year true-up window closes, any further bad news will hit the income statement directly. After all the pain Boeing has inflicted on its shareholders and the public, it can’t afford another misstep.

—Jonathan Weil

Why We’ll Have to Get Used To ‘Meh’ Job Reports

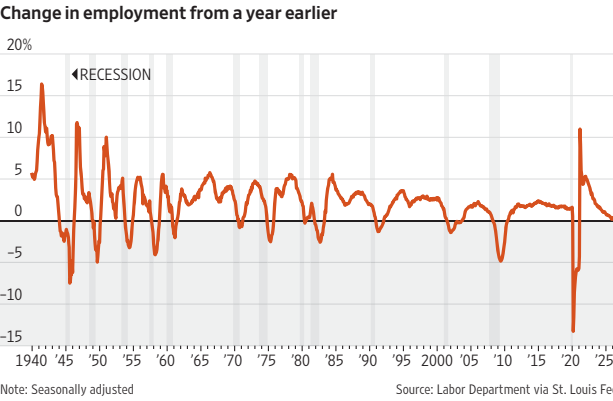
The economy probably doesn’t need to generate all that many jobs to keep the labor market steady. But that won’t keep low job growth from feeling dissatisfying for many Americans, and challenging for investors.

Economists think Friday’s jobs report will show the U.S. added a seasonally adjusted 53,000 jobs in August. That would be a step up from July’s unexpected loss of 23,000 jobs, and better than the average gain over the previous 12 months of 26,000.

It’s still a lot less than people are accustomed to—not just when the job market was bouncing back from the pandemic, but before it hit too. Over the five years ending in 2019, the U.S. added an average of 191,000 jobs a month.

What Friday’s report will actually show is a bit of a crash. Temporary Protected Status ended for about 350,000 Haitians at the end of July, which could dent the employment figures. Any jobs people got hired onto for the World Cup are off the table. On the other hand, July registered a large drop in state and local education employment that might have been due more to calendar quirks than anything else and could be unwound.

Stepping back from month-to-month noise, economists reckon the U.S. simply doesn’t have enough available young people to deliver much job growth. The population is aging, while the immigration clampdown has reduced



the supply of workers.

The plus side of that is that even limited hiring can keep the unemployment rate stable. Economists think Friday’s report will show an August unemployment rate of 4.1%, even with July and down a bit from 4.3% a year earlier.

Relatively low unemployment aside, the labor-market environment probably doesn’t feel dynamic to many Americans. In the past, the low pace of job gains the U.S. is now experiencing has typically occurred just before, during, or right after recessions. Now it could just be a feature of the economy—some demographers believe growth in the working-age population will effectively stall out in the decade ahead.

This creates a challenging envi-

ronment for companies and investors, too. The U.S. business environment has always been underpinned by population increase—more workers, so more people earning wages, so more money to spend on cars and clothes and so forth. What will it mean if even in good times growth in the number of people with salaries to spend is at standstill?

The hope is that those salaries will be bigger—that artificial intelligence delivers on promised productivity gains, that a large portion of those flow into higher pay, and spending flourishes. But even if all that happens, it is hard to figure out what the contours of the economy will be, who will win, and who will lose.

—Justin Lahart

Microsoft Investors Get A New Black Box

Microsoft is rejiggering its financial reporting—and while some of the changes will lead to more transparency, others will do the opposite.

On the bright side, after years of complaints by investors, Microsoft will finally report revenue in actual dollars for Azure, its flagship cloud platform and primary growth engine.

After the market closed on Wednesday, the company also released Azure revenue figures for the past eight quarters, under a newly narrowed definition of Azure that no longer includes certain coding tools, security software and specialized apps.

So now it can be told: Azure revenue was \$101.9 billion during the fiscal year ended June 30, up 40% from a year earlier.

By comparison, Microsoft’s total revenue last year increased 18% to \$331.8 billion.

But the company won’t be reporting Azure’s cost of revenue, operating expenses or margins. Azure will remain tucked inside a larger segment, limiting visibility into its profits.

This points to the most glaring problem with Microsoft’s new disclosure regime.

The company is actually reducing its number of reporting segments to two from three, rather than disaggregating them to show more granular detail about each major business line’s expenses and profitability.

One of the segments, called

“Agents and Infra” (short for infrastructure), is a monster, with 81% of Microsoft’s revenue last year and 88% of its operating income.

That is the group that will include Azure and other cloud businesses. The other segment, called “Devices and Consumer,” is tiny by comparison.

Microsoft previously had three reporting segments, the largest of which accounted for 42% of revenue under the old framework.

In effect, the company’s management has just smoothed the bulk of its operations into a single segment, with a smaller stub to hold leftovers such as Xbox, search advertising and devices.

The company will report cost of revenue, operating expenses and operating income for both of its segments.

But investors won’t get that same level of disclosure across all of Microsoft’s major products and service offerings.

Microsoft will report quarterly revenue for several of them, including Azure, as well as revenue and a gross-margin percentage for its overall cloud business. But expense and margin data across the product lines for the most part will remain elusive.

Opacity has long been the norm with Microsoft’s financial reporting.

It will still be a black box under the new structure, just with a few new touches of gray.

—Jonathan Weil

MONEY & INVESTING

Stock Spotlight

Snowflake
The cloud-storage company reported a narrower quarterly loss, saying artificial intelligence drove its business. Its stock surged 17%.

Broadcom
The company was bullish about demand for its custom chips over the next two years; its shares declined 2.7%.

Ultragenyx Pharmaceutical
The pharmaceutical company said a drug in its pipeline failed to meet its primary endpoint in a late-stage trial; its stock plunged about 44%.

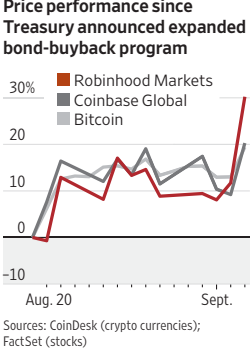
Hewlett Packard Enterprise
The company’s results beat expectations, helped by artificial-intelligence demand. It also lifted its long-term goals. Shares increased 5%.

Impala Platinum
Higher precious-metal prices

gave the South African miner’s earnings a boost; its shares climbed 9%.

Victoria’s Secret
Shares fell 13%, the bra retailer boosted its full-year outlook but reported second-quarter sales below Wall Street estimates.

FRIDAY’S EVENTS:
◆ Economic data: U.S. employment report for August at 8:30 a.m. ET, average hourly earnings



Bitcoin Retakes \$80,000

Bitcoin broke back above \$80,000 on Thursday as global bond yields retreated from their 2026 highs, sparking a rally across cryptocurrency-linked stocks.

The largest cryptocurrency recently traded around \$81,759, up about 6% from its 4 p.m. Eastern time level on Wednesday. Bitcoin had pulled back from its late-August surge

above \$80,000, which was triggered by the Treasury Department’s expanded bond-buyback program about two weeks ago.

Thursday’s resurgence lifted major cryptocurrency-related stocks.

Shares of popular trading app Robinhood surged 17% Thursday to lead gains in the S&P 500. Coinbase Global, the largest crypto exchange in the U.S., gained 10% as the index’s second-best performer.

—Vicky Ge Huang



\$5.35 Million
Travis Kelce snapped up a home near Cleveland **M2**

\$5 Million
A condo sale this week broke the Provincetown record **M10**



Life’s a (Private) Beach

On Martha’s Vineyard, ‘beach keys’ are the ultimate status symbol and can cost hundreds of thousands of dollars



Lisa Herrick uses a key to access a private beach in Aquinnah with her dog, Otis.



CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: CHARLIE RIEDEL/AP; NAUSET MEDIA; CODY O’LOUGHLIN FOR WSJ

By E.B. SOLOMONT

On a brilliant August afternoon, retired architect Tyler Smith hops into his “beach car”—a dented and sandy RAV4 with 130,000 miles on it—and maneuvers onto a grassy farm road on Martha’s Vineyard’s south shore. It is less than a mile from his house to Black Point Beach in Chilmark. When we arrive, he stops at a weathered wooden fence, uses a saw-toothed key to open a padlock, and swings open the gate before pulling into a nearly empty

parking lot. We cross a boardwalk and step onto one of the Massachusetts island’s most coveted private beaches, where entry is limited to those with physical keys that can cost \$400,000 or more. When his now-adult kids were young, says Smith, 84, “we used to spend all day here, swimming and riding the surf.” On Martha’s Vineyard, “beach keys” are the ultimate status symbol, giving affluent property owners entry to secluded stretches of sand that are off-limits to

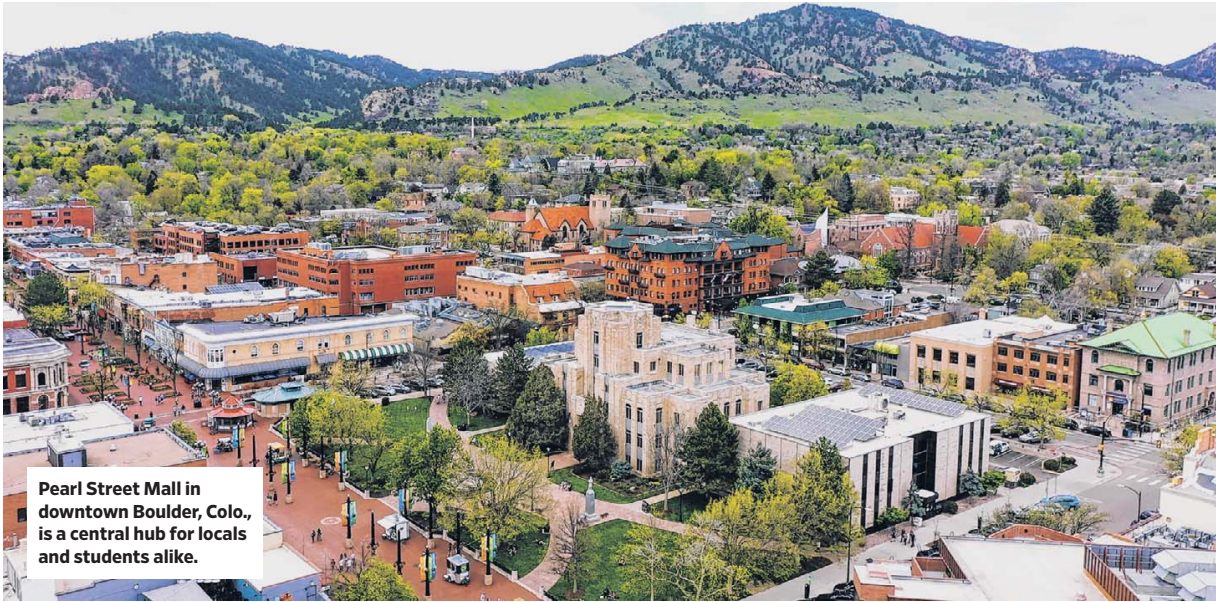
\$650,000
Recent sale price of a key to Hancock Beach

the masses. Keys come with deeded ownership to a sliver of non-buildable beachfront; they often stay in the same family for generations, though a handful sell on the open market each year. In recent years, prices for these keys have shot up thanks to wealthy buyers—seemingly undeterred by the threat of erosion—clamoring for privacy and convenience amid the island’s swelling popularity. In 2003, a key to Quansoo Beach in Chilmark

Please turn to page M4

Dorms Be Damned: Parents Spend Millions on Student Homes

Mom and Dad drive the market in America’s priciest college towns



Pearl Street Mall in downtown Boulder, Colo., is a central hub for locals and students alike.

By JESSICA FLINT

IN AMERICA’S HIGHER-EDUCATION corridors, the campus boundary line doubles as a lucrative real-estate border. From New York City to Los Angeles, wealthy parents have long helped drive college-adjacent market demand by purchasing residences for student children. Now these purchases are shifting from pure investment to secondary family homes, real-estate agents say. Still, the parent playbook isn’t universal; in towns such as Wellesley, Mass., traditional buyers rule the block. Beyond property values, proximity to a campus can boost local vibrancy with public lectures, arts and events. We examined college-town ZIP Codes across five school types. Here are each category’s priciest markets, as ranked by median listing price according to July data from Realtor.com. (Realtor.com, operated by News Corp, developed this methodology exclusively for The Wall Street Journal.)

Please turn to page M6

PRIVATE PROPERTIES



Palm Beach’s ‘Ham and Cheese House’

A historic Palm Beach, Fla., estate, known locally as the Ham and Cheese House because of its alternating coral and brick exterior, is coming on the market for \$105 million.

FOR SALE
\$105 MILLION
13,200 sq. ft., 7 bedrooms, wine cellar, tunnel to beach

Officially named Casa Eleda, the house was designed around 1928 by Swiss-born architect Maurice Fatio for banker Mortimer Schiff and his wife, Adele, according to the 2020 book “An Illustrated History of Palm Beach.”

Eleda is Adele spelled backward. Marion H. Antonini, a former Xerox executive who was known as a turnaround specialist, bought the oceanfront property for \$15.975 million in 2013 with his wife, Penny Antonini, property records show. They completed a multiyear renovation that won a preservation award in 2017, said Penny. Marion died in 2021. Located in the estate section of Palm Beach, the Italian Romanesque-style home has seven bedrooms and about 13,200 square feet of interior space. When they bought the house, it was dark but had good bones, Penny said. “We appreciated the history and we wanted to retain it,” she said. In the courtyard, they added landscaping and re-

placed the swimming pool with one inspired by a church in Venice, Italy. The roughly 1-acre property has about 150 feet of ocean frontage. A rare tunnel under the road runs from the main residence to the beach, where the Antoninis built an oceanfront cabana, said listing agent Christian Angle of Christian Angle Real Estate. It’s one of six homes listed for more than \$100 million in Palm Beach, where the record home-sale price was set in 2023, when an oceanfront property traded for around \$170 million. The Antonini property’s size, provenance and water frontage support the price, Angle said. “The land alone is worth \$60 million,” he said. —E.B. Solomont



Travis Kelce has purchased a lakefront home in Ohio for \$5.35 million, according to people familiar with the deal and property records. The Kansas City Chiefs player closed on the house in March, a

Travis Kelce Buys Lakefront Ohio Home

few months before getting married to pop superstar Taylor Swift, the people said. The house is close to Cleveland and a private airport. Figurati Construction Group, owned by Gary Pellegrino, purchased the home for \$1.95 million in 2023, property records show. After an extensive renovation, the house was listed for \$6.99 million in 2024, according

to Zillow. It was most recently asking \$5.99 million. The 3.5-acre property in Bratenahl sits on the edge of Lake Erie, records show. Originally built around 1895, the roughly 21,000-square-foot home has eight bedrooms, according to the listing. The original ballroom is now a game room and home theater. The gatehouse was

SOLD
\$5.35 MILLION
21,000 sq. ft., 8 bedrooms, guest cottage



converted into a two-bedroom guest cottage. Swift has a real-estate portfolio including several historic homes, such as a circa-1930 mansion in Rhode Island and the former Samuel Goldwyn estate in Beverly

Hills, Calif. Kelce is gearing up for another season with the Kansas City Chiefs. In 2023, he purchased a \$5.5 million estate in Leawood, Kan., a suburb of Kansas City. Bratenahl is a few miles from where Kelce grew up in Cleveland Heights. The affluent village is on the shore of Lake Erie, with a median sale price of \$490,000 for the three months ending July 31, according to Redfin. David Ayers and Nick Zawitz of The Agency Cleveland represented both sides of the transaction. In a statement released through their team, Ayers and Zawitz said, “We’re thrilled for the new owners and so excited for Cleveland.” —Libertina Brandt and E.B. Solomont

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CALL OF THE THINGS I JUST FOUND TOO HARD TO SAY

LAUREN JAUREGUI // TRACK 03

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PRIVATE PROPERTIES

A ‘Glowing’ Fort Lauderdale Spec Home

A Florida spec property with about 145 feet of water frontage, clad in backlit quartzite that glows at night, is in contract to be sold for \$51 million, making it one of the priciest home sales in the city.

Developer Dov Stark purchased the roughly 0.4-acre lot for \$5.5 million in Fort Lauderdale, Fla., in 2024. After demolishing an older

IN CONTRACT

\$51
MILLION

15,000 sq. ft., 8-car garage, massage room, 80-foot pool

home, he spent more than \$35 million to build the new residence—with roughly 15,000 square feet of interior space—in just about 14 months. He listed the completed house for \$55 million in April.

Joelle Oiknine of ONE Sotheby’s International Realty declined to identify her clients but said the buyers rejected several “bland, white box” homes in Miami Beach and Golden Beach. “When they



got to Fort Lauderdale, they made us cancel all the other appointments,” Oiknine said. The deal is expected to close in January.

Stark said he was inspired to use backlit stone after visiting New York’s Perelman Performing Arts Center. “It looks like an ember in a fireplace that’s glowing from the inside,” he said. All of the interior walls and ceilings are covered in stone, leather, wood or fabric. “I didn’t buy one gallon of paint,”



Stark said. Amenities include an 80-foot outdoor pool.

The property is located in the Sunrise Intracoastal neighbor-

hood, a gated community where about a third of the homes are on the water. Fort Lauderdale has seen a string of big-ticket sales as wealthy buyers gravitate toward the city’s laid-back and boating-centric lifestyle.

Last year, a property with about 840 feet of water frontage sold for \$42.7 million. Hedge-funder Donald Sussman sold his 2.7-acre waterfront property for \$70 million in 2024.

—E.B. Solomont

A Seaside Estate in Palm Beach County

An oceanfront property in Palm Beach County, Fla., is coming on the market for \$59.95 million—more than three times its purchase price in 2018.

Freedom Mortgage founder and CEO Stanley Middleman and his wife, Roslyn Middleman, paid roughly \$19.88 million for the property in Ocean Ridge about eight years ago, records show.

The couple bought the house from the developer and have not made major changes, said listing

FOR SALE

\$59.95
MILLION

10,520 sq. ft., 5 bedrooms, club room, terraces, tiki hut

agent Nicholas Malinosky of Douglas Elliman, who is marketing the property with colleague Michael O’Connor.

He declined to comment on the seller but said his client is selling



because he purchased something else nearby. The Middlemans did not respond to requests for comment.

Set on 1.55 acres, the five-bedroom house has about 10,520 square feet of interior living space with wood paneling and fabric

wall coverings.

There is a club room with a full bar and fireplace, multiple terraces, an outdoor kitchen and a new tiki hut that the current owners added for beachfront seating.

Ocean Ridge is one of several small towns in the county that has attracted massive wealth since 2021. Just south of Manalapan, Ocean Ridge has only a handful of oceanfront estates, and the limited inventory has played a “massive role” in driving up property values, Malinosky said.

The asking price reflects that surge. “They’re not shooting for the stars,” he said of the Middlemans. “They’re aligning the property to sell this season.”

—E.B. Solomont

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MANSION

The Keys to The Beach

Continued from page M1

could be purchased for \$200,000, said Abby Rabinovitz of Tea Lane Associates. Last year, one sold for \$475,000, while a key at nearby Hancock Beach fetched \$650,000, property records show. “There’s more demand than supply. Prices reflect that,” said Tea Lane’s Alexis Holden, who has two clients who have waited for “well over a year” for the opportunity to buy a Chilmark beach key. In “Strangers: A Memoir of Marriage,” Belle Burden said her ex-husband bought her a key to Black Point Beach as a birthday gift. After they divorced, she kept the key, which cost \$310,000 in 2016, records show. Some keys come with rules saying they can never be sold at all.

But as property values on the island rise generally—a Herring Creek Farm home recently sold for a record \$43 million—beach keys are increasingly out of reach for most. That frustrates some locals, who say affluent keyholders enjoy one of the island’s most valuable resources at the expense of the public.

Mike Peters, a retired National Grid worker from Albany, N.Y., has rented a place on Martha’s Vineyard every summer since the 1990s. He could never afford to buy a place, or key, of his own, he said. “For the common people, you just visit and go home. You can’t own a piece of it.”

Behind the gates

With 124 miles of shoreline, Martha’s Vineyard has more than two dozen public and private beaches, plus town beaches that are open only to residents.

Some states don’t allow private



The Black Point Beach gate, left. At right, Black Point Beach looking toward Hancock Beach.



Lisa Herrick, left, at the Chilmark home she owns with her husband. It has windows on all sides.

beaches, but Massachusetts does. On Martha’s Vineyard, key beaches emerged decades ago, when families who owned large swaths of oceanfront farmland divvied up beach lots and sold strips of land to neighbors and friends. Key beaches aren’t neces-

sarily more beautiful than others, said Rabinovitz, but the big draw is their seclusion, quiet and easy parking. By contrast, public beaches and parking lots are often teeming with people.

Lisa Herrick, a clinical psychologist who lives primarily in Wash-



ington, D.C., inherited the key to a beach in Aquinnah from her parents. The beach has six or seven parking spots and is rarely crowded. “That’s one of the magical things about it,” said Herrick, who spent summers on the Vineyard as a kid. She and her husband paid \$740,000 for a three-bedroom house on the island in 2016. Having a beach key, she said, “doesn’t feel like a club, because you don’t go there to socialize with other people—but it feels like an incredible thing to have.”

Julie Flanders, a 13th-generation Vineyarder and real-estate agent, said her family has had a key to Goff Beach in Aquinnah for generations. “It seems elitist maybe,” Flanders added, but the small island absorbs a “crush” of people in the summer. “It’s just management of traffic flow.”

Not many keys come up for sale each year, however. Rabinovitz said roughly 40 beach lots have sold since 2019. Some are included in home sales, however, and a key can add several hundred thousand dollars in value to a property.

In May, Smith and his brother Whit Smith decided to list their 46-acre property, which they own jointly, for \$16 million. Tyler’s portion includes a two-bedroom house that he designed in the 1960s, plus two new studios. Included in the offering is Tyler’s beach key, which is likely worth \$450,000 to \$475,000, said Rabinovitz, the listing agent. Whit has his own key, which he is holding on to for now.

Higher key prices mirror the evolution of the Vineyard’s population, said filmmaker David Heilbroner, 69, who has a home in



The gate and road leading to Quansoo, a key beach in Chilmark that is one of the island’s most sought-after.

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MANSION



Lisa Stewart, left, works during the summer as a parking-lot attendant at Moshup Beach, above and below. Parking at Moshup, a public beach, costs \$30 a day.



maintain signs and locks; a warden monitors the beach to enforce its rules.

Many year-round residents resent the notion that wealthy second-home owners can purchase a piece of beach and prevent locals from using it, said Lisa Stewart, who moved to the island in the 1980s. Meanwhile, parking at public beaches has become a major issue as the island has gotten more crowded, said Stewart, who has sold real estate on the island and now works part time as a parking-lot attendant at Moshup Beach. “There’s beach stress related to it.”

Flanders said beach keys became more controversial as prices skyrocketed. “Island families had them forever. It was just a lifestyle thing,” she said. “When the pricing went up, it changed the perception.”

Heilbroner, a past president of the Hancock Beach Association, said the purpose of the association isn’t just to keep people out, but to preserve the beach. “It’s a very special place that deserves protection,” he said, adding: “There is the reality that the island is eroding.” A few years ago, when the beach parking lot came up for sale, the association bought it as a bulwark against the disappearing coastline, he said.

Heilbroner said he is both deeply appreciative—and uncomfortable—that he has access to a pristine beach while others don’t. “The starting line for everybody isn’t equal,” said Heilbroner. “Rich people can get a private beach and others can’t...I don’t pretend to be holier than anybody, I just do have these feelings.”



Policing the beach
Each key beach has its own flavor, etiquette and rules. Some beaches give owners a new key each summer to prevent too many from circulating.

Herrick said in her beach association, keys cannot be sold. “My parents gave it to me; I will give it to our kids,” she said. For the most part, keyholders self-police. They might politely

ask trespassers if they are lost, although locals all seem to have stories about overbearing keyholders who’ve kicked people off the beach. Black Point Beach Association has a handyman to

Chilmark and inherited a key to Hancock Beach. “Now people are building \$20 million houses routinely,” he said, “so a \$600,000 beach key is closer to a rounding error.”

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MANSION

College Material

Continued from page M1

1 In the City
New York University
New York | 10012

Vibe: Around Greenwich Village, dorms often share blocks with walk-ups, doorman rentals, luxury condos and co-ops.

Market drivers: Deep-pocketed parents purchase downtown Manhattan apartments for their college-age children, helping heat up neighborhoods that are already among New York’s most expensive. “This definitely fuels luxury condo sales,” says Roberta Golubock, a real-estate agent with Sotheby’s International Realty.

Inventory: “It wouldn’t be out of the ordinary for a parent to spend \$3 million or \$4 million for a two- or three-bedroom condo,” says Golubock, noting some buyers spend a lot more.

Pro tip: Parent buyers may prefer to purchase condos as opposed to co-ops, which often have strict regulations relating to occupancy and leasing, Golubock says.



2 Classic Liberal Arts Enclave
Wellesley College
Wellesley, Mass. | 02482

Vibe: Roughly 20 minutes southwest of Boston, the Wellesley real-estate market functions as an affluent suburban community rather than a student hub. The housing stock is mostly single-family houses, as most students live on campus.

Market drivers: Primary homeowners dominate. “People in Wellesley own their houses and live in them,” says Douglas Elliman real-estate agent Susan Bevilacqua, noting a strong draw among Boston commuters, first-time homeowners, trade-up families and relocations. There are some rentals; most are seasonal.

Inventory: Town center homes are sought after and regularly top \$1.8 million, Bevilacqua says, while neighborhoods off Cliff Road in Wellesley’s 02481 ZIP Code can push past \$3 million.

Pro tip: Start looking well before you need a house, because inventory has been lower and moves quickly, Bevilacqua says.



3 Ivy League
Harvard University
Cambridge, Mass. | 02138

Vibe: Urban density meets historic grandeur, with student rentals giving way to doorman buildings and estates fanning out along Brattle Street.

Market drivers: Faculty, families and out-of-state parents are seeking footholds. “People look at this area as an alternative to Boston’s Back Bay or Beacon Hill—urban living with a yard,” says Maggie Gold Seelig, founder of MGS Group Real Estate.

Inventory: “You can have a \$6 million...property right next to a house that is \$20 million,” Seelig says.

Pro tip: Details matter: Find an agent who understands hyper-niche pricing variables, like lot size, soil quality and historic guidelines, Seelig says.



4 Classic College Town
University of Colorado, Boulder
Boulder, Colo. | 80304

Vibe: Off-campus condo and townhouse rentals sit near multimillion-dollar single-family homes, all with eclectic architecture and close to mountain trails.

Market drivers: High-net-worth buyers corner luxury home sales, while shifting student trends—such as increased commuting—have recently cooled the parent condo market, says Joy Castillo, a Compass real-estate agent.

Inventory: Single-family homes start near \$700,000, average around \$1.3 million and can top \$10 million, Castillo says. Condos average around \$500,000.

Pro tip: “Pay close attention to rising HOA costs driven by soaring insurance rates,” Castillo says.



5 Big Ten
University of California, Los Angeles
Los Angeles | 90024

Vibe: In Westwood, standard off-campus student rentals fringe a high-end market bordering Beverly Hills.

Market drivers: “A lot of home buyers are parents of incoming freshmen,” says Craig White, a real-estate agent with Sotheby’s International Realty.

Inventory: Standard parent purchases often land between \$3.5 million and \$5 million, White says, though options range from \$2.5 million fixer-uppers to \$16 million-plus estates.

Pro tip: “Don’t delay on writing offers,” White says, citing a fast-moving inventory and intense competition.

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MANSION

My earliest inspiration for preparing food in the kitchen was making deviled eggs with my mother when I was 5. She wasn't a particularly great cook, so they were basic.

What I felt most was a sense of accomplishment. Before tests for learning disabilities, I had a hard time learning from books. In my mother's kitchen, I excelled at working with my hands.

I was an only child and grew up on the Upper East Side of Manhattan. We lived in a back apartment of a prewar building.

My father, Bill, was a Wall Street attorney who, in 1965, left law and became Joe Allen's partner in his newly opened theater-district restaurant. My mother, Dorothy, was fun-loving but tough on me. She had to be.

My passion for cooking and Saturday morning TV led me to ads for the Easy-Bake Oven. I wanted to see how you could bake a cake with a lightbulb, so my mother bought me one.

My parents divorced when I was 6, and their separation hit me hard. Living with my mom, I witnessed her pain. Fortunately, my paternal grandfather, Willie, stepped in. Every Sunday, he arranged for all of us to have dinner at a high-end Chinese restaurant for family time.

As a preteen, I played stickball, basketball and softball. When I turned 16, Willie took me to the racetrack at Saratoga Springs, N.Y. He knew everyone and taught me the value of a big personality.

High school was tough. The workload increased but my disability didn't improve. I flourished in sports but I didn't do homework and failed every subject. All my teachers said, "Bobby's a smart kid, but he needs to apply himself."

My parents worried, and my grandmother thought I was doing drugs. They couldn't figure out why I was screwing up. In my junior



HOUSE CALL | BOBBY FLAY

High School Was a Bust. The Kitchen Saved Him.

The host of ‘The Line’ recalls dropping out junior year, his job as a busser and the chef who inspired him most



Bobby Flay in New York in April, top, and with his parents in the mid-1960s, above.

year, I dropped out. After I quit, my father called and said a busser at Joe Allen needed a replacement for two weeks.

I filled in. On my last night, the chef asked if I wanted a kitchen job. I said, "Sure." I began by making salads and dressings, and learned how to use a chef's knife. My passion kicked in. After 18 months, Joe suggested I attend Manhattan's French Culinary Institute, which was due to open.

Tuition in 1984 was \$6,500, and I planned to work at the restaurant to pay for it. Joe handed me a check for the full amount. "You

don't owe me anything," he said. "I just want to do this."

During the program, I learned all the basics. I also met Julia Child. She taught me never to take for granted the impact great food has on people. When I finished, I returned to Joe Allen's restaurant, but within months, Joe encouraged me to leave, saying, "You're not going to learn any more here." I began as a sous-chef at Manhattan's Brighton Grill, but a week later was promoted when the chef left. I was in over my head. One night, Jonathan Waxman, one of the first chefs to

BOBBY'S FRYER

Favorite at-home kitchen?
The one in the Hamptons. On the other side of my sizable island are three French cafe tables for guests.

Recent kitchen splurge?
A professional fryer.

Burger tip? Season with salt and black pepper, cook a touch past medium-rare and add a relish of diced green chili and pickles.

bring California and Southwestern cuisine to New York, introduced himself. A few months later, I asked him for a job. He hired me as a chef at Bud's. Over the next 2½ years, I worked there and at his Jams and Hulot's restaurants.

By then I had fallen in love with Southwestern cuisine. Mutual friends made some introductions, and I went to Dallas and Houston for weeks at a time. I cooked with chefs Robert Del Grande and Stephan Pyles.

I returned to New York in 1988 and worked at Miracle Grill before opening my first restaurant, Mesa Grill, in 1991, at the age of 26.

Today, my life partner, chef Brooke Williamson, and I have homes in New York and the Hamptons. In Manhattan, we live in Tribeca. I love that we're surrounded by 100-year-old buildings that originally stored coffee, tea, sugar and other food staples.

I built our Hamptons house about 15 years ago. The kitchen is spacious. The space relaxes me and allows me to cook for family and friends.

I still have the chef's knife I used at FCI. When I prepare food with it, the feel reminds me that I'm still learning every day.

—As told to Marc Myers

Bobby Flay, 61, is an Emmy-winning celebrity chef, cookbook author and restaurateur. He stars in the Food Network's "Bobby's Triple Threat" and the new series "Bobby Flay's The Line," due Tuesday.

FROM TOP: FOOD NETWORK; BOBBY FLAY

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[SCAN TO GIVE]

MANSION

By Sarah Paynter

In August 2014, cannon fire rang out across Richard van Stolk's family farm in Chestertown, Md., setting off car alarms and startling the neighbors. They would have to put up with the noise: History buffs were practicing for the re-enactment of the Battle of Caulk's Field, says local historian Kevin Hemstock, who helped organize the 200-year anniversary event.

For two centuries, bullets, buttons, buckles, thimbles and coins lay buried in Maryland's best-preserved battlefield from the War of 1812, according to a report from the National Park Service.

Archaeologists reconstructed the battle using the locations of 721 artifacts, the report says. After years of preparation, some 5,000 spectators watched men in wool uniforms act out the battle.

The history

According to the 1998 book "Historic Houses of Kent County," farmer William Moore built a brick house on the property in 1743. His grandson, farmer Isaac Caulk, inherited it in 1812. Two years later, the farm became a battlefield.



American militia forces set up camp on the farm. On Aug. 31, 1814, shortly after the British burned Washington, D.C., they confronted enemy troops during the Battle of Caulk's Field. Fourteen British troops were killed—including Capt. Peter Parker of the Royal Navy—and 27 others were wounded. The resulting British retreat boosted American morale before their pivotal comeback at the Battle of Baltimore in mid-September, according to the National Park Service.

Soldiers moved past Caulk's house during the battle, but it was



left unscathed. He raised cows, horses and pigs there until he died in the 1830s, says Hemstock. The house traded hands a number of times during the next century, property records show, until another war shaped its history.

Richard's grandfather, Dutch grain merchant Cornelis van Stolk, was traveling abroad when Nazi Germany invaded the Netherlands in May 1940, says Richard, 72. Cornelis and his wife re-



Asking price: \$38.2 million

HISTORIC HOMES

A Maryland Farm That Became A War of 1812 Battlefield

The 1,050-acre property helped reverse U.S. fortunes after the British burned Washington, D.C.

mained in the U.S., purchasing the Maryland farm to learn more about American farming.

That same year, Cornelis accepted a royal commission from the Netherlands to stockpile food in preparation for liberation. When Nazi occupation ended in 1945, ships carrying tens of thousands of tons of provisions delivered the food he'd accumulated, according to the Holland Museum Volunteer Program. Before he died in 1978, he passed the farm on to his three sons. Today, their 14 children share ownership of the corn and soybean-producing farm.

Modern day

The main house is now used as a guesthouse for visiting family, says Richard, who manages the farm and lives in another house on the property. Richard restored the house to more closely resemble its earlier appearance.

He also added flags to a stone memorial near where British sol-

diers were believed to have been buried. Richard allowed the U.K. government to contribute an additional stone marker and installed one for the U.S. himself, he says.

Historic details

The house has a few quirks. Richard, who is 6-foot-5, has to duck in some rooms, and some of the staircases are steep and windy. The doorways aren't standard size, so he's had to commission custom ones when they needed replacing, he says.

The best part of owning a historic home

"It's just unique, and it's a very welcoming spot," Richard says.

The hardest part of owning a historic home

"The upkeep always becomes more than you think it will be."

Reason for selling?

Managing a property with 14 co-owners around the world is "too confusing and complicated to continue," Richard says.

Market snapshot

The family is pursuing a conservation easement to protect the house and battlefield. While easements typically diminish land



Clockwise from top: The home today; the living room fireplace, after a restoration returned it to its former size; original wood paneling in a bedroom; re-enactment of the 1814 battle; and the house in the 1910s.



value, "no one is buying this for a housing development," says listing agent Francis Joe Hickman of Cross Street Realtors. The buyer will likely be someone looking to farm and hunt, he says.

Hickman says he expects the property to sell for a premium due to its historic ties. Homes in Kent County sold for about

\$389,000 in the second quarter, up 8.9% from the same time last year, according to Redfin.

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PRIVATE PROPERTIES

Condo Sale Is a Provincetown Record

“The numbers have gone crazy,” says Victor DePoalo, a Provincetown, Mass., restaurateur and real-estate developer. He is referring to his \$5 million sale of a condo that he built for himself in 2019 and has lived in until now. It’s the highest price ever paid for a condo in this town at the tip of Cape Cod, according to listing agent Thomas Andrews of Gibson Sotheby’s International Realty.

The 2,725-square-foot unit is one of five that DePoalo built on the Bradford Street Extension, which parallels the west end of Commercial Street, the town’s main drag. He sold one of the units for \$1.8 million when he finished it in 2019. It resold in August for \$3.9 million, which was a record condo price in Provincetown until Tuesday. The median sales price for condos in Provincetown is just under \$1 million, according to Redfin. (The

median price for single family homes is more than twice that.)

DePoalo, 64, shared the three-bedroom, five-bathroom condo with his husband and their 12-year-old son. Rare for Provincetown, it has a large, secluded backyard with a saltwater gunite pool. “I’m giving up something I may never be able to get back,” he says.

The five condos are decidedly modern, which might have been a problem on Commercial Street but not on the Bradford Street Extension, which is outside the city’s historic district.

DePoalo, a year-round Provincetown resident whose son attends school there, sold the condo to raise money for a much larger project, a 28,000-square-foot mixed-use building at 185 Commercial St. DePoalo said he is investing \$20 million in the three-story building, which will replace Bubala’s By the Bay, a popular



restaurant set back from the street behind an extensive outdoor seating area. DePoalo’s new building will contain a 100-seat restaurant, nine hotel rooms and 10 condos (two of them designated affordable).

One that won’t be designated affordable is the 3,000-square-foot unit being designed for DePoalo and his family. It will have views of Provincetown Harbor and open water beyond. “I’ve always dreamt of living on the ocean,”

said DePoalo, who grew up in Schenectady, NY.

The seller of Bubala’s is John “Jingles” Yingling, who bought the property in 1994 for \$550,000. Yingling also owns Spiritus, the pizza place up the street that attracts a crowd after the Provincetown bars—mostly gay bars—close. They agreed on a price, Yingling says, of “just under \$7 million,” with a closing scheduled for Oct. 9.

In Provincetown, where even tiny changes to historic buildings

can spark outsize controversies, DePoalo’s project has met only scattered opposition. He won the approval of the city’s Historic District Commission after making several changes to the building’s exterior. John Dowd, who heads the commission, said DePoalo “had no problem tailoring his designs to fit the guidelines of the district.”

—Fred A. Bernstein

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